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INSIDE



'Death toll climbs to 44 in Saudi air strikes on Yemen'

SANAA
The death toll from Saudi strikes on Yemen's Sanaa province climbed to 44, including more than 20 children, the Houthis said on Monday. » PAGE 14



Students warned on 'joining fake medical colleges'

NEW DELHI
The National Medical Commission has cautioned students and parents against enrolling in medical colleges without verifying their statutory recognition and regulatory approvals. » PAGE 6

Rahul dares Modi to debate after remark by PM

NEW DELHI
A day after PM Narendra Modi cautioned Central Reserve Police Force personnel to be alert about "*dimagi* (intellectual) Naxals", Rahul Gandhi on Monday dared the PM to debate him on who was an anti-national. » PAGE 5

Manipur census to be suspended until 2027: HC

GUWAHATI
The Manipur High Court has said that the Census in the State will remain suspended until at least April 30, 2027, while the Centre considers to delay or change the dates for the exercise. » PAGE 4

Russell Brand facing 10 years in jail for rape

LONDON
British comedian and Hollywood star Russell Brand was sentenced to ten and a half years in prison for rape and sexual assault by the Southwark Crown Court in London on Monday. » PAGE 12

Kharge's remarks on Deepavali 'an insult to Hindus'

NEW DELHI
The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday accused Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge of insulting Hindus by describing Deepavali as "Id of happiness", alleging the party of appeasement. » Page 9

Hasina seeks new passport; Dhaka wants her extradition as 'terrorist'

London-based law firm seeks new documents for leader; Acting Foreign Minister of Bangladesh says Hasina is a 'terrorist' and adds India should hand her over under the extradition treaty; Minister notes that Hasina has been sentenced to death

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

Hours after a legal team representing deposed Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina sought a new passport for her, the Government of Bangladesh asserted on Monday that Ms. Hasina can return to Bangladesh through an "acceptable prisoner exchange" programme under the India-Bangladesh extradition treaty.

A source in Dhaka told *The Hindu* that Ms. Hasina has requested the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, through a London-based legal firm, for a new passport and a National Identity Card.

The official said the Ministry is verifying the letter and will take a decision after internal consultations.

Document push

Bangladeshi officials were verifying a request for a fresh passport and a National Identity Card for the former PM

Sheikh Hasina had announced in August this year that she may return to her country in December despite facing serious legal challenges



Hasina's passport was revoked after she escaped to India in August 2024 after an uprising that toppled her government

A passport will be needed in case India has to consider Hasina's extradition to Bangladesh

"Bangladesh will seek the return of Sheikh Hasina through an acceptable prisoner exchange process

HUMAYUN KABIR, Acting Foreign Minister

Ms. Hasina's passport was revoked after she escaped to India in August 2024 after an uprising toppled her government.

She had announced in a press conference in August this year that she may return to her country in December despite facing serious legal challenges.

Speaking to the media in Dhaka, the country's Acting Foreign Minister Humayun Kabir described Ms. Hasina as a "terrorist" who had fled to India after committing crimes.

"Bangladesh will not issue a passport to any terrorist; there is no provision for such an action. Bangladesh will seek the return of Sheikh Hasina through an acceptable prisoner exchange process," Mr. Kabir said, adding that India should hand over Ms. Hasina under the extradition treaty. The External Affairs Ministry is yet to respond to Mr. Kabir's remarks, but a source familiar with the Indian stance on the matter told *The Hindu* that the Bangladeshi position of not issuing a passport to Ms. Hasina will further complicate the matter, as a passport will be needed if India were to consider her extradition. The Acting Foreign Minister of Bangladesh added that Ms. Hasina and several of her colleagues from her Awami League party are responsible for violent crimes and financial fraud, and need to be brought to justice.

The Bangladeshi official, who spoke to *The Hindu*, said over the phone, "We have received an email from Matrix Chambers, a law firm in London, seeking a new passport for Sheikh Hasina. We are currently examining the contents of the letter and will take an appropriate step after internal consultation."

Bangladesh High Commission press secretary Md. Saidur Rahman said the Bangladesh authorities are "not sure if the request is genuine".

India had earlier acknowledged receiving Bangladesh's extradition requests for Ms. Hasina but has not announced any decision on handing her over.



Xi Jinping and Donald Trump will meet for the third time this year during the APEC meet in China next week. FILE PHOTO

Trilateral meet with Putin, Xi likely next week, says Trump

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

U.S. President Donald Trump has said he will likely meet Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin in a rare trilateral leaders' meeting on the sidelines of the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) gathering in Shenzhen next week.

Beijing said on Monday it was "in communication with relevant parties" over the meeting, not ruling out the possibility as leaders gather for the APEC summit in the southern Chinese city on November 18 and 19.

Mr. Trump on Sunday indicated to presspersons that a deal on the Russia-Ukraine war, the Iran issue, and nuclear arms control would be on the agenda. "One of the meetings will be with President Putin and President Xi, and that will be interesting. We are talking a lot of things, including denuclearisation... We are trying to end the war in Iran," Mr. Trump was quoted as saying.

Mr. Trump and Mr. Xi will meet bilaterally next week for the third time this year, following the U.S. President's visit to Beijing in May and the Chinese President travelling to Washington in September. They will meet once again at the end of the year at the G20 in Miami, marking an unusual four meetings in a year. Asked about his remarks, China's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun on Monday did not rule out the prospect of a meeting, saying that China was in communication with relevant parties regarding the meeting between the Chinese, Russian and U.S. Presidents.

Chinese analysts have sought to play down the significance of a possible trilateral summit, just as they also played down Mr. Trump's remarks in Beijing earlier this year of a "G2". Russia was "most enthusiastic" among the three, Su Liuqiang, a scholar at the Centre for American Studies at the Shanghai Institutes for International Studies, said in an interview with state media.

"On the one hand, there is substantial political resistance in the U.S. Anti-Russia sentiment remains strong in both the U.S. and among its European allies, with opposition to negotiating with Moscow while bypassing Ukraine and Europe. On the other hand, the three countries have differing priorities. Russia's core concern is negotiations on a ceasefire in Ukraine, the U.S. is interested in the Russia-Ukraine conflict and non-proliferation, China supports peace talks but must also balance its relations with the U.S., Russia, Europe and Ukraine. In this context, a low-profile trilateral meeting is the more realistic option," he said.

Pollution unlimited



People commute in thick smog near Rashtrapati Bhavan on Monday morning. After Delhiites burst firecrackers well past the 10 p.m. deadline on Deepavali, PM2.5 levels in parts of the city shot up well past the the WHO limit. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP (REPORT: PAGE 6)

Method used to test E20 'follows lab procedure'

Rashmi Patil
BENGALURU

Karnataka Minister for Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs Rizwan Arshad on Monday said that he stood by the test reports on ethanol blending in petrol that were released on Friday. The test results had showed ethanol-blending levels of more than 20% in the E20 petrol. Mr. Arshad said, "We stand by our test reports as the tests were done as per the prescribed procedure in laboratories recognised by the National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories."

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 3

Nvidia investigates CEO Huang over affair with 'Chinese spy'

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

AI chip behemoth Nvidia was plunged into turmoil on Monday after its CEO Jensen Huang acknowledged having an affair, with reports saying U.S. officials believe the woman was spying for China.

Beijing denied the claim but Nvidia's board opened an inquiry into the reports that Mr. Huang was "the target of a foreign intelligence effort."

Late last month, *The New York Times* reported that U.S. intelligence officials determined that Alice Huang, a Chinese executive linked to a Singapore-based data centre company, Megaspeed, had been funnelling information to Beijing.

The executive, also known as Huang Le, developed a close relationship with the Nvidia chief, the *Times* said.

Nvidia's board announced on Sunday that it had opened a probe "in light of recent reporting that company's chief executive and co-founder has been the target of a foreign intelligence effort."

"While the board has no reason to believe that either national security or Nvidia secrets were compromised, the board's inquiry will examine all available information," the board said in a statement said.

Key figure

Mr. Huang is a huge figure in the AI revolution and a close informal adviser to U.S. President Donald Trump, who has repeatedly spoken out against regulating the industry so as not to let China gain the upper hand in the AI race.



Facing controversy: Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang with Alice Huang, a Chinese executive, in Taipei, Taiwan, in this 2024 photo. REUTERS

"I was unfaithful to my wife," Mr. Huang said in a message to company employees. "My actions hurt her and our children. There is no excuse for what I did. I am deeply sorry."

AI insights

The *Times* said Ms. Alice Huang's relationship with the Nvidia chief could have given her insights into Mr. Trump's thinking around AI.

Mr. Trump was briefed on the findings about Mr. Huang's relationship roughly a year ago and chose not to act on the information, the *Times* said.

The U.S. President said on said Sunday that he did not regret not acting on this intelligence. "No, I don't think so. I think – you know, he's an honorable guy. I think he probably has an excuse for it. You have to hear it," he said.

China rejected the spying allegations, with Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun telling a regular briefing on Monday that "the narrative of a so-called Chinese spy is entirely baseless vilification and smearing."

The issue of AI is likely to arise during Mr. Trump's planned talks with President Xi Jinping later this month at a summit in China.

China is in a race for tech dominance against the United States, which restricts the export to China of the most cutting-edge silicon chips.

Nvidia shares dropped roughly 5% in pre-market trading early Monday.

Technology analyst Dan Ives, with the investment bank Yorkville Ives, said the inquiry was "a black eye moment" for Mr. Huang.

He predicted it would at the very least spark multiple congressional inquiries and "create an overhang on the stock for a myriad of reasons."

THE CHIEF'S BLUNDER » PAGE 15

Four-year-old child 'killed to harvest his organs'

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

A 27-year-old man was arrested in Chhattisgarh's Jashpur for allegedly killing a four-year-old boy, a relative of his, with the intention of selling the boy's organs, the police said on Monday.

According to the police, the man, an agricultural labourer, got the idea after watching a video that purportedly suggested organ sale as a way to make money quickly. The accused lives in Sanna village.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 4

INBRIEF



After 137 fire incidents, aerial crackers banned in Mumbai

Mumbai has banned the use of rockets and other aerial firecrackers across the city till November 25 following a surge in fire incidents during Deepavali celebrations. The decision comes after 137 firecracker-related fires were reported on November 8 alone, leaving two women injured. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation, in a statement on Monday said the Urban Disaster Management Authority, Greater Mumbai, had issued prohibitory orders under the Disaster Management Act, 2005 as a precautionary measure to prevent further fire incidents.

ED attaches properties in 'misuse' of PM scheme case

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Monday attached immovable properties worth ₹10.63 crore under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act in a case of alleged misuse of the Prime Minister Employment Generation Programme (PMEGP). An ED spokesman said there was misappropriation of the scheme's loans in criminal conspiracy with the PMEGP borrowers, bank officials of Sumbal branch and Gamud Gadkhud branch of J&K Bank and other unknown persons. The ED said the suspected proceeds were diverted through bank accounts in multiple transactions and part of it was utilised for construction and renovation of assets.

Goa sexual assault: Minister blames 'outsiders' for crime; Oppn. seeks fast-track trial

3-year-old girl's condition now stable, CCTV footage being scanned to identify the accused: police; ahead of 2027 poll, Congress cites NCRB data to flag high rate of crimes against children in State

Press Trust of India
PANAJI

The alleged sexual assault of a three-year-old girl by an unidentified man in North Goa sparked a political row in the poll-bound State on Monday, with Tribal Welfare Minister Ramesh Tawadkar claiming that "90% of such crimes in the poll-bound State are committed by outsiders" while the Opposition demanded a time-bound investigation and trial by a fast-track court.

The police said the girl was sexually assaulted in a dilapidated building, leaving her in a critical condition. She was found crying on Sunday evening outside the building in Mapusa, 9 km from Panaji, police said. A passerby noticed the child and rushed to help her, following which locals alerted the police.

The survivor was rushed to the Mapusa District Hospital and later shifted to the Goa Medical College and Hospital in Panaji, the police said. The girl's family sells balloons and she had accompanied them to the Mapusa market for Deepavali, a police officer said. Superintendent of Police (North) Rahul Gupta, who rushed to the spot late Sunday evening, said efforts are under way to trace and arrest the culprit. The girl's condition is now stable, he said.



Goa Tribal Welfare Minister Ramesh Tawadkar.



Leader of the Opposition in the Goa Assembly Yuri Alemao.

The Mapusa police have registered a case and are examining CCTV footage from the area to identify the accused, officials said.

Reacting to the incident, Goa Tribal Welfare Minister Ramesh Tawadkar claimed "90%" of such crimes in the tourist State, where the Assembly poll is due next year, are committed by "outsiders". He termed the incident "unfortunate" and the perpetrator a person with a "demonic mentality".

He also called for stricter police enforcement to prevent such crimes. He, however, maintained people could not be stopped from coming to Goa to earn their livelihood.

'No delay, no leniency'

The Opposition Congress demanded a time-bound investigation into the crime and trial by a fast-track court. Leader of the Opposition Yuri Alemao demanded that the perpetrator be arrested.

"No delay, no leniency," he said in a statement, adding that the Opposition would pursue the case until justice is delivered.

Raising concerns over crimes against women and children in Goa, Mr. Alemao cited National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data to claim the State recorded 13 rape and child sexual abuse cases per lakh population in 2024, the highest among all States and more than three times the national average.

"Goa, once known for safe streets, now carries this shameful distinction. Citizens feel they are on their own. The government must answer for this failure," he said.

He also demanded the establishment of more fast-track courts under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, stronger policing and a time-bound action plan to protect minors.

Shah sets 2028 deadline to rid Gujarat of drugs

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday asserted that governments alone cannot eradicate narcotics without active public support, and urged citizens to report drug abuse to authorities via dedicated helplines.

Addressing a gathering here after launching development projects worth ₹1,024 crore, Mr. Shah said while the deadline to make India drug-free is December 31, 2029, Gujarat needs to achieve the status by December 31, 2028.

"Drug abuse hollows out our youth and the future generations. It undermines our country's future by impairing the minds, bodies, cognitive abilities, and sensory faculties of our young people. Moreover, money generated from the drug trade is used to fuel terrorism within the country," the Union Home Minister said, urging citizens to report any instances of drug sales to the authorities.

He noted that while the government has succeeded in making the country free from Naxalism, it cannot afford to rest.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah in his Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency, in Ahmedabad on Monday. ANI

"Our goal is to build a drug-free India by December 31, 2029. Since Prime Minister Narendra Modi and I hail from Gujarat, we need not wait until 2029. It is our responsibility to ensure that Gujarat becomes drug-free well before December 31, 2028," he said.

Mr. Shah stressed that creating a drug-free nation is a collective societal responsibility. He said every teacher must remain vigilant and report changes in a student's behaviour – such as bloodshot eyes, sleeping in class, or lack of focus – and ensure that the student is tested. Similarly, guardians must keep a close watch on adolescent children, he said.

Mamata group MLA arrested on charges of rape, extortion

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Mamata All India Trinamool Congress MLA Pareshram Das was arrested on Monday from Kolkata's Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose International Airport. According to the police, there are several charges against the Canning Paschim MLA, including extortion and rape.

According to police sources, the Special Operations Group of Baruipur district police began tracking the MLA after receiving information that he was heading to the airport. The team contacted the Bidhannagar Police Commissionerate, following which the MLA was arrested.

Mamata AITC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh alleged that when the MLA pledged his allegiance to party chairperson Mamata Banerjee, he was arrested.

BJP leader returns bulletproof car to Soren govt. after 'repeated breakdowns'

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Jharkhand Leader of the Opposition Babulal Marandi on Monday returned his bulletproof car to the Hemant Soren government claiming the vehicle was repeatedly breaking down during tours.

In a letter addressed to the Chief Minister, Mr. Marandi informed his decision by writing a letter to him asserting that a dilapidated bulletproof SUV allocated to him is 13 years old. He also mentioned that the three cars used by the security personnel in his convoy are equally in dilapidated condition, having covered over four lakh kilometres.

"I am formally returning the bulletproof vehicle provided by the State government for my security. Please instruct the Home Department to duly accept this vehicle and provide an acknowledgment to my office," the senior BJP leader wrote. He gave seven days for Mr. Soren to respond to him over the issue.



Babulal Marandi

Mr. Marandi further said he was compelled to write to the Chief Minister directly despite having informed senior officials of the CM's house that his vehicle repeatedly breaks down midjourney. He asked Mr. Soren whether he would like to undertake his next tour in such a vehicle.

Mr. Marandi reminded the Chief Minister that on March 21, 2026, he had written him a letter to draw his attention to this matter.

"Home Department had procured 17 bulletproof vehicles in December 2024. Of these, three were allocated for your use and two for the Raj Bhavan, while the remaining 12 were kept in the headquarters' reserve for the movement of VIPs. In that letter, I pointed out that former Chief Ministers are forced to undertake tours with vehicles that are 10-12 years old, and that the vehicle allocated to me also breaks down frequently," Mr. Marandi said.

Continuous reminders

He questioned the government that almost eight months having passed since his last letter, what instructions have been given by the Chief Minister over his continuous reminders. Mr. Marandi also mentioned that the Director General of Police (DGP) has also been informed of this situation on several occasions. The Leader of Opposition claimed that on many occasions, he has come to know that changing the vehicle is being "blocked from above". He sought answers onwhat decision has been taken regarding replacements for vehicles that have repeatedly broken down.

Reacting to the surrendering of the bulletproof car, ruling alliance partner Jharkhand Congress spokesperson Sonal Shanti said the State government will look into his concern but indicated that the blending of ethanol in petrol could be a possible reason for the vehicle's breakdown.

"Our leader Rahul Gandhi had pointed out that in India, petrol is not just being blended with up to 20% ethanol, the mixing levels are reaching as high as 32% to 40%. It is possible that Babulal Marandi's vehicle broke down due to this over-blending of ethanol," Mr. Shanti asserted.

7-member gang beats policeman to death in T.N. on Deepavali day

S. Sundar
THENI

The officer had scolded youth bursting firecrackers in the middle of the road and making reels

A Special Sub-Inspector of Police (SSI) was beaten to death by a gang of youth when he questioned them for disrupting traffic at Samadharmapuram in Tamil Nadu's Theni Allinagaram on Deepavali day.

According to the police, SSI Senthilkumar, 55, attached to the office of the Theni Deputy Superintendent of Police, was returning home after duty when he noticed the seven-member gang bursting firecrackers in the middle of the road and making reels on Sunday night.

The SSI, who was wearing civilian clothes, scolded the youth and asked them to burst the firecrackers on the roadside.

As the youth, reportedly in an inebriated state, did not heed his advice, Senthilkumar began recording their activities on his mobile phone. Angered by this, the youth beat him up, rendering him unconscious.

He was rushed to a private hospital in a police patrol vehicle. As his health deteriorated, he was taken to the Theni Government Medical College hospital, where he was declared 'brought dead'.

The Theni police had arrested six out of the seven accused, a police officer said.

A statement from the Theni district police said the SSI had attempted to apprehend one of the youth bursting firecrackers on the road. Another youth had elbowed Senthilkumar, causing him to lose balance and fall.

An earlier police statement had said the SSI had a heart-related ailment.

Meanwhile, Senthilkumar's mortal remains were cremated in Theni after a post-mortem. He was accorded a gun-salute.

Govt. criticised

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami criticised Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay over a number of murders reported across the State on Deepavali day.

AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran also came down heavily on the TVK-led government for "paying greater importance to entertainment" and participation in social events than attending to issues of governance.

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Tamilisai Soundararajan said it was painful to see such incidents occurring on the day the State was celebrating Deepavali.

Return of patriarch: Farooq steps in as NC old guard reasserts influence to check Omar

NEWS ANALYSIS

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The stand-off between the 17 MLAs of the ruling National Conference and Kashmir's first political family, the Abdullahs, has had a rare consequence. It has brought the 89-year-old party patriarch, Farooq Abdullah, back into the saddle to steer the party and shape how the government functions, after he had nearly faded from affairs run entirely by Chief Minister Omar Abdullah.

The stalemate began on October 27 with the CM's Cabinet reshuffle, after which at least three senior party leaders publicly expressed resentment over not being inducted. Later that day, the disgruntled legislators held a meeting,



Farooq Abdullah is back in the saddle after nearly withdrawing from NC, govt. affairs managed by his son CM Omar Abdullah. FILE PHOTO

conspicuously in the absence of the Abdullahs, and subsequently submitted a charter of demands to the party leadership, which included intensifying the struggle for the restoration of Statehood and special status, removing Nasir Aslam Wani as the CM's Adviser and reassigning the Roads and Buildings portfolio, currently held by Deputy CM Surinder Choudhary.

In seven decades of the NC, the parallel party meeting was seen as a rare implosion and a visible crack that the Opposition parties could exploit to tilt the balance of numbers against the Omar Abdullah government.

The NC has 42 legislators in the 90-member Assembly and the support of eight other MLAs.

The stand-off appears to have ended following a two-hour meeting on November 6 between the dissenting legislators and the party brass ahead of Friday prayers, which saw Mr. Farooq taking the lead role.

"Our struggle for Statehood, Articles 370 and 35A will continue," he later told mediapersons in Srinagar.

'Struggle has begun'

On Monday, NC's newly inducted Minister Mir Saifullah underlined that sentiment, saying the "struggle had started".

"Whatever has been snatched will be taken back. It was the NC who got pre-1953 status, Article 370 and separate flag for J&K. The struggle for their return has begun. We all start from zero but will reach 100 one day," he said at a rally in north Kashmir's Kupwara.

Ever since Mr. Omar took over as the CM for the first time in 2009, there has been an apparent waning of the influence of the old guard in decision-making in the party as well as the government.

After Mr. Omar, who has served as the NC president twice while his father has headed the party four times, came to power as the CM in 2024, the old guard remained out of Cabinet as well as the government.

His detractors view Mr. Omar's confidants – Mr. Wani; Shammi Oberoi, the first-ever Sikh to be sent to the Rajya Sabha from the Valley; and Tanvir Sadiq, an MLA and party spokesperson – as his only eyes and ears.

Behind the curtain, senior leaders have often spoken about Mr. Omar becoming inaccessible.

These rumblings took a concrete shape following the public expression of dissent last month. The criticism by disgruntled legislators was unequivocal and the CM found himself in the crosshairs.

CM's authority

The demands such as Mr. Wani's removal as the CM's Adviser was seen as an indirect way of challenging Mr. Omar's authority. Mr. Farooq's statement, following his meeting with the disgruntled MLAs last week, about their issues being "genuine" is being viewed as an indictment of his son.

Mr. Omar's bid to centralise decisions, within the party and in the government, is facing an open challenge, with the old guard and party loyalists such as Hilal Akbar Lone and Bashir Veeri throwing their weight behind it.

The 10-point charter underlined the need for a consultative advisory group of legislators and the constitution of a high-powered disciplinary committee, which is seen as an attempt to cut down the consolidation of power by Mr. Omar and place the party, instead of the Abdullahs, at its centre.

The demand to fight for J&K's special status is a pushback to ensure the party's relevance as an ideological force in the political landscape of J&K at a time when it is facing criticism from several quarters on the issues of Statehood and dilution of Article 370.

The issues featured prominently in the public speech that Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi made in the Valley on November 3 while announcing his resignation from the party and his Lok Sabha seat. He accused the NC of betraying the public's expectations "for a vain and vague promise of so-called restoration of Statehood".

'Injustice to Valley'

Addressing supporters in Kralpora of the Trehgam constituency on Monday, Mr. Saifullah said Kashmir was on August 5, 2019 reduced to a Union Territory in a "brazen" manner.

"The downgrading and division of J&K on August 5, 2019 was *zulm* (injustice) that no part of the world has seen. It was a stab to our chest. Our flag and constitution were taken away. All the parties should join hands to restore the flag of J&K," said the Minister. He added, "Only the NC can do it."

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Keralam govt. orders fuel inspections to check ethanol levels

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Food and Civil Supplies Minister announced random inspections at outlets in four districts

After sample testing in Karnataka revealed that petrol sold by several major oil companies in the State contained ethanol far above the prescribed 20% level, the Keralam government also began inspections in fuel outlets to check ethanol levels.

Food and Civil Supplies Minister Anoop Jacob on Monday announced random inspections at fuel outlets in four districts – Thiruvananthapuram, Ernakulam, Kozhikode and Kannur.

Thiruvananthapuram District Supply Officer Smitha S.R. told *The Hindu* that samples were collected from two pumps in the district, which would be sent to a lab accredited by the National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories for analysis.

The sampling operation in Kannur was conducted by a team led by District Supply Officer M. Sunil Kumar, BPCL Area Manager S. Sharanjit, and dealer representative S. Amarish. In Kochi too, officials collected samples as part of the inspection. Two of the samples were sent to the Regional Chemical Laboratory at Kakkanad.

Mr. Jacob said the sample analysis would be completed in a timebound manner, with results expected within 10 days.

Karnataka Minister defends method of testing E20 petrol

Rizwan Arshad slams oil firms for claiming the tests were not done as per procedure; he adds that it was the OMC laboratories' failure to provide ethanol percentage in results that raised suspicion

Rashmi Patil
BENGALURU

Karnataka Minister for Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs Rizwan Arshad on Monday said that he stood by the test reports on ethanol blending in petrol that were released on Friday. The test results had showed ethanol-blending levels of more than 20% in the E20 petrol.

Addressing presspersons on Monday, Mr. Arshad said, "We stand by our test reports as the tests were done as per the prescribed procedure in laboratories recognised by the National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories (NABL), which is a constituent board of the Quality Council of India (QCI)."


Congress workers staging a protest in Bengaluru on Monday over claims of excess ethanol blending in petrol. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

He added, "The OMCs' release is more about technicalities, but they have failed to answer how much ethanol is in the petrol at our pumps."

He slammed the oil companies for stating that the samples were not tested as per the prescribed procedure and that the laboratories used for testing were not those specified under the order.

"The initial 63 samples were first given to the OMCs' own laboratories at IOCL, BPCL and HPCL for testing. Not one of their test reports stated the ethanol percentage. It was the OMC laboratories' failure to provide the required result that raised suspicion. On no grounds can the State's tests be discredited for this," he said.

Responding to the statement that the problem exists only in samples collected from particular petrol pumps, he said, "The OMCs' own statement says ethanol blending is 'a controlled and automated process' carried out at their refineries and depots. A dealer only sells what the tanker delivers and has no role in the blend. The excess ethanol found is a failure at the source, and the responsibility lies with the OMCs alone."

T.N. may be heading for a water crisis, unless monsoon comes to its rescue

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu may be in for a spell of water crisis and lower rice production this time if the current Northeast monsoon does not come to its rescue.

As of now, the aggregate storage in the major 15 irrigation reservoirs is about 35% of the combined capacity of the reservoirs. In the corresponding period last year, it was around 88%. The State's largest dam, Mettur, has about 24.7 thousand million cubic feet (tmcft) but this is hardly enough for the authorities to maintain sustained release of one tmcft a day to farmers, beyond a week, in the Cauvery delta.

The rainfall during the Northeast monsoon has been moderate, as the State received around 248 mm of rainfall during October 1 to November 8 against the anticipated 236 mm. It should get at least 260 mm more to be considered comfortable, the most of which should materialise in November. Ordinarily, December yields only about 20% of the total rainfall of the monsoon.

In fact, the existing pattern of rainfall registered by the State so far during the season appears to be more in tune with the forecast made by the Tamil Nadu Agricultural University (TNAU), which, in late September, predicted that the State would get 438 mm during the entire monsoon against the normal 434 mm, a deviation of one per cent.

The Meteorological department, in its outlook at the beginning of October for the season, referred to the southern peninsular region of the country in general and stated that the expected rainfall "is most likely to be normal (88%-112%) of the Long Period Average."

The TNAU, which was more specific in its forecast than the Meteorological Department, had anticipated only a normal rainfall for the core delta districts. Despite the water availability at Mettur not being comfortable and the expectation of a subdued rainfall, farmers have gone in for raising paddy during the *samba-thaladi* cultivation season to the tune of around 3.62 lakh hectares. Of this, nearly 50% falls under "direct sown" category of cultivation, which means that seeds are directly sown instead of transplantation. This method is followed during times of water shortage.

As part of its efforts for protecting the crop in the delta, the State government, at meetings of the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee and the Cauvery Water Management Authority on Friday last, demanded that Karnataka release around 20.7 tmcft, including the backlog of about 16.9 tmcft.

NDA wins 499 Zilla Parishad seats; YSRCP confined to 76

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The NDA partners in Andhra Pradesh – the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), the Jana Sena Party (JSP) and the BJP – sealed the fate of YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) in the elections to 582 Zilla Parishad Territorial Constituencies by winning 499 seats.

While the TDP won 406 seats, the Jana Sena and the BJP won 73 and 20 seats respectively. The YSRCP was confined to 76 seats.

Mandal Parishad polls

In the elections to 7,768 Mandal Parishad Territorial Constituencies, the TDP secured a total of 4,806. The Jana Sena and the BJP secured 938 and 117 seats respectively.

The YSRCP won 1,711 seats, the CPI (M) emerged victorious in 15 seats while the Congress and the Bhajuan Samaj Party won nine and three seats respectively.

Meanwhile, the State Election Commission announced elections to Gram Panchayats in three phases. The elections will be held on November 26, 29 and December 2, for which the Commission will issue notifications on November 13, 16 and 19.

Keralam may defer purchase of electricity via GNA Energy

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam government is likely to put on hold a decision for short-term procurement of electricity via the over-the-counter (OTC) platform GNA Energy.

The move, apparently, is based on a conclusion by the Power Department that Keralam is not facing power shortage at the moment and there is no urgency for additional power purchases.

The latest development comes amid a raging controversy over Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's decision to opt for supplies via GNA Energy for the November 2026-March 2027 period over an offer from Himachal Pradesh.

The Opposition LDF had questioned the logic behind Mr. Satheesan's decision from the perspectives of cost, peak-hour requirements and transparency. The previous Kerala State Electricity Board CMD M.G. Rajamanickam had reportedly written to the government seeking an urgent decision on the power purchase proposals.

Additional Chief Secretary (Power) Puneet Kumar said the department will try to purchase power required at the best price available, he said.

INBRIEF



A.P. tightens fireworks safety rules after explosions at units

The Andhra Pradesh government has overhauled its fireworks safety, licensing and enforcement framework following explosions at cracker manufacturing units in Rayavaram and Vetlapalem, introducing a system of centralised monitoring, risk-based inspections and stricter accountability for enforcement officials. The reforms followed the findings of inquiry panels which pointed to fragmented enforcement and inadequate risk-based monitoring. It has also ordered the constitution of a State Explosives and Fireworks Safety Cell within 30 days.

Police issue notice to KPSC chairperson for questioning

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) of police investigating the alleged irregularities in examinations conducted by the Kerala Public Service Commission has directed chairperson M.R. Baiju to appear for questioning on Tuesday. The official had avoided a summons issued earlier, citing the pending proceedings before the Kerala High Court on the PSC's petition to quash the case. Investigators are considering further legal action, including making him an accused in the case and possible arrest, sources said.

V-C summoned by panel after sexual harassment complaint

The Telangana State Commission for Women on Monday summoned Aldas Janaiah, the Vice-Chancellor of Professor Jayashankar Telangana State Agricultural University in connection with allegations of sexual harassment levelled by an assistant professor. He was asked to appear before the commission on November 12. The complainant had said that she had been harassed, body-shamed and intimidated by the V-C. However, several professors and staff members had disputed her version, claiming that the allegations were fabricated or motivated.

Seeking blessings


Silver trail: Devotees visited the Bhagyalakshmi Temple to collect a free silver coin with the image of Goddess Lakshmi, popularly known as 'Amma vari khajana', in Hyderabad on Monday. G. RAMAKRISHNA

Cut in guidance value for regularising BDA sites: Karnataka CM

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

To resolve long-pending property-related grievances, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Monday announced a 50% reduction in the guidance value considered for calculating charges to regularise unauthorised houses built on land acquired by the Bangalore Development Authority (BDA).

As the BDA had completed 50 years, the government wanted to provide relief to those who had been living in houses built on BDA-acquired land for years, Mr. Shivakumar told presspersons.

This also comes in the backdrop of a lukewarm response from residents who have built houses on these lands. While it is estimated the BDA will collect nearly ₹5,000 crore through this regularisation scheme, multiple efforts by the municipal body since 2015 have failed to yield any results. The BDA would be compelled to initiate legal action if land was occupied without regularisation, the Chief Minister said.

Keralam Health Dept. detects nine Shigella cases in Malappuram

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

The Keralam Health Department has stepped up preventive measures in Malappuram district following an outbreak of Shigella infection, with nine cases confirmed so far.

Cleaning operations, including super-chlorination of wells and houses in the affected areas, are under way. The family health centre at Elamkulam, near Perinthalmanna, formed a special squad to conduct house-to-house surveillance and create awareness about the infection.

Shigella is a diarrhoeal disease marked by fever, abdominal cramps, and bloody diarrhoea (dysentery). The outbreak came to light after more than 100 people who attended a wedding at Elamkulam on October 31 reported symptoms. Extensive testing was conducted following the reports. The Health department has advised people to seek medical attention immediately if they develop symptoms and avoid self-medication.


The government has stepped up preventive measures after the outbreak. GETTY IMAGES

Actor Mammootty faces online attacks over his visit to BJP leader's residence

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Actor Mammootty faced online attacks after he visited the house of Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader B. Gopalakrishnan in Thrissur on Sunday to extend wishes to his daughter on her marriage.

The cyber attacks started after visuals of the actor being received by Mr. Gopalakrishnan and his family members appeared online. Mr. Mammootty visited his house to wish the newly married couple as he could not attend their marriage held on November 1. Criticism had emerged that the online attacks came from social media handles aligned with the Communist Party of India (Marxist), though the party distanced itself from the controversy.


Actor Mammootty had earlier faced criticism when he visited the Wayanad model township for landslide survivors. FILE PHOTO

CPI(M) leader T. M. Thomas Isaac said that the party has its own social media handles and pointed out that it has a cordial relationship with the actor.

BJP leader slams attacks

Mr. Gopalakrishnan on Monday condemned the online attacks on the actor. He said that the cyber attacks may not have come from genuine CPI(M) workers. There are some divisive elements who wanted to pursue their agendas by criticising such meetings. I have good personal relationships with leaders across political parties, though I remain a committed worker of the BJP. Such personal relationships should not be judged through political affiliations, he said.

He said that several leaders including Keralam Chief Minister V. D Satheesan and Opposition Leader Pinarayi Vijayan had attended his daughter's wedding.

Mr. Mammootty had been targetted earlier this year after a video showed the actor, who was visiting the Wayanad model township built for landslide survivors, telling CPI(M) Wayanad district secretary K. Rafeeq to move aside as people might assume that his visit was organised by the CPI(M).

The senior actor also faced online criticism in September after visiting the Statue of Unity dedicated to Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel located in Ekta Nagar, Gujarat.

Commercial farming in forest land is not protected in FRA: SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


The Bench made its *prima facie* view clear against Tamil Nadu's claim of historical cultivation of silk cotton. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

The Supreme Court has made it clear that commercial crop cultivation within reserve forest areas is not protected under the Forest Rights Act (FRA), 2006.

The court has distinguished commercial cultivators and plantation owners from forest-dwelling Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers, who have lived in forests for generations and depend on them for livelihood. Their rights are protected under the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, commonly known as the FRA.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta recorded the court's view in an order concerning extensive silk cotton cultivation within the reserve forests of the Agasthyamalai Biosphere Reserve. The court, in its November 6 order, directed the Central Empowered Committee to examine the Tamil Nadu government's opinion that silk cotton was a 'minor forest produce'. At present, 3,637.83 hectares of the 5,072.64 hectares of forest land are under silk cotton cultivation.

The Bench made clear its *prima facie* view against the State's claim of historical cultivation of silk cotton. "What emerges from the government affidavits is the promotion and sponsored cultivation of silk cotton as a commercial crop... The concept of planned cultivation of commercial crops is totally contrary to the very concept of a naturally occurring minor forest produce," the apex court noted.

'Not permissible'

"We are of the prima facie view that planned or promoted cultivation of a commercial crop inside the forest areas is completely impermissible, as no such right is recognised under the FRA, 2006. The Act recognises the right of forest dwellers to collect, use and dispose of minor forest produce in accordance with Section 3(1)(c). The cultivation of a commercial crop cannot, therefore, be recognised as a forest right so as to justify occupation or continued presence within the forest area," the Bench said.

"If commercial crops are permitted to be cultivated in the forest areas, the very nature of the forest is bound to change," Justice Mehta, who authored the order, observed.

Fourth 'encounter' in just 4 months as rape-murder accused killed in Bengal

He was shot dead while trying to flee to Bihar, say police; CM Adhikari backs the police action, says his government has given the force a free hand to deal with rapists, drug traffickers, infiltrators

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA


The spot where an accused in the rape and murder of a minor girl was killed in the police encounter in Uttar Dinajpur on Monday. ANI

A prime accused in the rape and murder of a minor in Raiganj in Uttar Dinajpur district of West Bengal was shot dead by the police when he allegedly tried to flee to Bihar. This is the fourth such encounter in the State in the past four months since the BJP came to power.

According to the police, the accused, Dilip Roy, was on the run after the mutilated body of the 13-year-old girl was recovered on Thursday. Around 3.30 a.m. on Monday, the personnel moved to arrest him in the Gauri village area, where he was attempting to cross into Bihar.

As soon as the police reached the spot, he shot at the officers and was killed in retaliatory firing, the police said.

He was rushed to a nearby hospital, where he was declared dead. The body was later sent for an autopsy.

The police said the minor victim went missing on Tuesday and the body was recovered from the Kulik Wildlife Sanctuary. Following a preliminary investigation, a case of rape and murder was registered at the Raiganj police station following a complaint by her parents, after which the police began searching for the accused.

Reacting to the development, Panchayat Minister Dilip Ghosh said the police would have to take such action if anyone violates the law. "Such crimes will not be spared. If everyone follows law and order, nothing will happen. But the police have a duty to act if accused individuals attempt to evade the law or escape," he said.

Previous 'encounters'

Monday's development comes only 13 days after two more 'encounters' took place on October 27, just 12 hours apart.

Samaul Sheikh, a key accused in the murder of BJP worker Sujit Mondal on August 28, was shot dead in a gunfight with the police in Murshidabad around 3 p.m. About 12 hours earlier, Prahlad Das, accused of raping and murdering a minor girl in North 24 Parganas's Gaighata, was shot dead in an encounter around 3.30 a.m.

Earlier, on July 8, a similar 'encounter' took place in the Baruipur area of South 24 Parganas, when the police took Prabhas Mondal, the prime accused in the rape and murder of a minor girl, to reconstruct the crime scene. The area had been tense since July 5, when the body of the 12-year-old girl was recovered from a pond after she was allegedly raped and murdered.

CM issues warning

On November 3, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari warned criminals that they would not be spared if anyone caused harm to women in the State.

"You all are seeing what is happening when someone lays hands on our mothers and sisters," he said on November 3.

He defended the killing of the rape-murder accused in the police encounter in Uttar Dinajpur, stating that personnel can fire in self-defence and asserting that his government has given the force a free hand to deal with rapists, drug traffickers, and infiltrators.

Addressing reporters in Digha, Mr. Adhikari, who also holds the police portfolio, said personnel do not shoot every accused, but are authorised to act without waiting for clearance from their superiors in cases involving rape and murder, drug trafficking, and infiltration from Bangladesh.

"Do police shoot every accused? When someone attacks the police, they retaliate in self-defence. Are the police supposed to keep its gun in its pocket? The government has given the police a free hand in certain cases. They need not wait for permission from their superiors to act. There is absolutely zero tolerance towards rape and murder, drug trafficking, and infiltration," he said.

Census to remain on hold in Manipur till April 2027: HC

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI



A protest calling for updation of NRC before State Census. PTI

The High Court of Manipur has said that the Census in the State will remain suspended until at least April 30, 2027, while the Centre considers requests from campaign groups and residents to delay or change the dates for the exercise.

A Bench of Chief Justice M. Sundar and Justice A. Guneshwar Sharma said postponement notices already issued by the Centre and the State government must remain in force until the date specified and cannot be withdrawn or altered.

The court's November 4 order disposed of two petitions, one filed by Imphal resident Shanta Singh Nahakpam and the other by the Kangleipak Students' Association and the International Peace and Social Advancement. They had challenged the plan to begin house-listing, the first stage of the 2027 Census, in the State from September 1.

The petitioners argued that conditions in Manipur, where thousands of people have been displaced by the ethnic violence that began in May 2023, were not right for an accurate headcount. They also expressed fears that Census figures could affect the redrawing of Assembly constituency boundaries.

The court noted that some groups wanted the National Register of Citizens (NRC) to be updated before the Census operation is undertaken and the 2001 Census figures in certain hill areas to be recounted.

The court asked the Registrar-General of India and the Census Commissioner to consider the demands raised in existing petitions on their "own merits" and issue a detailed, reasoned decision. It said the petitioners and anyone else could send additional petitions by November 25.

The court said the authorities concerned may hold public consultations after the decisions by April 30, 2027. "If it (public consultation) is considered not necessary, the reasons shall be set out in the common speaking order," it said. It further said the Census would remain on hold for four weeks after the decision was issued, allowing anyone dissatisfied with it to approach the court again.

Meitei and Naga organisations want the citizens' register updated before the Census, but pro-Census Kuki-Zo organisations see the NRC demand as "premature and unjustified".

'Inspired' by online video, man kills child for organ trade in Chhattisgarh

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

Accused buried the body at a different site after extracting organs, which he kept in a plastic bag, said Jashpur SSP

A 27-year-old man was arrested in Chhattisgarh's Jashpur for allegedly killing a four-year-old boy, a relative of his, with the intention of selling the boy's organs, the police said on Monday.

According to the police, the man, who works as an agricultural labourer, got the idea after watching a video that purportedly suggested organ sale as a way to make money quickly.

The accused, Basudev Korwa, alias Tangnu, lives in Sanna village. Mr. Korwa's cousin, Ramjeet Ram, 36, also lives there with his wife and their children. On November 5, after getting Ramjeet Ram inebriated, Mr. Korwa allegedly lured one of his sons with chicken and fed him liquor. The accused is then alleged to have taken the boy to his hut, where he slit the child's throat. According to the police, he then removed the boy's organs, including the kidneys.

Jashpur Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Lal Umed Singh said the accused buried the body at a different site after extracting the organs, which he kept in a plastic bag.

The following day, the boy's father complained to the police about his son's disappearance, and villagers mounted a search. The body, wrapped in a blanket, was discovered by a villager nearly 500 metres away from the field where both the victim and the accused lived in separate huts. A witness also told the police that the child was seen with Mr. Korwa.

AI interaction

Upon his arrest, the police learnt that Mr. Korwa, who had received little formal education, had no understanding of how organ transplants worked and did not have a buyer.

Mr. Singh said that through the content the accused had consumed online, he was convinced that there would be a "buyer from Delhi" who would come and buy the organs he had supposedly "preserved" in the plastic bag.

The SSP said that Mr. Korwa, in a bid to make more money than the few hundred rupees he earned daily, had joined some groups on a chatting app that discussed ways to make money. However, all conversations were in English, which he did not understand.

"What came to his aid was an AI assistant embedded in the chatting app that understood and replied in Hindi. As he started interacting with the app, it redirected him to other sites, which would open in the browser. One such video was about organ sales fetching good money," said another senior police officer.

Six of family killed in fire at home above grocery store in Maharashtra

Yohaan Varghese
MUMBAI

A boy, who was brought to safety by his parents before they went back to rescue others, was the sole survivor

Six members of a family – two teenage girls, their parents, and their grandparents – were killed after a fire broke out at their house above a grocery store in Maharashtra's Dharashiv district in the early hours of Monday .

A boy, who was brought downstairs to safety by the parents before they went back in an effort to rescue the others, was the sole survivor.

The fire broke out around 2.30 a.m. in Yedshi village at the residence of Govind Uttam Karande (47), whose family lived on the upper floor of a building housing their grocery store, said Prakash Vhatkar, an official from the Dharashiv Revenue Office.

The deceased have been identified as Uttam Trimbak Karande (75), his wife Chandrakala Uttam Karande (70), their son Govind Uttam Karande (47), his wife Jyoti Govind Karande (42), and the couple's daughters Gayatri (16) and Siddhi (15).

Senior Police Inspector Vasudev More of Dharashiv Rural police station said a driver working for a travel company noticed the fire on the upper floor and alerted the family.

According to Mr. More, Govind and Jyoti initially managed to bring their son, Krishna, downstairs. They then returned to the upper floor to rescue the elderly couple and their two daughters, asking Krishna to fetch water in buckets.

However, the fire intensified rapidly, trapping them on the upper floor.

Mr. More said the presence of cooking oil, containers of ghee, and stacks of disposable leaf plates contributed to the rapid spread of the flames.

According to the police's preliminary assessment, Govind and Jyoti suffered severe burns, while the other four family members died from inhaling smoke and fumes. Postmortem reports are awaited.

Local residents rushed to the scene and attempted to extinguish the blaze. Fire brigade personnel were also deployed, but the intensity of the fire made it difficult to bring the blaze under control.

According to Mr. Vhatkar, local residents said the family had been awake until around 2 a.m., celebrating Lakshmi Puja and bursting firecrackers.

However, the police have not established whether the firecrackers were connected to the blaze.

The bodies of the six deceased were taken to Civil Hospital, Dharashiv, for post-mortem examination.

Mr. More said the origin and cause of the fire were still under investigation.

Modi said India ready to help end the conflict: Zelenskyy

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI


Narendra Modi meeting with Volodymyr Zelenskyy on the sidelines of UN General Assembly in New York in September 2024. ANI

India is ready to mediate between Russia and Ukraine to establish "food corridors", announced Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, welcoming the offer after a telephone call with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, ahead of the Ukraine-Russia peace talks set to begin in Abu Dhabi on Tuesday.

Mr. Modi conveyed India's "readiness" to help with all initiatives to end the nearly five-year-old conflict. The call was followed by another call between External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar and Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov, in the clearest indication thus far of the mediatory role that New Delhi is now playing between Moscow and Kyiv.

On Tuesday, U.S. President Donald Trump's negotiators, including his son-in-law Jared Kushner and special envoy Steve Witkoff, will restart negotiations after three months with Russian and Ukrainian representatives to discuss security guarantees required for a possible ceasefire. The calls from New Delhi came just ahead of the talks in the UAE, and a week before Mr. Modi and Mr. Trump are expected to meet on the sidelines of the ASEAN-linked summits in Manila. Later this month, Mr. Trump is expected to travel to Shenzhen for the APEC summit in China, that Russian President Vladimir Putin is also expected to attend, making the timing of the Modi-Zelenskyy and Jaishankar-Lavrov calls more significant. "Prime Minister [Modi] reaffirmed India's human-centric approach and reiterated India's consistent position that the conflict must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy," the Ministry of External Affairs said in a statement about the Modi-Zelenskyy call. "He conveyed India's readiness to contribute to all efforts aimed at peaceful resolution of the conflict," it added.

'Briefed Modi'

In a post on social media, Mr. Zelenskyy said he had briefed Mr. Modi on the latest developments and stressed that Mr. Modi had said to Mr. Putin that the war must end. The Ukrainian President said Russia must understand that the "global economy and hundreds of millions of people around the world are suffering because of blocked sea routes" in the Black Sea, and called for India to clarify its peace proposal.

"It is important that India identify what steps it can take and what dialogue it can pursue with other leaders to help bring the war to an end. Food security could be one such area. We discussed Russia's blocking of grain exports via the Black Sea. India is ready to mediate in establishing food corridors, and we are counting on these efforts to continue," Mr. Zelenskyy wrote.

Within a couple of hours of the announcement, Mr. Jaishankar posted that he had spoken to his Russian counterpart Mr. Lavrov as well, and said their conversation had "focused on the Ukraine conflict and ongoing diplomatic initiatives".

Tool developed to test teachers' grasp of inclusive education

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Researchers from Nagaland University have developed and tested a 50-item achievement test to measure how well teachers in training understand inclusive education. They said the tool is designed to help identify gaps in teachers' preparation and improve teaching practices for children with learning needs.

The study by Gyanendra Nath Tiwari, a professor at the university's Department of Teacher Education, and research scholar Aseto Iralu Meyase was published in the peer-reviewed International Journal of Research and Innovation in Social Science.

According to the study, most available tools focus on teachers' attitudes or confidence. However, few measure what future teachers know about education – its concepts, practices and policies.

"The new test aims to fill that gap. It can help teacher education institutions spot areas where trainee teachers struggle," the study said.

Rahul dares Modi to debate after '*dimagi* Naxal' remark by PM

Let him debate me on who is anti-national and controlled by foreign forces, says Cong. leader; he slams PM's address to CRPF personnel

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Rahul Gandhi has repeatedly challenged Narendra Modi to a debate, claiming he could establish in minutes that the PM was a 'traitor'. PTI

A day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi cautioned Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) personnel to be alert about "*dimagi* (intellectual) Naxals", Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday dared the Prime Minister to debate him on who was an anti-national.

In a post on X, addressed to CRPF personnel, Mr. Gandhi said their expressions showed they had not been convinced by the Prime Minister's remarks. "Your faces said it all: you didn't buy the PM's lies," he said.

Accusing Mr. Modi of branding his political opponents as "Naxals", Mr. Gandhi reiterated his challenge to debate him on "who is anti-national and who is controlled by foreign forces".

"He called us Naxals. My challenge stands. Let him debate me on who is anti-national and who is controlled by foreign forces. Any time, any place. My guarantee: after the debate, the PM won't have the guts to stand in front of a single jawan again," the Congress leader said.

On Sunday, addressing security personnel at a CRPF camp in Bastar, Chhattisgarh, during his Deepavali visit, Mr. Modi said that while armed Maoists had been eliminated, "*dimagi* Naxals" had infiltrated political parties and organisations, and were instigating people against the Constitution and democracy. He called for identifying and defeating such elements.

The Prime Minister had also used the term in his Independence Day address in August, arguing that ideological supporters of Naxalism continued to pose a challenge despite success in eliminating armed insurgency.

The Congress accused Mr. Modi of being "distraught, disturbed and desperate", adding that his "*jhola*[bag]-picking-up time" was approaching.

"The Prime Minister has not spared the country his usual abusive language even on Diwali. Once again, he has called some of his political opponents 'intellectual Naxals'. Most objectionable is that he abused an extremely solemn and non-political occasion for this, wore the uniform of the security forces, and hurled a barrage of mud at his political opponents. This is an open assault on all norms of propriety and tradition. But when have these gentlemen ever cared about principles and ideals?" Congress's communications chief Jairam Ramesh said in a post on X on Sunday.

Mr. Gandhi has repeatedly challenged Mr. Modi to an open debate, claiming that he could establish within five minutes that the Prime Minister was a "traitor". Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders have dismissed the challenge, accusing the Congress leader of avoiding debates in Parliament.

Prashant Kishor opens a new line of attack with 'Brahminical criticism' of BJP's Hindutva

NEWS ANALYSIS

Varghese K. George
NEW DELHI

Secularism is a modern, constitutional principle. In real-world politics, the manifestation of this principle is tested against a rather narrow yardstick: the fair representation of religious minorities, particularly Muslims. Generally speaking, the English-speaking secularists are unaware of the caste dynamics that come into play in the field operation of representative politics, and they are also resistant to the idea of discussing caste as a determinant.

The intersection of caste representation and religious representation can be framed as an intersection of social justice and secularism in electoral politics. The caste dynamics of politics are often manifested as critiques by non-Brahmins against Brahminism.

A Brahmin perspective on these dynamics is rare, and that is the reason why Jan Suraaj Party founder Prashant Kishor's address to fellow Brahmins in Bihar's Mithila region is an extremely valuable opportunity to peer into the emerging thinking within the community. He said the BJP's Hindu communalism, which excludes Muslims from electoral calculations, has cost the Brahmins heavily and asked them to rethink their position. He addressed the Maithili Intellectuals' Symposium-cum-Felicitation Ceremony in Mahinam village of Benipur block in Darbhanga district of Bihar on November 5.

The village falls within the Mithila region of Bihar, which consists of a dominant population of Maithil Brahmins. In Darbhanga, their population is almost one-fourth, making them politically significant, in addition to the cultural and social capital they possess.

The speech was addressed to Brahmins of the Mithila region attending the event.

On the occasion, Mr. Kishor said Brahmins were able to win elections with the support of Muslims, whom they have alienated through communal hostility. Brahmins were unwise in joining the BJP's Hindu platform and antagonising Muslims, Mr. Kishor told his caste brethren, in a speech that has now gone viral.


Hot take: Kishor says BJP's Hindu communalism, which excludes Muslims from electoral calculations, has cost Brahmins heavily. ANI

'You need votes'

"...Your ancestors used to rule here... someone told me someone from Congress used to be an MLA here. In a democracy, you have to count how many votes you will get. How you have left the company of Saraswati [alluding to the fact that Saraswati is the goddess of education], I will tell you with an example. You are calling yourselves knowledgeable; you know that to win an election, you need votes; you cannot increase your population. But your ancestors created the system that the 20% Muslims used to vote for you. What did you do? You took up and started moving around with the BJP flag. So the 20% drifted away to the other side. Now you are rattling: 'How will we win? How will we win?' Now understand carefully. Is your fight with Muslims for reservation? Or for land? What is the fight for? You never went to join a communal riot. You won't be able to kill even an ant, but you will write abuses against Muslims on Facebook, by becoming a Bhajpai [of BJP]. What happened? The people because of whom you used to become king drifted away from you. You are calling yourself an intellectual; what knowledge is this? What knowledge is this?" Mr. Kishor said, arguing that Brahmins were acting against their self-interest by joining the BJP bandwagon.

Mr. Kishor was recalling the original Congress social coalition, which was led by the Brahmins but had Muslims as a central part of it, along with the Extremely Backward Castes. "The EBCs are being discussed a lot; it is they who are lately deciding the terms of politics. Those EBCs – did your ancestors keep them with themselves or not? Did they make them sit with them? Along with Pandit*ji* [reference to Brahmin], Nau*ji* [reference to Nai, the traditional occupation caste of barbers] was also respected or not? Why was this system made? But a new system is being created. New things are being taught to you," he said.

'Pen is your strength'

He also warned Brahmins that the idea that they should be wielding weapons would also be self-destructive.

"This person told me that he is another Parshurama. Hey brothers! Don't tread this wrong path. Your strength is the pen. Your strength is Saraswati. You are not among those who wield an axe. The thing about wielding an axe, about Parshurama, is in a certain context. That is not your instinct. Even people among you are taking up movements to celebrate Parshurama Jayanti. When your child won't study, wielding an axe won't fill his stomach. You will also face destruction... you are treading the path of destruction. My only request is that you use your intellect. Your strength is not agitation and an axe. The 18% who were with you without any effort were addressing you as Guru*ji* and made you sit on the throne with their votes; those are the people you are abusing on Facebook. By addressing that person as Pakistani, you distanced him from yourself. And you call yourselves intellectuals; then how will you win?"

The BJP policy in general takes the upper castes, particularly the Brahmins, as its committed voters. They were the original converts to the party in the early 1990s. In recent months, the party has been struggling to deal with the angst among the upper castes, expressed most consequentially in their open protests against the UGC guidelines on caste discrimination.

Despite their unhappiness with the BJP, it is not easy for the upper castes to find an alternative, as other options such as the Congress under Rahul Gandhi, Akhilesh Yadav's SP, and Tejashwi Yadav's RJD are pronouncedly in favour of OBCs and other subaltern castes. Mr. Kishor takes the critique of the BJP beyond these considerations and places a social coalition with Muslims at the centre of Brahmin interests.

What has been whispered in community circles has now been emphatically stated by a leader of consequence. This is a new line of attack against the BJP in the heartland.

BJP criticises Kharge for calling Deepavali the 'Id of happiness'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Gaurav Bhatia

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday accused Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge of insulting Hindus by describing Deepavali as "Id of happiness", alleging that the statement reflected the principal Opposition party's "politics of appeasement" and "anti-Sanatana" ideology.

"Whatever statements Mallikarjun Kharge*ji* makes should be understood as the anti-Hindu and anti-Sanatana thinking of Rahul Gandhi and Sonia Gandhi. Mallikarjun Kharge*ji* is advancing that very same thinking," BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia said at a press conference.

'Reverse remark on Id'

"I issue a challenge to Rahul Gandhi and Kharge*ji*. When Id comes this time, please make sure you say this once: 'The Diwali of happiness has arrived'... This will demonstrate whether your thinking and ideology are consistent. If Diwali is an 'Id of happiness', then Id should also be a 'Diwali of happiness'. However, this will not happen, as the remarks are a reflection of the Congress's mindset," he said.

In a statement to the media on Saturday in Bengaluru, Mr. Kharge had said, "I wish everyone a happy Deepavali. This is a very big festival that everyone celebrates in India, as it is an Id of happiness, and this is the Id that lasts for a long time. So, it is a good festival for people to live in happiness and peace and to meet their loved ones."

"That is why, during this festival, while wishing all the people of my country, I have a special appeal that maintaining peace is important. Particularly, those people who are fighting with each other and have misunderstandings among themselves should stay away from those misunderstandings. To save our country, everyone should work wholeheartedly," said Mr. Kharge.

Congress leader Pawan Khera defended the party chief's remarks, saying those criticising it were "semantically ignorant" as the word 'Id' meant festival. He said Mr. Kharge's statement was perfectly normal and accused the BJP of viewing even a festival through the lens of negativity.

"We come from the Ganga-Jamuna *tehzeeb* [syncretic culture]. We will bring all religions along together," Mr. Khera added.

Earlier, describing Deepavali as one of India's biggest festivals that taught harmony, Mr. Bhatia asked: "Why is it that when we are talking about Diwali, which has its own sanctity, its own tradition and identity, you are congratulating Hindus by calling it Id? Has the character and DNA of the Congress party now become such that Hindu festivals should have their identities changed?"

Akhilesh's proposed visit to Ayodhya temple meant to broaden PDA outreach, say analysts

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW


The BJP has criticised Akhilesh Yadav over his Ayodhya visit. ANI.

The announcement of Samajwadi Party president and former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Akhilesh Yadav's proposed visit to the Ram Temple in Ayodhya on December 12, for the first time since its consecration two years ago, has triggered a political slugfest with the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) calling the visit politically motivated.

Analysts see the visit as an attempt by the SP chief to leave no stone unturned before the Assembly polls early next year and addressing the concerns of Brahmins, who are traditionally associated with temple priesthood. The visit holds significance as it is taking place post the Ram Temple donation embezzlement episode.

Party spokesperson Pawan Pandey last week said that Mr. Yadav would visit Hanuman Garhi with his MP wife Dimple Yadav and other family members and later the Ram Temple on December 12. "Akhilesh Yadav *ji* made it clear several times that religion and faith are personal issues... The BJP anxiety and propaganda regarding his visit further reinforces that they do not want to contest the U.P. Assembly issue on their 10 years of achievement and governance," said Sudhir Panwar, a senior SP leader.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath had remarked that those who had neglected the holy town and opened fire on Lord Ram's devotees were welcome to visit, but only after seeking forgiveness.

"The SP is trying to broaden its PDA [Pichda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak] outreach, beyond the backward classes, Scheduled Castes [SCs] and Muslims. Akhilesh Yadav is aware that in the 2022 Assembly polls, despite getting a sizeable vote share, he was far from forming the government," said Shashikant Pandey, a political scientist teaching at Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar University in Lucknow.

Umakant Pandey, a political analyst based in Lucknow, said Brahmins have traditionally functioned as priests responsible for daily worship at temples, hence the visit can be linked to a community outreach.

Videos of poor at Ayodhya ghats spark row in U.P.

Press Trust of India
AYODHYA

A political controversy erupted in poll-bound Uttar Pradesh on Monday as videos and photographs purportedly showing poor people rushing to collect leftover oil from 30 lakh earthen lamps at Ayodhya's Saryu river ghats, which set a new Guinness record at the 10th edition of Deepotsav on Saturday, circulated on social media for the second consecutive day.

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav trained guns at the ruling BJP over inflation and "humiliation" suffered by the poor. He also shared video clips purportedly showing men wielding wooden sticks at the ghats to prevent people from collecting oil.

In a post on X, Mr. Yadav said, "A few months from now, we will form our 'PDA government' and ensure that mustard oil is provided through the ration system so that no exploited, deprived or poor person has to suffer humiliation after being beaten with sticks by these BJP people."

Meanwhile, Ayodhya Mayor Girish Pati Tripathi, of the BJP, said the civic administration was aware of the issue and took steps to ensure that oil and sweets were distributed to the needy ahead of Deepotsav.

"We are aware of this and have, this year too, distributed oil and sweets in slums and among the needy. This time, I too was especially careful about this and oversaw this distribution," Mr. Tripathi said.

He added that one possible solution was to remove all lamps after the event.

As NDA govt. finishes one year in Bihar, PM to visit on Nov. 21

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA


Narendra Modi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to visit the Rajapakar block in north Bihar's Vaishali district on November 21 to mark the completion of one year of the incumbent National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government in the State.

During his visit, he is expected to inaugurate the six-lane, 9.76 km cable-stayed Kacchi Dargah-Bidupur bridge over the Ganga River, which connects Kacchi Dargah in the Deedarganj area of South Patna to Bidupur near Hajipur in Vaishali through the Raghopur *diara* (riverine) area. He will also lay the foundation stone for several projects in the State, including a park for which the State government has acquired 1,243 acres of land in Vaishali district.

On Monday, NDA leaders met and addressed the media at the office of NDA ally Janata Dal-United (JD-U). Mr. Modi's upcoming visit would prove a milestone in Bihar's industrial development, they said.

Leaders from all five NDA coalition partners – the BJP, the JD(U), the Hindustani Awam Morcha-Secular (HAM-S), the Lok Janshakti Party-Ram Vilas (LJP-RV), and the Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) – were present at the meeting.

The Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) accused the Centre of taking credit for projects started by others.

"PM Modi is coming to inaugurate the six-lane Kacchi Dargah-Bidupur bridge but the project was initiated by the *mahagathbandhan* [grand alliance] government when I was the Deputy Chief Minister in 2015," RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, the Leader of the Opposition in the Bihar Assembly, said. "We did the work but someone else is cutting the ribbon," Mr. Yadav, three-time MLA from Raghopur in Vaishali district, alleged.

Congress slams govt. for not proroguing LS even after 88-day gap

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The 88-day gap since the Lok Sabha was adjourned *sine die* but not prorogued is designed to give Union Home Minister Amit Shah time to muster the numbers for a two-thirds majority to push through the delimitation Bills, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh alleged on Monday.

In a post on X, Mr. Ramesh cited the eighth edition of *Practice and Procedure of Parliament*, popularly known as Kaul and Shakdher (after its authors). The book says the interval between the adjournment *sine die* of the Lok Sabha and its prorogation is generally two to four days, he claimed.

"... This record has been set to give time to the Union Home Minister to somehow manipulate a super-tainted two-thirds majority in the Lok Sabha to get the dangerous and destructive Delimitation Bills passed," he alleged.

The Opposition's unity and solidarity, which had defeated the government's designs on April 17, 2026, would prevail again if Mr. Shah resorted to his "trademark bulldozer tactics", he said. Mr. Kharge had written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi four times in the past six months seeking an all-party meeting to discuss the delimitation proposals transparently and in detail, he said.

INBRIEF



Modernist artist Arpita Singh, aged 89, passes away

Modernist artist Arpita Singh, widely known for her detailed figurative works, died at a hospital in New Delhi from age-related ailments on Monday, her husband and artist Paramjit said. She was 89. "She had heart and lung related issues for some years now. However, she was actively working. Her health dipped in the last three days and was admitted to the hospital," he added. Their only daughter, also an artist, Anjum Singh died in 2020 from cancer. Ms. Singh received the Padma Bhushan in 2011 and the Lalit Kala Akademi Fellowship in 2014 for her contribution to art. PTI

Delhi Police serve notice on Mamata in 2013 protest case

Thirteen years after a major student agitation in New Delhi over the death of Students' Federation of India (SFI) leader Sudipto Gupto in police custody in Kolkata, the Delhi Police on Monday served a notice on former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in connection with a case registered during the protest. According to police officials, a team of the Delhi Police visited Ms. Banerjee's residence in Kolkata's Kalighat to serve the notice. The 2013 gherao of Banga Bhawan was part of a major student agitation in New Delhi triggered by the death of 22-year-old SFI leader in police custody in Kolkata.

Air pollution spikes 200 times above WHO limits in Delhi during Deepavali

Data missing from several monitoring stations at the peak of air pollution during the intervening night of Nov. 8 and 9; AAP accuses BJP govt. of 'data fraud', the latter hits back alleging stubble burning 'conspiracy' by AAP-governed Punjab, which recorded 1,152 stubble burning incidents on Sunday

Nikhil M. Babu
NEW DELHI

As Delhiites burst firecrackers well past the 10 p.m. deadline set by the Supreme Court for Deepavali night, air pollution shot up to over 150-200 times World Health Organisation (WHO) limits in parts of the city, but fell through the early morning hours of Monday due to better weather conditions, show official data.

At the peak of pollution, following the bursting of firecrackers on Sunday night, crucial air quality data were missing from several monitoring stations managed by government authorities. Experts say missing data on peak values of air pollution will artificially show better air quality than the reality.

Though the Supreme Court allowed only green firecrackers during fixed windows on November 7 and 8, traditional firecrackers, which are more polluting, were also available in the markets of Delhi.



Worrying trend: Rashtrapati Bhavan was shrouded in thick smog during the early morning hours of Monday after Deepavali celebrations in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

As per the Delhi government's Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) data, the level of PM2.5 (a major pollution) in Patparganj of East Delhi was 2,597 micrograms per cubic metre at 1 a.m. on Monday – about 173.13 times the WHO permissible limit of 15 micrograms per cubic metre for a 24-hour period.

Similarly, the level of PM2.5 on NSUT West Campus was 3,008.4 micrograms per cubic metre at 5 a.m. on Monday – about 200.5 times the WHO permissible limit. PM2.5 (Particulate matter 2.5) are fine inhalable particles, which can get into lungs and bloodstream and lead to a range of respiratory and other diseases.

Favourable wind

Gufran Beig, chair professor, National Institute of Advanced Studies, said though the air pollution spiked around 12 midnight on Sunday to 5 a.m. on Monday due to bursting of firecrackers on Deepavali, both wind direction and speed were very favourable for faster dispersion of air pollution.

"The wind direction was earlier north westerly, originating from stubble burning areas in Punjab and Haryana. But around Sunday afternoon, it changed to easterly and south easterly and also picked up speed by Sunday evening. The reversal of wind direction led to almost negligible effect of stubble burning in Delhi," said Mr. Beig, who is also the founder-director of the Central government's SAFAR (System of Air Quality and Weather Forecasting Research).

The 24-hour average overall Air Quality Index (AQI) of Delhi stood at 344 ("very poor") at 4 p.m. on Monday, lower than 376 ("very poor") a day earlier, according to the CPCB's daily bulletin, which is considered the day's AQI. A higher AQI means worsening of air quality. The overall AQI of Delhi which stood at 370 (very poor) at 9 a.m. on Monday, improved through the day to reach 344 by 4 p.m.

Meanwhile, both the AAP and the Congress attacked the BJP government over the missing data, with the former alleging that it was "data fraud". Hitting back, Delhi Labour Minister Kapil Mishra alleged there was a "conspiracy" by AAP-governed Punjab to set stubble on fire on Sunday evening.

Every winter, air pollution spikes in Delhi-NCR and many parts of the larger Indo-Gangetic Plains, mainly due to meteorological factors such as lower wind speeds and a drop in temperature. Also, pollution from stubble burning during October and November and bursting of firecrackers during the festive season add to existing pollution from vehicles and dust, worsening the air quality.

Stubble burning

Meanwhile, Punjab recorded 1,152 stubble burning incidents on Sunday – the highest this paddy harvest season, according to the Indian Agricultural Research Institute's (IARI) daily bulletin. But it dropped to 198 on Monday, taking the total this harvest season to 4,657, the second lowest since 2020 (till November 9), the data show.

The contribution of stubble burning in neighbouring States to PM2.5 (a chief pollutant) in Delhi on Sunday was 5.1%, according to the Union Ministry of Earth Sciences data.

NMC warns students against joining fake medical colleges, asks them to verify approvals

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The National Medical Commission (NMC) has cautioned students and parents against enrolling in medical colleges without verifying their statutory recognition and regulatory approvals, warning that fraudulent institutions could be misleading aspirants through advertisements, websites, social media promotions and unauthorised admission offers.

In a recent advisory issued in compliance with directions from the Supreme Court, the NMC has urged students to independently verify a medical college's approval status, permitted student intake, and admission permissions for the relevant academic year before seeking admission or making any payment.



The advisory follows Supreme Court directions in an ongoing case. FILE PHOTO

The advisory follows the Supreme Court taking cognisance of the issue in *Ayesha Jain v. Amity University, Noida & Ors.*, an ongoing case in which the Court directed regulatory bodies, including the NMC, to caution students and parents against dealing with unauthorised educational institutions.

'College' in farmhouse

The directions came in the context of a reported instance of a purported fake medical college operating from a farmhouse and claiming to offer various courses. The Commission has clarified that a medical college's presence in an official list, or its previous operation, does not automatically establish that it has permission to admit students in subsequent academic years.

Candidates must check the approval granted for the particular year and the number of seats sanctioned through official NMC and Medical Assessment and Rating Board (MARB) records.

Highlighting the importance of distinguishing between regulatory approvals, the NMC said affiliation, registration or recognition granted by one authority for a particular purpose should not be construed as permission from the Commission to conduct an MBBS course. Each statutory requirement must be independently satisfied, the NMC said.

Only non-*Sanatanis* have a problem with firecrackers: Suvendu

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari and a few of his BJP colleagues have defended Deepavali celebrations in Kolkata after several parts of the city witnessed severe air pollution on the night of the festival, with the Air Quality Index (AQI) crossing 500 and noise levels crossing permissible limits in some areas.

About 205 people were arrested for violation of the rules governing firecrackers in the State capital.

While a section of residents of the city and its suburbs were vocal about their displeasure on social media, Mr. Adhikari blamed "communists", and those who do not have *Sanatani* (traditionalist Hindu) beliefs for criticising the government.

"People will celebrate a little during Diwali and burst green crackers, what is the problem with that?" Mr. Adhikari said while interacting with media.

Mr. Adhikari said the administration had taken the necessary measures to enforce the Supreme Court's guidelines on noise pollution, though he acknowledged that some firecrackers were burst beyond the permitted hours.

"Some green firecrackers might have been burst after 10 p.m., but the police took action against those responsible. I feel the situation was largely under control," he said.

While the Chief Minister stopped at blaming Communists and non- *Sanatanis*, BJP MLA Papia Adhikari claimed that bursting firecrackers can cure several diseases. She made the remark during a Kali Puja event in her constituency, in Kolkata's Tollygunge area. "You will see that bursting firecrackers will cure many illnesses," she told the crowd.

Modi govt. is in denial over air pollution deaths, must wake up, says Cong. leader

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

With the post-Deepavali air in the Delhi-National Capital Region (NCR) deteriorating to 'severe' levels on Monday, Congress spokesperson and former Union Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh said on Monday that the Modi government had "long been in denial" on the impact of air pollution on mortality in the country.

"It (the Centre) has rejected, both in Parliament and outside, a number of studies on the grounds that they are not India-specific and that the impacts are not direct and uniquely attributable," he posted on social media platform *X*.

His comments were in the context of a joint report by the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI) and consultancy firm EY (formerly Ernst & Young), released in October 2026, which attributed 2 million deaths (about 22% of total number of deaths) in India in 2023 to air pollution.



Jairam Ramesh

"This is yet another wakeup call for the somnolent Modi Govt. Ease of doing business is fine but ease of breathing is even more fundamental. PM2.5 has become a decided killer across many parts of India," Mr. Ramesh said.

The FICCI-EY report, titled *Clean Air, Healthy India*, argues that air pollution should be treated not merely as an environmental problem but as a major public health and economic challenge. More than 660 million Indians, the report says, live in areas where annual fine particulate pollution exceeds the national standard, with an average loss of three-and-a-half years in life expectancy.

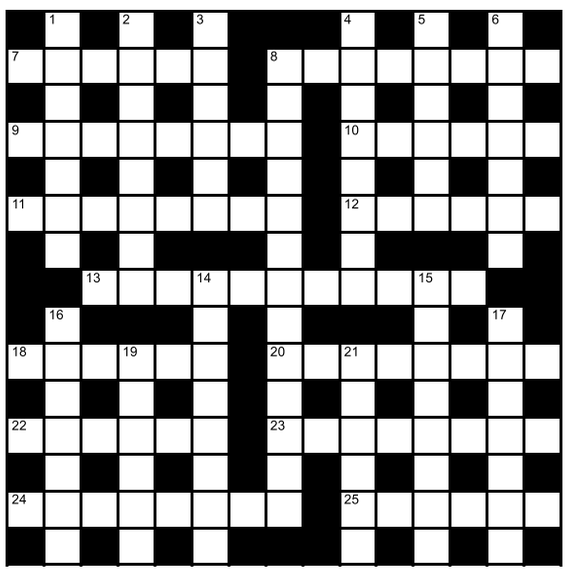
The report contends that pollution increases healthcare expenditure, absenteeism, and lost working days, while reducing productivity even among people who continue working. While acknowledging progress under the National Clean Air Programme, the report argues that the programme's emphasis on PM10 (particulate matter with diameter 10 micron) needs to be supplemented by explicit PM2.5 targets, precursor gas controls, and health-linked exposure indicators. It also stresses that AQI is a warning tool, not a pollution-control measure.

TH CROSSWORD + 14944

(set by Pixie Dust)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

7 Some bishop at hospital? Tragedy (6)
8 True! This footwear binder damages a Hercules toe? (8)
9 Finally 'Club XXIII India ' in Dehradun, Bengaluru, Agra call for an event occurring twice in a year (8)
10 Country delivered oil (6)
11 Tailor had cross braided rope (4,4)
12 Frankly Oscar (writer) liberal and young-at-heart from the beginning (6)
13 How sprites become experts? (4,7)
18 Picked up sluggish weapon for war cry (6)
20 City mess bizarrely is widely prevalent (8)
22 Atrocious cycling around Spooner reversing suddenly, say (6)
23 Pixie Dust is putting on an act in August (8)
24 Wake up call? (8)
25 To a great extent Girish Sir goes around like a monster (6)

Down

1 Discovered image, nice, calm and fascinating (7)
2 Capture large city (8)
3 Early glimpses of exclusive silver coin used during olden-times (6)
4 Bloomer! It looks like a dog, Mitt! (8)
5 Rob filmed Emcees periodically (6)
6 Diamonds could heartlessly become frosty (3-4)
8 Glad, resin is frequently used in sauce? (5,8)
14 Spooner's gang to catch guide? (8)
15 Unfortunately rusty era for the bank (8)
16 Fictional hero! A boy close to Princess- basically naive (7)
17 See Red going around Thailand on ship (7)
19 Girl's frail and ravenous (6)
21 Drain components of useless iPhone (6)

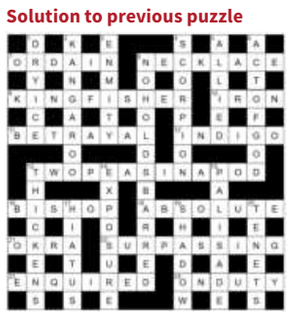
SUDOKU

		2	5	1	4			
				3				5
1	5		2					
5							6	9
6	9		3	7	5		1	4
2	7							8
					7		4	2
9				8				
			4	6	2	8		

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to Sunday's Sudoku

8	3	9	6	1	4	5	7	2
2	1	6	8	7	5	3	4	9
4	7	5	2	9	3	1	8	6
3	2	1	5	6	7	8	9	4
9	5	4	1	2	8	6	3	7
6	8	7	3	4	9	2	5	1
7	6	3	9	5	2	4	1	8
5	4	2	7	8	1	9	6	3
1	9	8	4	3	6	7	2	5

FAITH

Greatness of Padma Purana

Itihasa refers to events that actually took place in the past, conveying the meaning "Thus, indeed, it happened." Purana, on the other hand, refers to something extremely ancient, yet its teachings remain fresh and meaningful whenever we listen to them, said Sri Aravindalochanan. Sage Veda Vyasa compiled the 18 puranas; among them, the second most revered is the Padma Purana. The word "Padma" means lotus. The Padma Purana is symbolically regarded as the Supreme Lord's heart. When the 18 Puranas are collectively visualised as the divine form of Bhagavan, the Padma Purana represents His sacred heart.

The Padma Purana glorifies Bharata bhumi, describing its noble kings, sacred rivers, holy pilgrimage centres (*kshetras*) and their profound spiritual significance.

The Padma Purana is also associated with Lord Brahma, who emerged from the divine lotus arising from the navel of Lord Vishnu; the sacred teachings he imparted to sage Narada form part of the revered Padma Purana. The 18 Puranas are traditionally classified into three categories based on the three gunas (qualities): Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas, with six Puranas belonging to each category. The six Sattvic Puranas are Vishnu Purana, Padma Purana, Bhagavata Purana, Varaha Purana, Garuda Purana and Narada Purana. The Sattvic Puranas hold special importance, as listening to their sacred teachings helps cultivate Sattva Guna, the quality of purity, harmony and goodness. The Padma Purana is an extensive sacred scripture comprising approximately 55,000 slokas and 628 chapters (*adhyayas*). The Padma Purana's greatness lies in its detailed exploration of dharma, devotion and divine glory.

At COP31, 'overshoot' narrative cannot replace climate action

No COP decision has referred to the quantitative value of the total or remaining carbon budget nor has it discussed which countries have spent it the most; if COP31 is to deliver real impetus to climate action, it must focus on accountability for emissions and the fulfilment of finance commitments

Ankita Ranjan
Tejal Kanitkar



The focus on creating narratives and coining buzzwords has obscured legitimate scientific discussions at successive COPs. AFP

The 31st Conference of the Parties to the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP31) kicked off in Antalya, Turkiye, on Monday, in a year marked by extreme weather events, terrible human tragedy, as well as a severe energy crisis entered its final stretch. It is also the year in which the world is preparing to officially accept that we will exceed a warming level of 1.5 degrees Celsius.

The natural corollary to this unassailable reality is that countries should strive to collectively limit warming to as little over 1.5 degrees Celsius, and as below 2 degrees, as possible. This requires scientific discussions, assessment of options, and a critical analysis of the trade-offs. However, what we have instead is another buzz word: "overshoot".

Overshooting something is typically taken to mean passing swiftly (or mistakenly) past an intended point. But in the case of "1.5 degrees Celsius overshoot", it means passing the point in the near term and returning to it by the end of this century.

The term emerged in the climate modelling literature and countries are now seamlessly importing it into political discussions to ensure that the 1.5-degree target remains perpetually alive, at least on paper if not in reality. And just as "net-zero" was the flavour of the COP26 summit in Glasgow, "overshoot" is likely to be the flavour at COP31 – and could once more help some countries avoid the real issues.

Unmet obligations

The years since the Paris Agreement came into effect have passed in a flurry of ambitious discourse, including terms like "net-zero targets", "keeping 1.5 degrees alive", and "transitioning away from fossil fuels".

But in stark contrast is the real action by countries most responsible for climate change as well as which are the most economically developed. In 2025, fossil fuels still accounted for about 83% and 73% of primary energy use in the U.S. and the European Union respectively. Having exited the Paris Agreement twice, the U.S. has proposed opening nearly 1.3 billion acres of its waters to offshore drilling. Norway has offered 70 new oil and gas exploration blocks, including in the Arctic, while the United Kingdom has approved the Jackdaw gas field. Germany and the Netherlands have likewise cleared gas drilling near the Wadden Sea, a UNESCO World Heritage site. Australia, which will preside over the COP31 negotiations, has itself approved 37 fossil fuel projects since 2022.

In the same vein, the low ambition on climate finance is being outdone only by its even poorer delivery, with some governments even cutting down on what they have pledged. Developed countries reported mobilising around $137 billion in climate finance in 2024. However, its true value has been estimated to be only $33-45 billion, with 65% of public finance provided as loans. The U.S. has since also rescinded $4 billion in pledges to the Green Climate Fund while the U.K. has almost halved its contribution.

Adaptation finance also fell to $26 billion in 2023, against a need of at least $310-365 billion every year by 2035.

Further, unilateral trade measures such as the EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) target iron, steel, cement and aluminium – sectors central to industrial development. In effect, the economically developed countries are backtracking on their own obligations as well as penalising the industrialisation the Global South needs.

The narrative of "overshoot" will only deepen this imbalance because the promise of a future decline in global warming rests on uncertain science as much as on the land and resources of the Global South.

Inequity of overshoot

The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) recently released a report titled *Limiting Overshoot: Navigating Exceedance of 1.5 degrees Celsius and Pathways towards Return*. It discussed the immense scale of net-negative emissions required to keep the earth's average surface temperature from warming by more than 1.5 degrees Celsius. The report found that reversing just 0.1 degrees of warming would require countries to permanently remove 220 billion tonnes of carbon dioxide (CO_2) from the atmosphere – a quantity that the world currently emits – in five years.

The world removes about 2.2 billion tonnes of CO_2 annually, almost entirely through forests and soils, while direct air capture barely removes 2 million tonnes, and scaling it up could still impose a cost of $600 per tonne of CO_2 removed. Also, removing a tonne of CO_2 may not undo the warming caused by emitting it, at the same rate or in the same proportion.

However, the UNEP report is silent on who should undertake and pay for these removals and on whose land they will happen. National pledges already rely on nearly 1.2 billion hectares of land for CO_2 removal – most of which is located in the Global South.

Rich countries are also already outsourcing their mitigation obligations. Switzerland, for example, plans to meet up to one-third of its 2030 target by purchasing credits from projects abroad, including through cookstoves in rural Ghana, whereas its own emissions were only 22% below 1990 levels in 2024 against a 50% target by 2030. In the U.S., an oil company selected for federal funding for a direct air capture hub has described the technology as giving the industry "a license to continue to operate for 60, 70, 80 years" more.

Without clearly allocating responsibility, the "overshoot" narrative will turn the land that the Global South needs for food, livelihoods, and development into sinks for the excess emissions of the Global North.

Back to basics

The focus on creating narratives and coining buzzwords has obscured legitimate scientific discussions at successive COPs.

No COP decision has referred to the quantitative value of the total or remaining carbon budget nor has discussed which countries have spent it the most. If COP31 is to deliver real impetus to climate action, its decisions must revert to the basics.

The first is immediate, deep, and sustained mitigation by the developed countries. Given their historical overuse of the carbon budget, developed countries must reach net-zero well before 2050 and achieve net-negative emissions within their own borders. They must not bank on the forests still standing in developing countries to continue to be net-positive emitters.

Second, developing countries urgently need predictable, grant-based public finance from developed countries. They do not need loans or private investments. The Climate Finance Work Programme agreed at Belém, in Brazil, last year must take shape in Antalya this year and provide clear political guidance on implementing Article 9.1 of the Paris Agreement: on the obligation of developed countries to finance climate adaptation and mitigation in developing countries.

Country representatives at the summit must also discuss, frankly, the intellectual property and other barriers that result in technology being sold at premiums rather than being transferred.

Finally, any discussion of "overshoot pathways" must clearly explain the term as well as acknowledge the associated carbon budget, historical emissions, scientific uncertainties, feasibility constraints, and consequences on livelihoods, food security, biodiversity, and indigenous communities.

The world needs scientific, equitable, and fair climate action – not rhetoric.

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Some predators, such as killer whales, suffered impairment in prey detection because of marine noise pollution. GETTY IMAGES

A noisy Anthropocene is imposing fatal stress on wildlife

Divya Gandhi

The Anthropocene, the epoch of sweeping human-dominated planetary change, has ushered in an understudied phenomenon: extreme noise pollution. And the polluted soundscape is not just a human health hazard, but impacts the dynamics of wildlife too, physiologically, developmentally and behaviourally, found a new study published in *Science*.

The din of traffic, industrial activity, offshore construction, petroleum exploration, sonar operations and multiple other sources of noise, which has consistently increased during the past 50 years, affects over a 100 aquatic and terrestrial species, said the paper.

Researchers analysed over 200 experimental studies on 177 aquatic and terrestrial species across six continents and found that noise altered specific traits in 80% of the animals studied. These included everything from a decline in fitness and abundance to disruptions of predator-prey interactions. Mortality among many animals increased by a staggering 138%.

Species were found to change their behaviour in response to noise is several ways. This included an increase in 'antipredator behaviour' or the ability to ward off prey. As a result, predators suffered around a 25% decrease in hunting success despite increasing their hunting effort by over 150 %.

"In other words, they expended 2.5 times as much effort while catching 25% less prey," said the paper. Some predators, such as killer whales, suffered impairment in prey detection because of marine noise pollution.

Anthrophony in the ocean

The marine world is especially vulnerable to noise pollution as sound travels faster and farther in water than in air. A 2021 paper in *Science* said that marine organisms, from invertebrates to great whales have evolved to rely on sound to "interpret and explore the marine environment and to interact within and among species." But shipping, resource exploration, and infrastructure development have increased the 'anthrophony' (sounds generated by human activities), and in extreme cases, compromise the very survival of marine life forms, said the reseacrhers.

As for parental care among wild species, the new paper finds that while some species, such as those among birds, "compensated" for the changed soundscape by increasing care, which raised the weight of the offspring, others reduced care that led to a lower survival rate of the offspring.

Noise also interfered with internal homeostasis, or the biological process by which an organism maintains a stable internal environment. There was an activation of stress hormones and cellular damage among several species and also impaired immune function, changes in organs and specialised tissues. It impaired reflexive reactions, cognition and even sexual selection.

The paper reported a reduction in overall fitness by 27% "through both direct mortality and sublethal effects reducing survival."

Interestingly, there were some "winners" in the acoustic arms race too. For instance, some predators can "benefit when noise creates 'acoustic traps'," explained the paper: while "noise typically increases sheltering behavior, enclosed shelters amplify sound, forcing prey to escape to open areas where predation risk increases."

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Unconventional science prizes

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1
The X Prizes were established in 1991 to recognise research that first makes people laugh, then think. Its winners have investigated if cats behave like liquids, why wombats produce cube-shaped poop, and how slippery banana peels are. One of them is Andre Geim, who also won a Nobel Prize. Name X.

QUESTION 2
Like the X Prizes in Q1, the _____ _____ Award, has since 2012 celebrated research funded by the U.S. government that once appeared frivolous but eventually produced important benefits. Named for a Brothers Grimm fairy tale, it challenges politicians who do not appreciate that many discoveries often emerge from unexpected places. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 3
Name the international competition that challenges doctoral students to explain their theses with choreography instead of the usual presentations, with bonus marks for creativity. The 2026 winner was able to explain their work on piezoelectric polymers for wearable ultrasound devices.

QUESTION 4
The Y Award is a satirical prize presented by the group Australian Skeptics since 1982 to laud especially outrageous pseudoscientific claims. Past winners have included promoters of nonsensical medical treatments and UFO conspiracists. Name Y, derived from one supposed ability of psychics.

QUESTION 5
The Canadian-American magician _____ _____ created the Pigasus Award to recognise outrageous claims about paranormal phenomena. The winners are supposedly notified telepathically and are expected to explain whether they could predict their wins. They also win flying pigs as trophies, delivered with 'psychokinesis'. Fill in the blanks.

Please send in your answers to science@thehindu.co.in


Visual: Name this U.S. filmmaker. In 2012, he initiated the Flame Challenge where scientists are expected to explain difficult scientific concepts to 11-year-olds. The children then judge the explanations.
MOODY COLLEGE OF COMMUNICATION (CC BY-SA)

Answers to November 3 quiz:
1. Psychiatrist who described a disease in 1906 with August Deter – **Ans: Alois Alzheimer**
2. Distress signal established in 1906 by members of 27 countries – **Ans: SOS**
3. First animal virus to be crystallised, in 1955, by Schaffer and Schwerdt – **Ans: Poliovirus**
4. OS developed by team led by Ken Thompson, Dennis Ritchie – **Ans: Unix**
5. NASA mission to Mercury that provided first close-up pics of the surface – **Ans: Mariner 10**
Visual: **Laika**

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Cracker conundrum

Any regulation of crackers needs strict enforcement at all levels

The two Deepavali nights following the Supreme Court's (SC) temporary relaxation of the cracker ban, played out predictably. The Air Quality Index (AQI) in several north Indian cities – already 'poor' and 'very poor' in the first week of November – was 'severe' on Diwali night. Several air sensors – maintained by various organisations – reported PM2.5 in Delhi and its outskirts, exceeding 1,000 by Diwali night. In this context, the SC's order last week regarding crackers bears revisiting. While stating it was aware of the consequences of emissions from crackers, the Court has been waiting for quantitative evidence on the health and environmental effects of emissions from Diwali celebrations. Such direct, causative evidence is almost impossible to furnish. Slackening winds and post-monsoon atmospheric dryness are known to trap the latent particulate matter from vehicles, industries, construction dust and stubble burning. Crackers are only an additional element that further degrades an already vitiated air. Delhi's five-day average AQI rose from approximately 298 before Diwali to 358 afterwards in 2024, 259 to 315 in 2025 and from 350 to 376 in 2026. While the timing of these spikes is consistent with a contribution from firecrackers, their precise share of overall pollution cannot be isolated from other emissions and meteorological influences. An absolute ban would encourage "illegal crackers from across the border," the Court was told. Cracker season begins a fortnight before Diwali and therefore an earlier decision by the Court regarding its permissibility would have given stockists time to better dispense 'green' crackers.

However, it is important to note that CSIR-NEERI, the developers of the products, underline that low-emission crackers – under stringent lab conditions – only reduce emissions by 30%-45%. These percentage reductions reveal nothing about gross particulate matter emissions. The post-Deepavali AQI is evidence of this. The Court acknowledges, but does not address, the immense implementation challenges in policing cracker sales and hyphenates crackers with religious observation but pays only lip service to provisions in the Constitution that say that religious customs cannot override considerations of health and life. Rather than wait for the week running up to Deepavali 2027, the Court must pronounce a final view on crackers and lay down the contours for the government to evolve a policy on limiting the manufacture, sale, and burning of crackers in a time-bound manner.

Point of no return

Without peace, Israel risks descending into chaos

Israeli President Isaac Herzog's decision to invite opposition leader Gadi Eisenkot to form the next government reflects the real mandate of the October 27 legislative elections. While Mr. Eisenkot's centrist Yashar party finished second with 21 seats, behind Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's Likud, which won 27, the former military chief, who campaigned on an anti-Netanyahu platform, has secured the support of 67 legislators in the 120-member Knesset. In Mr. Eisdenkot's own words, Israel risks "descending to dark places, to a point of no return". But it is not yet clear what kind of a government Mr. Eisenkot is seeking to form. The opposition parties are split between a Jewish-led bloc with 48 MKs and an Arab-led bloc of 19 MKs. Arab parties have offered in-principle support for Mr. Eisenkot to keep Mr. Netanyahu's right-religious coalition out of power. But what is not clear is whether they would be part of the government or offer outside support by allowing Mr. Eisenkot to run a minority government. Some of Mr. Eisenkot's Jewish right-wing allies, such as Avigdor Lieberman, are opposed to joining hands with Arab parties. Mr. Eisenkot has now called for a unity government, appealing even to Likud and the far-right Religious Zionism, to join him.

But the challenges facing Israel's next leader are formidable and immediate. Mr. Netanyahu's unchecked militarism has deepened Israel's international isolation, strained its relationship with the U.S., its most important patron and ally, and aggravated the security challenges it faces in its neighbourhood. At home, the surge of the far-right has further polarised society, while systemic violence against Palestinians has spread across the West Bank. Mr. Netanyahu's response to these challenges has been to unleash more violence, which has only compounded Israel's problems. If Mr. Eisenkot is serious about pulling Israel back from the point of no return, he must pursue a three-pronged approach. Firstly, he should form an Arab-Jewish unity government focused on healing the country's internal wounds and bridging gaps between communities. Second, Israel's deepening international isolation and increasingly negative public opinion around the world will begin to exact a heavy toll sooner rather than later. Tel Aviv must take urgent steps to restore its international standing. Third, Israel must reopen the path to peace. The new government should initiate negotiations with the Palestinians under international mediation, crack down on settler violence, pull back from Gaza and reaffirm its commitment to the two-state solution. Without peace, Israel risks continuing to "descend to dark places".

How students are the first line of resistance



N. Sai Balaji

Former AISA President and CPI(ML) activist

It would be a grievously wrong reading of the current national climate if one were to see the recent student protests as isolated incidents of resistance. Such a reading assumes that this movement is a temporary expression of dissatisfaction. It also assumes that it will eventually dissipate. The movement of today is built on the sediments of the grievances of the past, which were ignored and buried under layers of distortion.

The first section of society that recognises when democracy is under threat and stands up for it are always students. Almost a year after the Narendra Modi-led government first came to power in 2014, students of the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) went on a hunger strike for 139 days, opposing the appointment of Gajendra Chauhan as chairman of the institute. Mr. Chauhan's lack of academic credentials was made up for by his proximity to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

These protests, from June-October 2015, were the first act of resistance. The government responded by dismissing the protesters as anti-nationals, an overused *modus operandi* to counter any protest challenging the government. While Mr. Chauhan wasn't sacked, his tenure was cut short to 14 months. The government's victory was temporary.

Agitations of the past

Such grievances cannot be suppressed by distortion – a lesson that governments find hard to understand. If not addressed and resolved, they simply change shape and return in other forms; this is what we have seen time and again. The 'Occupy UGC' movement demanding the restoration and a hike of the non-NET fellowship; the 'Justice for Rohith Vemula' campaign; the protests against the manufactured sedition cases against students of Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU); the #WhereIsNajeeb movement; the anti-fee hike protests in various universities across the country, including Panjab University in Chandigarh, JNU and Delhi University; and the equal citizenship movement – all are examples of the same. Social and gender justice movements in India such as the 2012 Nirbhaya protests solidify the idea that the youth have the courage to mobilise, diagnose, and remedy society.

The COVID-19 pandemic and subsequent lockdowns witnessed a further attack on the integrity of educational systems. The government imposed the new National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 on students, teachers, and the academic community through a press conference. While the long-term consequences of this policy on the educational system are yet to be seen, issues have already begun to trickle in. Consolidation of power, centralisation of policy, and corruption are the essence of the system that NEP 2020 has built. Students, once again, were the first to resist this. The Jantar Mantar 1.0 movement was a testament to this resolve.

> In a country, and more broadly a society, that bleeds with hate, the youth continue to resist with humour and hope

Students also participated in the protests against the Unnao rape case, the Hathras gang rape, and the sexual harassment faced by wrestlers under the aegis of the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI). They continued to brave police brutality, arbitrary FIRs, and the persistent avoidance of the government in dealing with said issues. The entire country turned a blind eye to the brutality unleashed on students, consumed by the methodical madness of hate which has been moulded into acceptance by the 'Corporate Raj', that is, the Adani-Ambanification of India. Linguistic tools, therefore, were insufficient in resisting and challenging this juggernaut of fascist practices.

The sea of humanity that has turned up for the recent protests has been fed through the tributaries of agitations of the past; on the sediment of grievances that have settled over the years. It is ironic that a government that brags about and celebrates its role in the anti-Emergency protests has forgotten that it too began with a student movement against a fee hike in a university in Gujarat. It is presumptuous of the government to imagine that it is unique and will remain insulated from protests.

Different mode of protest

The political participation of Gen Z has brought a shift in how protests are carried out. Gen Z was a storm that rained memes and reels on the political landscape, with satire and non-conformity as a mode of politics; having fun was political resistance. The Jantar Mantar 1.0 movement isn't the first to witness this spirit. Since the post-COVID era, and especially during the third term of the Modi-led government, a brief survey of social media reveals that platforms such as Instagram and Reddit, along with youth-run YouTube channels, have become sites of resistance and challenge.

It is only natural that the social media-savvy Gen Z grew tired of the WhatsApp-forward drivel of older generations and brought its own rules of engagement with politics into the picture. For Gen Z, protests have become a site for content creation, and the police have become a destabilised collaborative figure in humorous reels, which reflects a refusal to fear the police state. Armed with a no-holds-barred approach, Gen Z has easily dismantled the curated PR caricatures political leaders had built of themselves with thousands of crores.

Interconnected struggles

A few political observers have said that the protests against electoral malpractices are not as emotive an issue as the anti-paper leak agitation. Again, this is an erroneous reading. The anti-SIR protests are yet another powerful turn in the student movement.

The youth have many grievances for which to hold the government accountable such as corporate monopoly over jobs, the rise of AI and its regulation, the government's withdrawal from the public sector, and the consequences of global conflict caused by the U.S.-Israel nexus. Free and fair elections are where they can act on their political aspirations and grievances. However, if the electoral system itself is broken and rigged, the youth can only rely on peaceful protests to seek accountability.

The government had given free rein to the police from day one. Those who opposed Mr. Chauhan and those who stood against former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan all faced lathis and FIRs. And now, peace bonds are being pushed on protesters to kill the democratic uprising. However, there is resistance here too; Neha Bora, AISA President, had recently refused to sign a peace bond, showing how resistance can turn into civil disobedience. To imagine that the government can, through brute force, slam the lid shut on protests is delusional. Let's not forget how the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967 has been weaponised to silence and jail student and pro-democracy activists.

By denotifying Jantar Mantar as a site of protest, the Modi-led government has denotified democracy. The only course to reclaim this is for India as a whole to become Jantar Mantar through peaceful protests. The protests across various campuses in India demanding the restoration of student union elections are a step towards rebuilding democracy that was destroyed over years of anti-democratic consolidation in our institutions.

In a country, and more broadly a society, that bleeds with hate, the youth continue to resist with humour and hope. You will find the youth protesting, and you will find them in reels. The youth refuse to give up on either of these spaces, displaying the public conscience in ways we never imagined. They are the public health centres of democracy; they diagnose threats and build resistance from the first instance. The responsibility to strengthen this fight falls on other sections of society. The process for democratic restoration has just begun.

A case for Nepal: suing major carbon emitters for floods



Manoj Kumar Sinha

V-C of Dharmasashtra National Law University, and president of Indian Society of International Law (ISIL)



Anwar Sadat

Associate Professor in international environmental law at ISIL

The catastrophic floods in Nepal which resulted in the deaths of thousands of people in August 2026, is overwhelmingly attributed to climate change. This is yet another worst-case climate change scenario from South Asia, after the floods in Pakistan in 2022.

A debate that has not drawn much attention so far in this part of the world is that there is scope to explore and establish the flood victims as victims of climate wrongs. The case for the Nepalese people needs to be analysed from the prism of climate litigations used by plaintiffs in many jurisdictions of Europe and the U.S. in the last two decades.

These plaintiffs, who were exposed to climate-related risks, have brought claims against state and private corporations on the ground of serious risks to life, well-being, health, property, privacy and disruption of family life. Though the plaintiffs have not turned out to be winners in these proceedings every time, the challenge itself has been eye-opening.

Legal reasoning

In a strict legal sense, it is extremely difficult to establish causation between a defendant's (such as a state or private corporation living miles away) failure to take appropriate measures restricting the emission of Greenhouse Gases (GHG) and the flood victims in those districts of Nepal bordering Tibet.

While climate wrongs harm society, they do not harm specific individuals or a group of individuals in a sufficiently direct and proximate way. The logic that is widely accepted now is that the failure to take appropriate measures by an entity makes an incremental contribution to global cumulative GHGs, which diffuse and leave global and lingering effects on the likelihood of adverse physical events. The impact of such events is itself dependent on extraneous factors such as exposure, vulnerability and resilience.

> While climate wrongs harm society, they do not harm individuals in a sufficiently direct and proximate way

The identification of the victims exposed to risks in contrast to the 'general' population is needed to describe that specific group as victims of climate change. This gives them the standing to sue – to justify their invocation of individual or group rights and consider claims for compensation.

The people living in the Tibet-Nepal border area, specifically those living in the Trishuli and Bhote Koshi river basins area of Nepal, have been exposed to Glacial Lake Outburst Floods (GLOFs) over the last three decades. Scholarship focusing on the Tibetan Autonomous Region is of the view that since 2010 both the area and the number of glaciers is retreating at a faster rate than before. Climate scientists predict that the mountain glaciers will lose most of their volume by the end of the 21st century, placing alpine ecosystems and human population at risk. These climate-linked physical events, which were present prior to the flood, could possibly fulfil the normative threshold of the imminence of a catastrophe.

Holding emitters accountable

The case that merits attention in this context is the *Lliyua vs RWE* case which established that it is possible to causally link the GHG emissions of one large emitter to a concrete risk of life and property in a country that is 5,000 miles away. In the case, Lliyua, a Peruvian national, sued RWE (a German energy provider company headquartered in Germany) under a German private nuisance law on the ground that the company's past and present coal-fired power generation is responsible for huge quantities of CO_2, which reduced the stability of glaciers near his home.

In an important judgment, the Higher Court of Appeal in Hamm on May 28, 2025 ruled that RWE can be held legally responsible in principle, though the specific claim was dismissed due to inadequate proof of an imminent risk. The court accepted that past individual climate harms can proportionally contribute to climate risks and it also upheld that German civil law can apply to transboundary climate harms. This, in effect, amounts to saying that long distance and global scale do not automatically shield a corporation from liability.

In *Milieudefensie et al vs Royal Dutch Shell* (November, 2024), the Dutch Court of appeal confirmed under Dutch tort law principles that companies which contribute significantly to climate change and have it within their power to contribute to combating it, have an obligation, as per the general duty of care under Dutch law and human rights standards, to limit GHG emissions to counter climate change.

The climate lawsuit brought by four Indonesian islanders against Holcim, a Swiss building material giant, in the Swiss Cantonal Court of Zug (*Asmania vs Holcim*) is also quite relevant. Here, the plaintiffs sought a reduction of GHGs as well as compensation for present and future damages against Holcim's excessive CO_2 emissions.

Although there is no rule of binding precedent, it is still advisable for the flood victims of Nepal to use the channel of litigations against major GHG emitters, as there is growing judicial awareness of the duties owed by large emitters in responding to the threat of climate change.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Shocking development

Four retired judges resigning from the Bengal SIR tribunal (November 8 edition, 'Another retired judge resigns from Bengal SIR tribunal') comes in as seriously shocking news. It is time for serious action from the Centre and the Supreme Court. The image of the Election Commission has taken some serious beating and before the voter loses complete faith in the system, things need to be set straight. Earning the confidence of the common voter should be the top most priority. The Centre cannot just brush protests away as politically motivated.

Balasubramaniam Pavani
Secunderabad

Air quality decline

In spite of the Supreme Court's interventions, there has been no improvement in the air quality, especially in Delhi, and people continue to breathe poisonous and toxic air affecting their quality of life. Knee-jerk steps are not going to help improve the situation. A serious attempt to cleanse the air we breathe is a must, involving all the agencies responsible for monitoring the quality of air. The should be done all-year round and not when the situation gets out of control and panic sets in, which leads to just temporary measures. The issue must be tackled in a holistic manner.

V. Padmanabhan
Bengaluru

Shami's exit

The alleged discriminatory treatment meted out to Mohammed Shami by the Indian cricket selection committee is deeply disconcerting. A formidable match-winner, Shami has repeatedly exemplified extraordinary bowling prowess, unwavering perseverance, and patriotic commitment. His potential retirement from international cricket, reportedly precipitated by persistent neglect, would constitute an irreparable loss to Indian cricket. The selectors must be held accountable for decisions that appear to disregard merit and proven performance. The nation deserves a transparent, equitable, and performance-oriented selection policy that honours its sporting stalwarts.

Nagarajamani M.V.
Hyderabad

Moving portrait

The extract from Sonia Gandhi's memoir *Belonging-A journey of love* captures an important phase of her life that has been not only instrumental in changing the fortunes of the Congress Party but also the political landscape of India (Magazine, "Where I truly belong", November 8). Her reflections invite empathy, revealing how she assiduously embraced Indian values and genuinely came to belong to the nation.

Kosaraju Chandramouli
Hyderabad

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The next test for renewable energy



Arunabha Ghosh

is a globally recognised author, adviser and institution builder. He is founder of CEEW, COP30 Special Envoy, and Co-Chair, WEF Global Future Council on Energy Nexus. The views expressed are personal

Last week, India hosted the Bharat Renewable Energy Summit, celebrating India's double transition: near-universal household access to electricity and meeting surging power demand while building the world's third-largest renewable energy capacity. This week, Türkiye hosts COP31, with Australia holding the presidency of the climate negotiations. The COP31 hosts have proposed a global electrification target – 35 by 35 – seeking to raise electricity's share in final energy consumption to 35% globally by 2035.

Global energy transition

The reality is more nuanced. Global renewable energy capacity reached 5,149 GW in 2025. Last year alone, 692 GW were added, nearly 97% of it solar and wind. But the goal of tripling renewable energy capacity by 2030 remains far out on the horizon. The deployment of renewables is also uneven. China accounted for nearly two-thirds of last year's deployment; Africa only 1.6%. About 560 million people in Sub-Saharan Africa have no electricity.

Since 2020, there has been about 80% growth in renewable energy capacity. Renewables are now the default expectation in energy planning. But the question has flipped: from whether renewables make economic sense to whether the energy system can absorb them at scale.

Three challenges explain the gap between ambition and reality. One, grids and markets built for centralised fossil fuel plants cannot move cheap power to those who need it. Two, intellectual property and supply chains for cleantech sit in a few hands, raising energy security concerns. Three, a surge in AI-driven power demand is colliding with limits on energy, water and climate.

The global energy transition needs a new mantra: make renewables reliable, secure and digital.

Reliable renewables

Reliable means paying for what the system needs. India's installed battery storage stood at only about 9 GWh in mid-2026, most of it added in the first half of this year. Most contracts still pay for energy delivered, not for flexibility, reliability or dispatchability. The risk is cheap capacity that cannot be fully used, with the costs landing on distribution companies and consumers.

The fixes are unglamorous but decisive. Move beyond 25-year contracts towards real-time trading and contracts for difference. Run technology-agnostic auctions on integrated system plans. Cut permitting delays and grid-connection queues.

The International Renewable Energy Agency estimates that global grid investment must roughly double, from about $0.5 trillion a year to about $1 trillion. Recognising the need, India recently approved about $19 billion for State transmission and 50 GWh of battery storage, enabling up to 135 GW of renewable energy to be evacuated by 2032-33.

Secure means a transition that eases energy security concerns rather than worsening them. Energy security is the argument that wins support for renewables in most capitals; it will be lost if clean energy merely swaps one dependency for another. According to the International Energy Agency, cleantech manufacturing investment is dominated by China (70%).

India has begun to respond. Its solar module manufacturing capacity has reached about 262 GW; for solar cells, capacity has jumped to about 37 GW. Its National Critical Minerals Mission and Green Hydrogen Mission aim to increase mineral processing and electrolyser manufacturing. But no country can copy another's model. Multilateral institutions should offer a menu of options, matched to each country's starting point to build local manufacturing, resilient supply chains and skills pipelines.

Digital means guiding the frontier rather than reacting to it. Smart meters can act as the nervous system of a digital grid. India has already deployed about 54 million smart meters. This enables more grid-edge technologies, including storage solutions, software for optimising energy flow, and even a digital public infrastructure for energy.

Further, AI can forecast renewable output, optimise grids and unlock flexibility markets. Data-centre electricity use is set to rise from roughly 485 TWh to 950 TWh by 2030, from about 1.5 to 3% of global demand, and annual water consumption could more than double.

Large new loads should be sited using forward-looking heat and water-stress data. Data centres should disclose their power, water and carbon intensity, making resource efficiency a condition of viability, not an afterthought.

India has installed about 308 GW of non-fossil capacity. Crossing 500 GW will be a milestone for India, not the finish line. The real test is whether every unit generated is dispatched, every consumer benefits, and every manufacturer and young worker has a place in the new system. Cheap renewables made the transition possible. Reliable, secure and digital systems will make it real.

India has installed about 308 GW of non-fossil capacity. Crossing 500 GW will be a milestone for India, not the finish line

Building over Srinagar's future



Tikender Singh Panwar

is an author, urban practitioner, and former Deputy Mayor, Shimla. He was also a member of the Kerala Urban Commission

Two conversations about the Himalayas are running at the same time, and they are not converging. Everyone agrees that mountain towns are reaching their limits in different ways. No hill town should approve large construction before measuring what it can carry. Yet the developmental model is running parallel. Recent notifications and bills in Jammu and Kashmir are making it easier to build more, on more land. Srinagar is being overwhelmed by that.

Let us start with a simple idea. Floor Area Ratio (FAR) determines how much floor space can be built on a plot. On a 100-square-metre plot, an FAR of 200% allows 200 square metres of floor space. When the number is raised, the same plot must hold more people, cars, toilets, drains, etc. Over nine months, the rules have been repeatedly changed. The building by-laws were amended on December 1, 2025. On July 24, 2026, they were extended to Housing Board colonies, with additional FAR and reduced setbacks. On September 9, fresh limits were proposed, including an FAR of 300% for commercial complexes. On September 28, the Ease of Doing Business Bill, 2026, was tabled. In the first week of October, the Lieutenant Governor gave his assent, and the Bill became law.

At first glance, this sounds robust. But read what else the Act does. Residential buildings up to 24 metres tall, about eight storeys, with a floor area of 5,000 square metres can be built outside FAR and ground coverage limits, based on a third-party certificate. Malls of the same size need no government approval. Agricultural and horticultural land is opened up for construction, with only red- and orange-category industries barred. Section 22 allows an executive committee to relax Master Plan conditions for individual enterprises. In plain terms: buildings can rise tall and wide on farmland, while a committee decides the exceptions. Deciding what can be built, where, and to what height is part of the planning process. This Act juxtaposes over planning, reducing it to meaningless proportions.

Srinagar already has a plan. The Master Plan-2035, approved in February 2019, covers 766 square kilometres and a projected 3.5 million people. It identifies wetlands and flood basins as areas at risk. A master plan is a city's promise to itself. Allowing a committee to waive its provisions rewrites that promise. Iftikhar Ahmad Hakim, the former Chief Town Planner, says the law was passed without public consultation. In the past, government housing projects were halted over liquefaction risks, and a 2026 study of 87 wards found high to severe susceptibility along the Jhelum. He warns that eight-storey buildings will further increase the city's vulnerability. A recent study shows that Srinagar's farmland has shrunk from 142 square kilometres in 1992 to about 66 by 2024. Marshland, the city's sponge, declined from over 1,100 hectares to just 283 hectares – a loss of over 70%. Two Ramsar wetlands, Hokersar and Shallabugh, lie nearby. Opening farmland to commercial building and wetlands for real estate development will reduce the city's capacity to absorb floodwaters.

The Smart City Mission ended in March 2025. In Srinagar, it was run by a company and funds were spent on projects that did not adequately address local needs. The Comptroller and Auditor General of India found that Srinagar has no separate networks for sewage and stormwater. It also found that 49 pumping stations, built at a cost of ₹124 crore, spend much of the year pumping sewage into water bodies. A study published in the journal *Water* estimates that of the 201 million litres of sewage produced daily, about 147 million reach the Dal Lake and the Jhelum untreated. This is the problem with running a city through a company: no one is answerable. The Smart City mission forgot that water gives Srinagar its identity.

The Srinagar Municipal Corporation's term ended on November 5, 2023. There is still no elected mayor or councillor. The Bill was moved by an elected Chief Minister. The 74th Constitutional Amendment lists urban planning and the regulation of land use and buildings among municipal functions. In Srinagar, these responsibilities sit with officers, authorities, and a Smart City company. A city without a council is a city without a defence.

The way forward

Suspend the FAR and land-use exemptions, along with Section 22, until they are brought within the Master Plan framework and subjected to public objections. Hold municipal elections now, and make the councillors the first readers of every proposed change to the plan. Approve no large construction without a published carrying-capacity assessment that counts water, slopes, drains and wetlands. Single-window clearances are welcome, as are quicker permits. But no Himalayan city can be given the freedom to build anywhere. Let citizens speak before its ground does.

Suspend the FAR and land-use exemptions, along with Section 22, until they are brought within the Master Plan framework and subjected to public objections

Anuj Shrivatri completes India's century of Grandmasters

Shrivatri becomes the first Grandmaster from Madhya Pradesh, while T.N. continues to lead the country's tally, accounting for 38% of India's Grandmasters

DATA POINT

Devyanshi Bihani
Srinivasan Ramani

Anuj Shrivatri became India's 100th Grandmaster on Sunday, winning the 7th ASEAN+ Individual Open Chess Championship in Ozamiz City, the Philippines. The 22-year-old won the tournament with seven points from nine rounds, earning the title after completing the requirements.

Shrivatri, who hails from Katni in Madhya Pradesh, has achieved a double milestone: he is the first Grandmaster from his State and the latest to join India's growing list of 100. His achievement adds Madhya Pradesh to a list dominated by a handful of established centres.

Tamil Nadu leads the way, accounting for 38 of India's 100 Grandmasters. The State's legacy is closely linked to Viswanathan Anand, who became India's first Grandmaster in 1988 and put the country on the international chess map. Chennai has remained a key centre of the game since. Maharashtra (14) and West Bengal (12) follow Tamil Nadu, while Delhi has produced eight Grandmasters and Andhra Pradesh seven **(Map 1)**.

From Anand becoming the first Grandmaster in 1988, it took the country 14 years to produce its first five. The numbers began to gather pace in the 2000s, rising from one in 1988 to 23 in 2010 and 67 in 2020. India added 33 Grandmasters between 2010 and 2020, nearly three times the 12 added in the preceding decade.

The growth has been even more pronounced in recent years. From 44 Grandmasters in 2016, India's tally rose to 100 in 2026, with 56 players earning the title in the intervening decade. The country crossed the 50-mark in 2017 and reached 90 in 2025.

The year-on-year additions, however, have fluctuated. After producing 10 Grandmasters in 2019, India added just two in 2020, during the COVID-19 pandemic. The annual count rose to five each in 2021 and 2022, and seven in 2023, before dropping to one in 2024. The pace picked up again, with five additions in 2025 and 10 in 2026 **(Chart 1)**.

The average age of India's new Grandmasters has generally trended lower over the years. The average stood at 38 in 1997, which fell to 15 in both 2001 and 2002. More recently, it dropped to 16.6 in 2022, before rising to 20.4 in 2023 and 32 in 2024. In 2026, the average age was 19.9 **(Chart 2)**.

The annual averages also need to be viewed alongside the number of Grandmasters added each year. In 1997, 2001, 2002 and 2024, India added just one Grandmaster, making the annual average the age of that individual. By contrast, 10 players earned the title in 2026, bringing the average age to 19.9. Smaller cohorts can therefore cause sharp year-to-year fluctuations, so the averages are better read as an indication of the broader trend than as evidence of a steady decline.

India's presence among the countries with the highest number of Grandmasters is matched by the strength of its leading players. It ranks fourth in the number of registered Grandmasters, behind Russia, the United States and Germany.

The comparison of the average Standard ratings of the top 10 players in each country places India second, at 2,706, just behind the U.S. (2,719). China follows at 2,663, while France and Russia have averages of 2,632 and 2,638, respectively **(Chart 3)**.

The country-wise comparison also distinguishes between the total number of players who have achieved the GM title and those registered in the FIDE count. For India, the corresponding figures are 100 and 97, respectively. The remaining three are yet to be included in its official count.

The century club

The data for the charts were sourced from the International Chess Federation, commonly referred to by its French acronym FIDE, and the All India Chess Federation, which is the administrative body for the game of chess in India



MAP 1: State-wise distribution of Grandmasters
Tamil Nadu accounts for 38 of India's 100 Grandmasters. The State produced Vishwanathan Anand, who became India's first Grandmaster in 1988

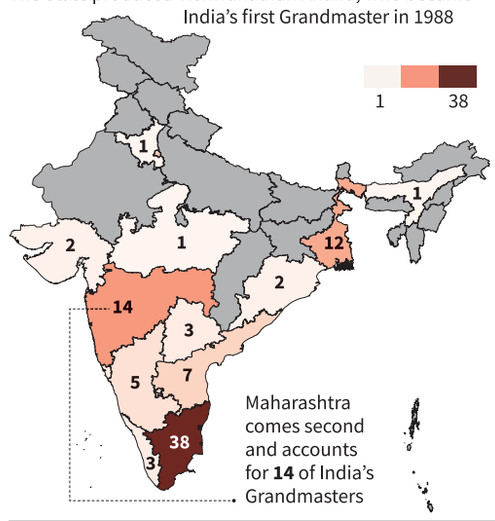


CHART 1: India's growing tally of Grandmasters
India's Grandmaster tally rose to 100 in 2026, with 56 players earning the title in the last ten years

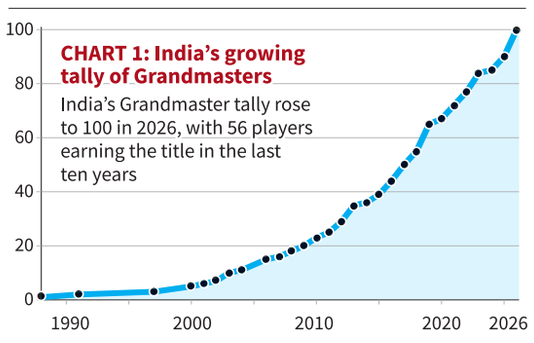


CHART 2: Average age of India's Grandmasters from 1988 to 2026
Smaller cohorts can cause sharp year-to-year fluctuations

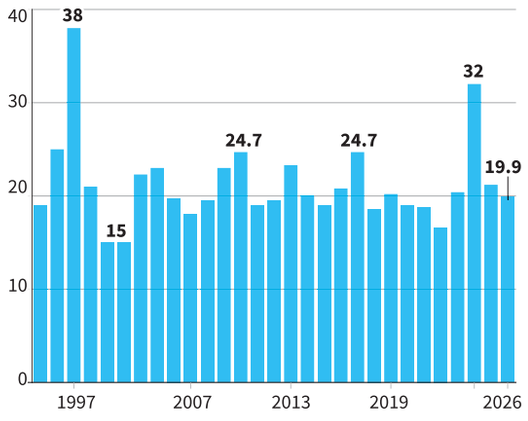


TABLE 1: The 10 countries with the highest number of registered Grandmasters (GMs). Note: GM counts are based on FIDE's official register as of November 7

Federation	Number of GMs	Average rating of top 10 GMs
Russia	184	2638
United States	115	2719
Germany	103	2630
India	**97**	**2706**
Ukraine	85	2625
France	60	2632
Spain	60	2600
Serbia	58	2549
China	57	2663
Poland	56	2590

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 10, 1976

Power struggle in China had begun 2 years ago

Tokyo, November 9: Though the ouster from power of the four Shanghai radicals, led by Mao Tse-tung's widow, Chiang Ching, became known to the outside world only last month, an acute power struggle within the Chinese Communist Party had been going on for nearly two years with Chairman Mao himself ranged against the gang of four, as they have now come to be known. Some light on this hitherto hidden aspect has been thrown by an editorial carried by the Liberation Army Daily, official organ of the People's Liberation Army.

According to the editorial, the gang of four had been engaging over a period of time. Mao, however, saw through the plot and made it impossible for their schemes to be achieved.

As long ago as before the fourth National People's Congress in January last year, the gang of four went in for conspiratorial activities to usurp power in a big way. After Premier Chou En-lai's death early this year, the four tried their best to push their person into the post of Premier. The editorial did not clarify who this person was. However, Mao "absolutely" refused to give the power to them and he personally proposed Mr. Hua Kuo-feng for acting Premiership. To block their intrigues, Mao himself further proposed that Mr. Hua be the first Vice-Chairman of the party Central Committee and Premier of the State Council. Not long after this, Mao wrote to Mr. Hua in his own handwriting saying, "With you in charge, I am at ease". Thus, Mr. Hua's position as successor to Mao was established and the plots of the gang of four to usurp party and State power were completely routed. It was after this acute struggle that Mr. Hua became leader of the party.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 10, 1926

Italy's speechless Parliament

Rome, November 9: It will be a speechless parliament which opens today since, by the request of Sgr. Mussolini, no speeches will be made. The Chamber will simply vote the new laws. Although the Fascist Secretary-General, Sgr. Farinacci, had lodged a motion expelling 102 Aventine or opposition deputies, most of them have deliberately absented themselves since their election. A few others have been forcibly expelled whenever they have attended.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Tonnes of firecracker waste cleared by the GCC after Deepavali

400 The Greater Chennai Corporation said on Monday that it had cleared around 400 tonnes of firecracker waste from across the city since Deepavali, with another 200 tonnes expected to be removed in the coming days. To speed up the clean-up, the civic body has deployed an additional 600 sanitation workers. PTI

Housing blocks mapped using special software for Census

24.25 in lakhs. The Registrar General of India has mapped 24.25 lakh Houselisting Blocks, using a special software developed for the purpose, an official communique said. The Houselisting Operation was successfully completed across the States and Union Territories, except Manipur. PTI

Value of crystal meth seized by authorities in Kenya

27 in $ million. Kenyan authorities have seized 454 kilograms of crystal methamphetamine worth $27 million in a multi-agency operation, the police said Monday. Kenya has long served as a transit route for narcotics because of its strategic location next to the Indian Ocean, and has stepped up efforts to combat drug trafficking. AFP

Number of deaths in migrant boat capsize in Senegal

39 This was one of two accidents involving migrants in boats over the weekend that left at least 56 people dead, the International Organisation for Migration said. The Senegalese boat was following a well-travelled migration route used by thousands of young Senegalese seeking a better life abroad. PTI

Burn injuries reported in major hospitals in Delhi post-Diwali

397 The extent of burn injuries ranged from 1 to 2 per cent to as high as 65 per cent of the body surface area, Sameek Bhattacharya, professor and head of burns and plastic surgery, said. The majority of those affected were children and young adults. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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How AI is reshaping China's universities

AI disruption and a tightening job market are driving a sweeping change across China's universities; under the government's 'guideline on the reform of higher education institutions', universities will now be tasked with specific goals, pursuing either research, application-oriented objectives, or skills development

WORLD INSIGHT

Ananth Krishnan

The story so far:
In September 2026, China's government unveiled an ambitious 10-year plan to reform its universities. Driving the change is an increasingly challenging job market for the country's close to 13 million college graduates, who are facing the twin disruptions of AI and a slowing economy. Under the plan, dozens of graduate programmes are being disbanded, while universities themselves will be categorised and tasked with either pursuing research, applications or skills developments.

What is driving education overhaul?
A combination of factors, some not too dissimilar to the current challenges in India's own job market, has left policymakers grappling with a tepid job market and a vast number of graduates facing dim job prospects. Top of the list is a mismatch in skills between graduates and what companies are seeking. Depressed economic sentiment has also led companies to cut back on hiring, with the prolonged structural slowdown in the real estate market dragging down growth. AI is the third disruptive force, changing rapidly how the marketplace views and values skills.

One in five young Chinese is unemployed. According to data from China's National Bureau of Statistics in September, the jobless rate in the 16-24 age group (excluding students) was 18.9% in August, up from 17.9% in July.

How will the plan change higher education in China?
The Chinese government's "guideline on the reform of higher education institutions", released in September 2026, calls for universities "to pursue distinct development paths" and "foster new forms of integrated education to explore innovative approaches to nurturing top talent."



The government's guideline directs universities to 'pursue distinct development paths'. GETTY IMAGES

The main objective is differentiation. Universities will now be tasked with specific goals, pursuing either research, application-oriented objectives, or skills development.

China has more than 3,000 higher education institutions. Each of these will now be slotted into one of the three categories: research, applications or skills.

The problem of too many universities offering similar programmes and producing too many of the same kind of graduates has been cited as a major reason for differentiation. The disruption in the job market from AI, which is already widely being integrated across different industries in China, is another.

At the top end of the pyramid, the country's top research universities will be freed up to focus on, as the guideline says, "driving major breakthroughs in science and technology".
Application-oriented institutions will be tasked with emphasising "practice-oriented talent, industry-education integration, technological innovation and research commercialisation." Finally, the institutions aimed at developing skills will "serve as a mainstay for cultivating master craftsmen and highly skilled professionals, with a focus on employment-oriented training and support for the development of a modern industrial system."

Liu Zhentian, an expert on China's education system at Xiamen University, described the objective as not aimed at "labelling universities" but, as he told official media, "creating a rational division of functions among higher education institutions and their respective missions".

How will this impact students and how has the plan been received?
The restructuring will be implemented in the current Fifteenth Five-Year Plan (2026-2030) and completed by the end of the Sixteenth Plan (2031-2035), by when the goal is to establish China as a "leading nation" in education. China in 2024 launched an 11-year master plan on "building China into a leading country in education" by 2035.

Besides reorganising the roles of universities, the degree programmes within each university are also in the midst of a major adjustment. The Ministry of Education said last year that in the four-year period leading up to 2025, as high as 30 per cent of the degree programmes offered at Chinese universities had been reshuffled, with 10,200 new degree programmes added while 12,200 were cancelled.

A focus of additions has been AI, semiconductors, robotics and advanced manufacturing, while many of the deletions are in the humanities or in programmes related to streams such as interpretation, that have been impacted by AI.

The deletions have divided opinion. The Communication University of China, a leading university in Beijing related to the arts, said it had suspended more than a dozen tracks including translation, sociology and photography. It also scaled back its journalism programme – one of the largest in China – and is reviewing the dozens of degrees it had previously awarded in interpretation and foreign languages. The university will no longer offer five degrees in the arts, including photography, visual communication design and fashion design, while it introduced new undergraduate programmes including intelligent audiovisual engineering.

The decision sparked widespread debate in China, given that the university has produced some of the country's best known journalists and foreign language scholars. It will soon no longer be training students in those disciplines. Universities are also scaling back programmes such as accounting and some elements of computing that are being rendered irrelevant by AI.

The response has been mixed. Some lament what they see as the death of humanities and liberal arts, and a pivot away from focusing on a foundation for educating students in critical thinking, viewing the transformation as being too focused on the short-term instead of considering longer term consequences. Others argue that change is inevitable, and the phasing out of disciplines is a necessary response to technological disruption. "We all sighed at the news, but there weren't any strong emotions," a photography student told the Chinese publication Sixth Tone. "For me, using AI is simply switching to another creative medium or tool. What matters more is my own thinking."

THE GIST

- In September 2026, China unveiled an ambitious 10-year plan to reform its universities, driven by an increasingly challenging job market for the country's nearly 13 million college graduates
- The restructuring will be implemented during the current 15th Five-Year Plan (2026–2030) and completed by the end of the 16th Plan (2031–2035), with the goal of making China a "leading nation" in education

How did a bank collapse bring down Paraguay's President?

How did the bank's collapse affect customers? How is President Santiago Pena linked to the bank?

WORLD INSIGHT

Mohammed Hidhayat

The story so far:
Following impeachment proceedings initiated against the country's President Santiago Pena, Paraguay's Senate voted to remove him for misconduct in office and placed him under house arrest on November 7. Subsequently, Vice-President Pedro Alliana was sworn in as interim President. Both Mr. Alliana and Mr. Pena belong to the Colorado Party.

The development comes just days after Mr. Pena announced his resignation amid a financial crisis triggered by the collapse of Ueno, a prominent digital lender-turned-bank that catered to nearly half the population. Millions of customers, abruptly, lost access to their savings accounts and pension payments after regulators seized the bank on November 3, setting off a sequence of events that culminated in a change of political leadership.

Why did the Central bank step in?
Banco Central del Paraguay (BCP), the top monetary authority in the South American country, initiated a resolution process after Ueno's solvency ratio fell below half the legal minimum. Solvency measures whether a bank has enough capital to absorb losses. The resolution process adopted by the Central bank is different from bankruptcy. It allows regulators to assess the bank's assets, transfer deposits to other financial institutions, and liquidate remaining assets if needed.

This led to the freeze of the savings of nearly three million customers and hundreds of millions of dollars in public pension money.

Reports in Paraguayan media have alleged that Ueno repeatedly gave loans to companies tied to the bank's owners. Some of these loans reportedly exceeded legal limits and lacked collateral. When adjustments were made to the bank's financial statements, its capital position was found to be substantially weaker than previously indicated.

Questions have arisen over whether Ueno was shielded from regulatory oversight due to its government connections. Mr. Pena has been linked to bank's parent company and is alleged to have used his political influence to steer public funds into Ueno.

He had previously held a stake in Ueno's parent company and appointed one, Carlos Carvallo to head the Central bank in 2023. Mr. Carvallo had previously run the finance company that would later become Ueno.

Is Ueno a traditional bank? What made it so popular?
Ueno can be best understood as a bank with a digital-first business model. Starting out as a small financial operation in the 1970s, it grew through acquisition, and rose to prominence only in recent years under the brand name Ueno after the financial institution was granted a license by the BCP to operate as a bank in 2023.

Apart from its flamboyant marketing – ranging from cashbacks at supermarkets to sponsoring the country's football team – local media reports note that Ueno made it easier to open a bank account and access banking services compared to its competitors. Buoyed by some $800 million in public money, Ueno became one of the largest banks in Paraguay in terms of number of depositors. It is said to have onboarded more than two-thirds of the country's adults into its banking services. The bank's website flaunts the tagline '2 out of 3 Paraguayans use Ueno' on its homepage, reflecting its claim of customer reach.

What happens to the money parked in the bank?
The bank reportedly held $800 million in public funds. A significant portion, about $350 million, belonged to Paraguay's Social Security Institute, the country's state pension and healthcare fund.

The main concern is whether the money can be recovered in full. Paraguay has a Deposit Guarantee Fund, which protects eligible depositors up to 75 monthly minimum wages. The fund insures up to about $36,000 per customer. The BCP says that covers the full balances of an estimated 97% of customers, but the timeline for distributing the funds is yet to be known. This protection applies to the combined deposits held by a customer at the bank, not separately to every account.

Some depositors said they have begun recovering their money since November 5, when the Central bank announced the first stage of guarantee payments.

Ousted President Pena had insisted, in a video address before his resignation, that public funds and citizens' savings must be protected. Mr. Pena's resignation had not been formally accepted earlier as lawmakers argued that a voluntarily departure would preserve his eligibility to become a Senator for life and shield him from prosecution under the country's law.

Although Ueno's failure has affected a significant section of the population, the Central Bank has described the episode as "an isolated institutional failure" rather than evidence of a systemic crisis in the country's banking sector. But it leaves a wider gap of confidence among takers for 'fintech' establishments.

CACHE

The journey towards integrating Tamil knowledge into AI platforms

The biggest challenge is to accurately represent Tamil's linguistic richness and cultural pluralism in AI, ensuring that it interprets the language's nuances and conveys the right meaning; this requires 'reliable, high-quality Tamil data that captures the language's depth and diversity'

T. Ramakrishnan

Tamil, as a language, is facing a situation in the era of Artificial Intelligence (AI) similar to what it faced about 25 years ago in the world of computing. At that time, when Tamil computing was nascent, experts engaged in a sustained campaign to promote the use of Tamil in computing and computers. Conferences and conclaves were held in different countries involving a cross-section of people. The process was not without hitches. Differences persisted in several aspects. To cite an example, experts and scholars were divided over the type of font to be used, as each font creator claimed superiority over the others. Gradually, such issues were resolved with the persistent efforts of academicians, including Anna University's former Vice Chancellor M. Anandakrishnan.



A new frontier: Tamil has more than 2,000 years of literary tradition, yet most commercial AI systems still regard it as a 'low-resource language'. GETTY IMAGES

Limited presence in AI tools

Today, more or less the same situation prevails. The language's richness and antiquity are posing "challenges", which may not exist in English. Many scholars and experts admitted to the limited presence of the language in AI tools at a recent four-day conference on classical Tamil and Tamils in Toronto. Former Vice Chancellor of Tamil University and current president of the 80-year-old Tamil Valarchi Kazhagam M. Rajendran, stresses the need to make the entire corpus of Tamil knowledge, including that found in inscriptions, available on AI platforms.

However, "AI learns only from what has been digitised in usable form. Tamil has more than two thousand years of literary tradition. Yet, in most commercial AI systems, it is still regarded as a "low-resource language," according to P. Kaliraj, former Vice-Chancellor of the Anna and Bharathiar Universities, who suggests that content be created; opened up; validated and used.

Passion for language is understandable but there are challenges that need to be overcome while making Tamil content available in great numbers. A.R.M. Imtiyaz, Affiliated Professor, South Asian Center, University of Pennsylvania, observes that the biggest challenge is the accurate representation of the linguistic richness and cultural pluralism of Tamil in AI. "It is not just enough to have an answer in Tamil but you need to properly blend the historical context, regional dialect, and cultural subtlety," he says.

In fact, for 10 years, Tamil has been there on different AI platforms and its content is quite useful for research, according to Nagarasa Iyer Subramaniyam, former Head of Tamil Department at the University of Jaffna, and Kawsalya Subramaniyam, Head, Faculty of Fine Arts, Canadian Tamil Academy, Toronto. However, the couple are quick to flag the issue of authenticity. They drive home the point that "the traditional practice of cross verification is absolutely essential, even as you use the modern, state of the art technology."

Dr. Kaliraj says current models make errors in Tamil grammar and can fabricate quotations. The solution is not to avoid AI, but to keep Tamil scholars in this process as validators. "In short, a language thrives only when it is present, in good quality, in the tools people use every day," he emphasises.

Rich variations

Variations in Tamil dialect are prevalent not only among Tamils living in different countries, such as Sri Lanka and Malaysia, but also within Tamil Nadu. One can find distinct dialects even within a district. S. Neelacantan, seasoned broadcaster who has digitised over 13,000 audio tapes, observes that "if you take Tamil Nadu, the language that is being spoken in areas bordering Andhra Pradesh is different from what is heard in areas bordering Keralam or Karnataka. You have poetry even in the dialect. The present challenge is how AI is going to provide the appropriate meaning, after understanding the nuances."

In fact, everyone, regardless of academic and professional backgrounds, insists that there must be "reliable, high-quality Tamil language data that captures the language's depth, diversity, and cultural nuances." If this is not ensured, there is every chance of AI misrepresenting the language and its heritage. At the same time, "we must also ensure that Tamil continues to develop beyond being a language of cultural identity, and remains a language of modern education, science, technology, and innovation," says Nimal Vinayagamoorthy, president of the Federation of Global Tamils (FGT), the moving spirit behind the Toronto meet. Efforts are on by different institutions to ensure that Tamil keeps pace with the growing demands of modern life. In the area of terminology, the "*Sol Puthithu*" programme, being run by the Tamil Valarchi Kazhagam, provides an environment for coining Tamil words that are equivalent to fresh terms thrown up by science, technology, sports and daily life, points out Dr. Kaliraj.

Though, relatively speaking, Tamil content is not as available as it should be, there is a view that the existing quantity of text data which is sizeable should first be consolidated. "Billions of tokens should be created as a minimum floor for text that is gathered from universities, the Tamil Virtual Academy, libraries, publishers and manuscript collections, rights-cleared, deduplicated, quality-audited and released under an open licence. Developing 5,000 hours of annotated speech is the real challenge: the individual open Tamil speech datasets, I am aware of, contain only tens to a few hundred hours," says Dr. Kaliraj.

Tamil content is available in other forms including audio tapes. "Apart from digitisation, the tapes involve many other tasks – improving audio quality and maintaining the authentic quality of an individual's voice. Eventually, you need to make such audio files appropriately available for the public use," says Mr. Neelacantan.

Avoiding human errors that normally creep in, while undertaking such tasks, is another thing that one has to keep in mind. Calling for developing common tests to evaluate the Tamil proficiency of the tools, Dr. Imtiyaz urges scholars and educators to work together to assess grammar, translation, cultural understanding, and factual accuracy.

Teaching the teachers

Amid the growing focus on AI and its application in everyday life, the role of Tamil teachers can hardly be missed. But it may appear that most teachers, who have been trained in traditional learning, may not be able to adapt themselves to the changing requirements. "If my interactions with the teachers or scholars, be they from India (Tamil Nadu), Sri Lanka and Canada, are any indication, they have started using them. I do not see any problem," says Dr. Nagarasa Iyer Subramaniyam. However, Dr. Rajendran concedes that some scholars have a problem in using the AI tools. Yet, he is hopeful that as scholars start realising that shunning the technology may lead to them being left out, they will embrace the change.

There is another position that underscores the importance of teachers, which is that they can never be replaced with AI. "You can integrate AI into existing teaching methods to make learning more interactive and engaging, particularly for younger generations who are growing up surrounded by technology. It can also help teachers with lesson planning, language exercises, and developing creative ways to connect younger generations with Tamil," says Mr. Vinayagamoorthy. It is in this context that training programmes for Tamil teachers acquire importance. There must be collaboration among educational institutions in Tamil Nadu, Sri Lanka, and diaspora communities. "Ultimately, the goal should be to use AI as a tool to strengthen Tamil education, while ensuring that teachers remain at the heart of the learning experience," the FGT chief emphasises.

Preserving Tamil's ancient heritage and preparing it for the future must go hand in hand. Tamil has evolved from palm-leaf manuscripts to digital platforms, and it is everyone's duty to ensure that the language stays relevant in the AI era, capturing every facet of the language's glory.

(This journalist was in Toronto during the second week of October on invitation from the Federation of Global Tamils.)

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

From the radical upheaval of the French Revolution to the attempt to replace religious authority with reason, explore the ideas behind the controversial Cult of Reason

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
On what date in the French Republican calendar was the Festival of Reason held at Notre-Dame Cathedral?

QUESTION 2
What position did Pierre-Gaspard Chaumette hold in the Paris Commune when he spearheaded the Festival of Reason?

QUESTION 3
Which Parisian cathedral was transformed into a Temple of Reason during the November 1793 celebrations?

QUESTION 4
Which revolutionary civic cult succeeded the Cult of Reason as the officially promoted alternative under Maximilien Robespierre in 1794?



Visual question: Identify this French physician and politician whose name became an eponym for a device associated with executions during the French Revolution. Although he did not invent the device, he advocated a more humane method of execution. CARNAVALET MUSEUM

Questions and answers to the previous daily quiz: 1. The political party which nominated Abraham Lincoln for the presidency, and the city where its national convention was held. **Ans: The Republican Party; its convention was held in Chicago, Illinois**
2. Abraham Lincoln's running mate in the 1860 presidential election. **Ans: Hannibal Hamlin, who subsequently became the 15th Vice-President of the United States**
3. The issue that was primarily responsible for the split within the Democratic Party ahead of the 1860 election. **Ans: Slavery, particularly the question of whether it should be permitted to expand into the western territories**
4. The presidential candidate of the Southern Democratic faction, which advocated federal protection for slavery in the territories. **Ans: John C. Breckinridge of Kentucky**
5. Number of Southern states that had seceded from the Union by the time Lincoln assumed office in March 1861. **Ans: Seven states**
6. The presidential election, held in 1864 during the American Civil War, that Abraham Lincoln contested and won for a second term, defeating the Democratic nominee George B. McClellan. **Ans: The 1864 U.S presidential election**
Visual: This gentleman, who became the central figure in a landmark 1857 U.S. Supreme Court case that intensified the national debate over slavery. **Ans: Dred Scott, whose unsuccessful legal battle for freedom culminated in the infamous *Dred Scott v. Sandford judgment***
Early birds: Tamal Biswas| Lalchand Bhutani| KN Viswanathan| Sunil Madhavan| Sitaram Saharay



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

The fort was restored to its former glory

The ageing towers and stairways of the monument were repaired

S Upendran

What is the meaning and origin of the term 'petty cash'? (K Arundathi, Raipur)
The word 'petty' has several different meanings. When you refer to someone as being a 'petty individual', you are suggesting he is rather mean; someone who is selfish and focuses on rather trivial matters. It is not in this sense, however, that the word is being used here. 'Petty' comes from the French 'petit' meaning small. When you say that a woman is 'petit', you are suggesting she is small built. The word 'cash', on the other hand, comes from the Latin 'capsa' meaning 'box' or 'chest'. The term was originally used to refer to a box in which people kept money; with the passage of time, however, the meaning of the word shifted from the box to the money that was inside the box. The term 'petty cash', which continues to be used even today, began to be used in the 17th century in business circles to refer to the small amount of cash set aside for the minor, day-to-day expenses, for example, snacks, tea, stationery, stamps, etc.

We usually pay for the afternoon tea and biscuits out of petty cash.

When the Manager went on leave, I was put in charge of petty cash.

What is the difference between 'repair' and 'restore'? (T. Balakrishnan, Chennai)
You usually 'repair' something that is not working or not working properly. The aim here is to get the object - car, clock, grinder, etc. - working again. For example, if your car or scooter is giving you problems, you might take it to a mechanic and get it fixed. The aim is here to solve a practical problem - getting the vehicle running again. When you get your brakes repaired, you do not usually worry about the number of dents in the car. You may get the brakes repaired without fixing the dents - in other words, you are not worried about how the car looks. Your primary aim is to get it running again.

Sujatha is looking for a good mechanic to repair her dad's old scooter.

Ravi spent a couple of weekends trying to repair the grandfather clock.

To 'restore' an old car is far more difficult than repairing it. The process of 'restoring' a vehicle involves not only getting it to run again, but also making the vehicle look brand new. In the case of restoration, unlike in the case of repairs, looks are important. To achieve this, you ensure that everything about the car looks authentic - the rear-view mirror, the paint, the upholstery, etc. should look like the original. The same is true of the engine as well. People who restore things spend a lot of time looking for genuine parts. In other words, restoring involves bringing the vehicle back to its original glory.

This shop specialises in restoring old clocks.

Suresh spent nearly five years restoring his grandfather's Fiat.

upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Doldrums:
a state of inactivity

Synonyms: stagnation

Usage: *A sluggish job market has kept the economy in the doldrums.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/doldrums

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈdɒldɹəmz/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Nifty Bank rises 1.5% as PSBs lead, Sensex closes steady

Banking stocks outperformed the broader market trend on Monday with Nifty Bank up 1.5% even as benchmark indices closed a tad higher amid profit-booking following a six-session rally. Nifty 50 ended at 25,044.65, up 0.23% while the Sensex closed 0.13% higher at 81,106.58. "Indian equities may consolidate near term as investors book profit after the sharp rally of over 10% in seven sessions," said Siddhartha Khemka, head, research, wealth management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

OALP deepwater bid deadline extended to December 10

The Directorate General of Hydrocarbons (DGH) on Monday extended the deadline for submitting bids for deepwater and ultra-deepwater blocks under the 10th and 11th rounds of the Open Acreage Licensing Policy (OALP) by 25 days to December 10. The latest extension marks the seventh for the 10th round, launched in April last year and the third for the 11th round, which opened in March this year.

L&T bags up to ₹2,500 crore order from Noida Metro Rail

Infrastructure major Larsen & Toubro (L&T) on Monday said it has secured an order ranging between ₹1,000 crore and ₹2,500 crore from Noida Metro Rail Corporation Ltd. The scope of the project covers the part design and construction of a 15.1-km elevated viaduct from Botanical Garden to Noida Sector-142 and from the Depot Station to Boraki, along with the construction of 10 elevated metro stations, including architectural finishes. PTI

Villages without 4G decline 75% in 4 years on BSNL's saturation project

Data obtained by *The Hindu* under RTI shows a sharp decline in the number of villages without serviceable internet speeds from 45,180 in 2022 to 11,372; reduction notable because of historical gaps in connectivity between urban and rural India

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI


India is still far from universal smartphone ownership, even as cities and towns often enjoy extensive high-speed 5G coverage. FILE PHOTO

The number of villages without 4G connectivity has fallen from 45,180 in 2022 to 11,372, about a fourth of the earlier figure, according to data from the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) obtained by *The Hindu* under the Right to Information Act, 2005.

The reduction is partly the result of BSNL's 4G saturation project. But the figure is beyond the scheme's initial target of covering 24,680 villages, indicating complementary efforts by private operators.

The reduction is notable because of historical gaps in connectivity between urban and rural India. The country is still far from universal smartphone ownership, even as cities and towns often enjoy extensive high-speed 5G coverage and affordable wired home broadband.

The development also comes at a time when additions to wired broadband subscriptions have stagnated for months, making mobile broadband – the primary means of internet access for Indians – all the more important. The Union government has "sanctioned the next order of 26,000 [sites]," a senior official said last week. In 12 or 13 circles, BSNL's efforts have been supplemented by intra-circle agreements with Vodafone Idea Ltd. (Vi). "So, BSNL has come a long way," the official said.

Odisha topped the list of States with the highest number of villages without 4G coverage, at 1,789, as of August 31.

This figure includes over 300 uninhabited villages. Arunachal Pradesh ranked second, with 1,518 villages, roughly a tenth of which are uninhabited. The northeastern State's tally of unconnected villages was reduced by 59%, 16 percentage points less than the national average.

The next few States – Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Rajasthan and Himachal Pradesh – have all reduced the number of villages without 4G connectivity by well over half. An analysis by *The Hindu* suggests that this year, about 40 lakh people may live in villages without 4G reception. This amounts to roughly 0.25% of India's estimated population. Scheduled Tribe-dominated villages account for the bulk of this population, the analysis found, with 46% of the population in villages whose names are found in the 2011 Census falling into this category.

The population of these villages represents 11% of the overall sample.

This estimate does not include villages that did not exist in 2011.

As there has been no nationwide Census since that year, many villages have been added and removed from the overall list.

Some entries in the newer list of villages with 4G connectivity are inconsistent with information shared by the Communications Ministry in a parliamentary response in March. For instance, while the list shared with *The Hindu* includes eight villages in Kerala, the Ministry's response reported no villages without 4G coverage in the State.

FPIs return to Indian equities, Nov. trend shows

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Foreign inflows into the Indian equity markets seen in the past week perhaps indicate the return of foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) to Indian equities.

Provisional exchange data show that foreign institutional investors purchased Indian shares worth a net ₹45,960 crore during the five trading sessions ended on November 6, 2026.

The inflows had exceeded the ₹45,162 crore in net selling recorded during October 2026.

According to Hemang Gor, Senior Research Analyst – Derivatives & Technical Research, Axis Direct, Friday (November 6) featured a historic rally driven by record FII concentration in private banks, delivering an over 1,900-point weekly gain – the year's highest.

Meta outlines India pricing for Muse AI agent ahead of launch

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Meta has set rupee-denominated subscription prices for its rapidly growing AI agent, Muse, ahead of its official launch in India, signalling its entry into one of the world's largest digital markets.

The service is priced at ₹1,799 for its Power tier and ₹8,999 for the Maximum tier, with marginally higher charges for subscriptions purchased through Google Play and Apple's billing systems, *The Hindu* has found.

The pricing, which is broadly in line with U.S. rates, has not been reported previously.

It remains unclear whether these prices are final or could be revised when Muse officially launches in India.

Meta did not respond to *The Hindu's* queries.

AI agents such as Muse and its rival Instinct have gained considerable traction as users increasingly entrust autonomous systems with online tasks.

Muse, which allows users to interact with it on WhatsApp, clocked more than 10 million downloads within two months of its launch. Its applications range from handling customer-service interactions and filling out online forms to planning travel and booking flight tickets.

Muse's integration with WhatsApp could give it a significant distribution advantage in India, where the messaging platform has a massive user base.

The service currently offers a free tier with generous usage limits in the U.S., Canada, Japan and Singapore.

Although Muse currently places Indian users on a waitlist, users can register through a VPN connected to one of its supported markets. Registered accounts continue to work in India even after users stop routing their internet connections through those countries.

Despite the absence of Muse from Indian app marketplaces, its web and WhatsApp interfaces are accessible in the country. Indian-issued cards can also be used to purchase subscriptions, provided their billing territory is set to a supported market.

However, the service's functionality in India remains restricted.

It does not accept user authorisation to make card payments on their behalf, as this capability depends on integrations with payment processors that do not operate in India.

VDA transactions top ₹35,000 cr in FY25

Dalip Singh
Shishir Sinha
NEW DELHI

Tier-2 and peripheral districts, including North 24 Parganas (West Bengal), Medchal-Malkajgiri (Telangana) and Kokrajhar (Assam), are among the top five districts in terms of Virtual Digital Asset (VDA or cryptocurrency) transaction value, according to government data.

However, the number of unique deductees is higher in major financial and technology hubs such as Bengaluru Urban, Mumbai Suburban and Chennai.

"There is a possibility of dormant bank accounts and PANs of individuals in districts of West Bengal, Telangana and Assam being used for VDA transactions. However, with effective inter-agency coordination and strong use of technology by the Income Tax Department, the transactions were tracked and action initiated," an official said.

Bengaluru leads

Among the top 10 districts in terms of unique deductees, Bengaluru Urban continued to occupy the top position from FY23 to FY26 indicating high concentration of technology-linked digital asset activity.

At the State level, Karnataka led in the number of unique deductees.

The total number of deductees rose to over 32.36 lakh in FY26 from 16.50 lakh in FY25.During the same period, the transaction consideration on which TDS was deducted increased from about ₹22,000 crore to over ₹35,000 crore. Tax collected on income from VDA transfers stood at over ₹585 crore in FY25. Data for FY26 is not available.

(The writers are with The Hindu businessline)

Little hope


Earth under siege: Vapour rises from the cooling towers of a coal-fired power station operated by RWE near Niederaussem, western Germany. COP31, the 31st U.N. Climate Change Conference, will be held in Antalya, Turkey from November 9-20. AFP

Prices of most kharif crops rule above MSP on weather impact

Prabhudatta Mishra
Vishwanath Kulkarni
NEW DELHI/BENGALURU


The yield of crops has suffered due to climate impact, says B. Krishnamurthy.

Prices of most kharif crops, barring a few like groundnut, are ruling above the minimum support price (MSP) fixed by the government as trade fears output could be lower due to drought and untimely rain.

Agriculture sector stakeholders say they are witnessing record prices for some commodities such as rice and maize. "Prices of even rabi crops such as gram (chana) and wheat are also ruling above MSP," said Delhi-based exporter Rajesh Jain Paharia.

"Current agricultural produce marketing committee (APMC) yard prices seem to be a natural hedge against climate impact, which affected the yield. Centre must factor in farmers' loss due to climate factors before taking policy decision against inflation," said S. Chandrasekaran, trade policy analyst.

More income for ryots

"Mandi prices are slightly higher than the MSP of various crops due to lower production hit by El Nino," said Siraj Hussain, former Agriculture Secretary.

However, Rampal Jat, president, Kisan Mahapanchayat, Jaipur, said: "At an all-India level, market prices for agricultural produce are being reported as higher than the MSP. This is a positive development. However, on the ground, the price for the best variety moong (green gram) is around ₹7,800 per quintal– ₹980 per quintal lower than the MSP. Similarly, for bajra (pearl millet), the price for the best variety is below MSP at ₹2,700 per quintal," he said.

Higher than MSP prices mean farmers will get more income compared with government-set rates, said D. K. Pant, chief economist and head of public finance, India Ratings & Research.

Mr. Chandrasekaran concurred, saying that in some pockets this will "provide rural growth and accelerate the economic engine".

Kharif estimates

The rise in prices of kharif crops comes with the Ministry of Agriculture still assessing kharif crop production, taking into account the impact of El Niño-induced drought and cyclones in the South.

"The yield of crops has suffered due to climate impact. For example, we were expecting a record 15 lakh tonne (lt) of urad (black matpe) crop. With untimely rain in U.P., M.P. and Rajasthan, we expect 8-9 lt urad crop," said B. Krishnamurthy, MD, Four P International Pvt. Ltd.

(The writers are with The Hindu businessline) With inputs from Subramani Ra Mancombu, Chennai

BDR Pharma to acquire major stake in Acme's oral solid formulations business

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The transaction values the business at $250 million, a person in the know of the deal said

BDR Pharma will acquire a controlling stake in the oral solid formulations business of Acme Formulation and its subsidiaries from its existing shareholders, led by alternative investment firm PAG.

The transaction values the business at $250 million, a person in the know of the deal said.

BDR Pharma said a key rationale for the acquisition is the addition of complementary capabilities across thyroid products, female sex hormone products and general pharmaceutical products.

Matches priorities

It aligns with its growth priorities across oncology, critical care and women's healthcare, while creating opportunities to expand its product offerings in international markets, the company said.

"Acme will further strengthen our CDMO platform and add differentiated capabilities. We see this as part of a larger growth roadmap... as we continue to build and expand our global presence," said Dharmesh Shah, Chairman and Managing Director of BDR Pharma.

Post sale of the controlling stake in the oral solid business, PAG and Viral Shah will retain full ownership of Immacule, which is a sterile injectable focused contract manufacturing businesses. Immacule had recently commissioned a new facility with a capacity of 200 million units and provides capabilities across dosage forms and in various therapeutic areas.

"BDR Pharma's strength in new and complex medicines will bring more innovative products to Acme's CMO and CDMO clients, existing and new, across geographies," Acme founder and Immacule Managing Director Viral Shah said.

India's Jindal, Italy's Arvedi bid for former Ilva steelworks

Reuters
ROME

India's Jindal and Italian steelmaker Arvedi Group have submitted binding bids for Italy's largest steelworks, the special commissioners overseeing the company said on Monday, as the government seeks a buyer for the industrial group. The commissioners will now assess whether the offers are complete and meet the tender requirements, according to a statement. The business of Italy's steel group Ilva, now Acciaieried' Italia (AdI), centred on the vast Taranto plant in southern Italy, is currently run by government-appointed commissioners after years of financial and operational difficulties. Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni's government has been seeking a new owner to safeguard steel production and thousands of jobs at the site, which directly employs around 8,000 people.

Chinese banks boost dollar deposit rates, sources say



Quiet move: U.S. dollar (top) and Chinese yuan notes are held by a currency exchange staff in Jakarta. AFP

Reuters

Several Chinese banks are sharply lifting dollar deposit rates, in some cases above U.S. benchmarks, in unusually swift moves that bankers say are attracting cash and could temper gains for China's yuan.

Higher dollar deposit rates encourage savers and exporters to park cash in dollars rather than low-yielding yuan, potentially slowing a prolonged currency rally that has begun to squeeze exporters' wafer-thin margins.

Hike dollar-deposit rates

More than six banks, ranging from state-owned to joint-stock and foreign lenders, have in recent weeks hiked dollar deposit rates to levels not seen since at least 2023, according to people at the banks.

All the bankers spoke to *Reuters* on the condition of anonymity as they were not authorised to speak to the media.

The hikes are an extension of a months-long rise in dollar deposit rates in China.

But the latest moves, which have not been previously reported, show the trend gaining speed, signal an end to a defacto cap on state banks' dollar rates and suggest efforts to slow down the rising yuan are stepping up.

Reuters could not determine whether policymakers had directed banks to raise dollar deposit rates. The People's Bank of China (PBOC), which typically issues informal guidance on such rates to state banks, did not respond to a faxed request for comment. The hikes come amid some of the strongest efforts yet to rein in a yuan rally that has lifted the currency about 10% against the dollar since early 2025, with the PBOC on Tuesday announcing it would raise the foreign currency reserves banks must hold.

"The current exchange rate is not particularly favourable for exporters," said one person at a state bank, where they said deposit rates rose by about 80 basis points over the past few months to as high as 4.5% in late October.

That is the highest level since 2023 and compares with rates around 4.8% at U.S. banks, according to LSEG data.

"To avoid being forced into converting FX back into yuan, banks can help offset some of the pressure," the person said. Exporters and retail customers were taking advantage of the higher rates and making deposits, said two people at separate banks. Chinese banks have been using their dollars to buy U.S. Treasuries, *Reuters* reported in September, a shift in their investment strategy. Some banks continued to do so, said a person at a joint-stock bank that has been a buyer of Treasuries.

Discourage dollar sales

At another state bank, dollar deposit rates have been hiked twice in two weeks and one-year rates now top 4% on balances above $50,000, according to a person with direct knowledge of the rates on offer, who said it was drawing deposits.

Predilection for 'perp' futures sets off risk alarms for Wall Street stalwarts

Perps greenlit in U.S. in May and are expanding beyond crypto; products do not expire and trade 24/7, in big structural shift; they have sparked a classification fight between CME, CFTC; incumbents warn novel products pose risks to derivatives market; 'industry is now at an inflection point'

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

The Trump administration's push to bring novel offshore perpetual futures to the U.S. is raising alarms, according to interviews with four executives at incumbent exchanges and other key market participants who warned that the products will introduce serious new risks to the multi trillion-dollar derivatives market.

Pioneered in non-U.S. crypto markets, perpetual futures, or 'perps,' trade around the clock and do not expire, meaning investors can hold positions indefinitely.

They are usually leveraged, sometimes by as much as 50 times, and are predominantly traded by retail or individual investors.

Crypto perps trading volume reached $61.7 trillion in 2025, up 29% from 2024, according to data provider CryptoQuant, with much of that on big platforms such as Binance and Hyperliquid and based in Asia.

The *Reuters* interviews with executives at exchanges, trading firms, asset managers and market-structure providers revealed broader concerns that improperly regulated perps and 24-hour trading could disrupt market structure and erode risk-management safeguards bolstered after the 2007-09 financial crisis.



Risky move: A street sign for Wall Street is seen outside the New York Stock Exchange (NYSE). REUTERS

Alarmed at nod

Traditional Wall Street exchanges were alarmed by the U.S. Commodity Futures Trading Commission's (CFTC) decision in May to formally approve U.S.-listed crypto perps, with Kalshi, Coinbase, Robinhood and other financial technology firms jumping into the new market.

Last week, the government regulator also approved single-stock equity perps. CFTC Chair Michael Selig has said itis important to maintain U.S. oversight of the nascent market to protect American investors.

> Pioneered in non-U.S. crypto markets, perpetual futures, or 'perps,' trade around the clock and do not expire, meaning investors can hold positions indefinitely.

Tensions rise

CME Group, the big futures market operator, is suing the CFTC to overturn its May decision, arguing it has wrongly classified perps as futures, creating unfair competition and downplaying their risks. A group representing Cboe Global Markets and Citadel Securities also sued last week to reverse the CFTC's recent equity perp approval on the same grounds.

"I think they've muddied the waters here significantly," said Terry Duffy, CME's chief executive and a 40-plus-year industry veteran. "Anytime you have ambiguity in markets ...that could hurt the business."

The CFTC declined to comment on the concerns raised in the interviews. It has previously said the CME had chosen "lawfare" over competing in the new market.

The clash is the latest sign that the administration's support for crypto and prediction markets, where some of the leading companies also run new exchanges, is fuelling tensions with traditional Wall Street firms.

The standoff over market risks could grow next year when Democrats, propelled by midterm elections this week that handed them control of Congress, are likely to square off against President Donald Trump and step up oversight of the young industries.

"Many of these incumbents haven't faced this type of disruption for a very long time," said Chris Perkins, head of crypto at Franklin Templeton.

'Not futures but swaps'

The CFTC's May decision sent exchange shares tumbling on competition fears. They have since recovered and executives have said they do not view perps as a serious threat to their predominantly institutional businesses.

Their concern is that treating perps as futures gives retail investors access to the novel products under a regulatory regime they say provides insufficient safeguards against leverage and counterparty risk. They argue the products are more akin to swaps, which face tougher margin, capital and reporting norms and are generally less accessible to retail investors.

Traditional futures let counterparties lock in a transaction price for a later date, while swaps involve counterparties periodically exchanging cash flows or liabilities based on a benchmark. Because perps do not expire and involve ongoing funding payments between counterparties, they meet the 2010 Dodd-Frank Act's definition of a swap, exchanges say.

Derivatives attorneys have said the CME has raised legitimate issues. The CFTC has said perps have futures-like features and their funding mechanism is a substitute for expiration.

"The industry is at an inflection point where product classification risks becoming a competitive tool," said Rob Hocking, global head of derivatives at Cboe, adding that the development is bad for markets. "There needs to be a resolution in short order."

Futures-style margin requirements may be inadequate for products that behave more like swaps, increasing counterparty and liquidity risks during intense volatility, the executives said.

Mechanisms that automatically liquidate traders' perp positions when their margin falls below required levels could amplify such stress.

Last year, such mechanisms triggered the biggest ever liquidation of bitcoin positions, amplifying the selloff. The CFTC, in an advisory, emphasised more customer disclosures

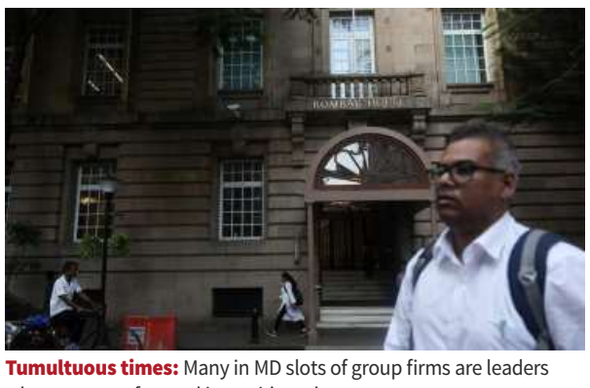
Family business: the craft of holding and folding

OPINION

Naveen Khajanchi

Power and wealth have a way of corrupting even those who appear most genuine and loyal. Succession planning, therefore, must account not just for the foreseeable but also for the unthinkable. Professionals who once swore by their loyalty can change sides; family members can have divergent ambitions; business environments evolve and family dynamics rarely remain the same across generations.

Ultimately, the objective must be to ensure the survival of the business and the preservation of family relationships, anchored in the broad values that define its legacy. Steward leadership is much talked about but remarkably rare when it begins to challenge personal power, wealth or ego. This is precisely why a robust framework must be put in place during relatively normal times so that even extraordinary situations do not spiral out of control.



Tumultuous times: Many in MD slots of group firms are leaders who can move forward into wider roles. REUTERS

My own philosophy is simple: every family member should have access to basic security during difficult times, while retaining the independence to lead their own lives within the broad boundaries of shared family values. Family gatherings should be rooted in affection, not obligation, and when a crisis strikes, members should be able to count on one another. In family businesses, succession can become a test of patience and restraint. For some family members, the chair is already theirs in their minds, almost as an entitlement by virtue of birth.

The Tata Group offers a compelling backdrop to this debate. Late Ratan Tata retained the chairmanship and did not induct Noel Tata onto the Tata Sons board, for reasons best known to him. With N. Chandrasekaran's resignation, reappointment and the subsequent opposition to his continuation now drawing attention, the question of who eventually leads Tata Sons has once again come into focus. Tata Trusts, the group's largest shareholder, under its chairman Noel Tata, has initiated the process of raising concerns in what it considers the larger interest of the institution. When the chemistry between the old guard and the institution begins to fracture, sometimes the most dignified course is to recognise the moment and make way gracefully.

Mr. Noel Tata has consistently demonstrated an ability to rise above personal considerations in the larger interests of the family and the institution. He has served under three Tata Sons chairmen – Ratan Tata, Cyrus Mistry and N. Chandrasekaran – maintaining dignity and restraint through changing circumstances. His understated style, attention to detail and willingness to listen are qualities that deserve recognition. His leadership at Trent has also demonstrated his agility, resilience and ability to build a formidable business.

As chairman of Tata Trusts, Mr. Noel Tata is well placed to play a decisive role in navigating the present transition, should circumstances require it. His approach will need to balance institutional interests, family expectations and the group's long-term legacy.

The next generation, including his children Maya and Neville, and the wider family, will ultimately inherit the consequences of decisions taken today.

(The writer is director of Executive Search Service and author of Evolutionary Leadership A Holistic Perspective. Views expressed are personal)

Data centres race for used turbines and jet engines on AI rush

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
BENGALURU/FRANKFURT

Utilities, developers and firms racing to power AI data centres are scouring the world for second-hand gas turbines, reviving mothballed machines and converting retired jet engines, as lead times for costly new equipment stretch into the next decade.

Despite growing scepticism over the perils of artificial intelligence (AI) technology and a recent selloff in related stocks, demand for energy-hungry data centres is soaring, creating a critical bottleneck for essential power infrastructure and equipment, such as turbines.

"Delivery conversations (are) firmly focused on the 2030 to 2031 window," Aurora Tenorio, senior analyst at energy consultancy Wood Mackenzie, said about the U.S. turbine market.

Second-hand gear

That is prompting some firms to search for second-hand and refurbished equipment as well as turbines based on jet engines rather than wait for order backlogs to clear, according to more than a dozen brokers, service firms and suppliers.

"That secondary market is very, very hot right now," said Ana Amicarella, CEO of Ethos Energy, an equipment services provider.

"We also have seen an escalation on the prices of what people are demanding." Can this market be the answer to the power supply squeeze?

Probably only partially, said Noor Qureshi, an associate at Enverus Intelligence Research.

"The market is already constrained, with limited excess supply, so it is unlikely to offset a meaningful share of the delays," she said. Turbines are also just one obstacle, with air permits, grid access and other factors also causing delays.

There are no reliable estimates of how much the secondary market is contributing to the global turbine supply worth about $25 billion a year. Its very emergence, though, attests to the profound impact the data centre boom has had across industries.



Power guzzler: Construction site of the Microsoft data centre in Amsterdam, The Netherlands. REUTERS

AI infrastructure firm Crusoe, for example, in April ordered 13 so-called aeroderivative gas turbines from U.S.-based ProEnergy– which are based on jet engines made by GE Aerospace –describing it as a strategic move to scale fast.

The turbines, with a joint capacity of 650 megawatts (MW), will be deployed at Crusoe's AI data centre projects in the U.S.

ProEnergy and Crusoe did not respond to *Reuters* requests for additional information.

Data centres and their operators have emerged as big customers of gas turbines, a market that almost solely catered to traditional utilities until a few years ago.

Orders top 100 GW

Today, worldwide orders top 100 gigawatts (GW), according to Wood Mackenzie, well above the estimated global production capacity of between 60 GW and 70 GW.

Analysts at investment bank Jefferies estimate that U.S. data centres alone account for nearly 17 GW of demand this year and that figure can more than triple by 2028.

While global gas turbine manufacturing capacity is growing and is expected to rise to around 87 GW in 2028, it will still be well short of the 129 GW in expected turbine power demand, they said.

Siemens Energy, GE Vernova and Mitsubishi Heavy Industries, which dominate the market, all say the AI boom has driven orders beyond their production capacity. In the United States, delivery of a gas turbine now takes six years on average, said Tenorio.

Used, refurbished or repurposed equipment comes with its own challenges. Overhauled turbines can have unclear maintenance histories, limited life left and weak long-term servicing, Tenorio said. Converted jet engines raise questions about how fit they are for continuous work as power generators. Still, waiting times counted in years ensure the market's appeal.

WASHINGTON

U.S. launches task force to disrupt land-based supply routes into Iran



REUTERS

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Sunday that a new task force 'Iron Gate' is in place to disrupt land routes into Iran that the U.S. military says are used for shipping weapons and illicit materials. Meanwhile, U.S. Central Command announced a 20-member team to expand on a U.S. naval blockade of Iranian ports. AFP

KRAKOW

Poland mass shooting suspect dies in hospital amid hunt for motive



AFP

A Polish man accused of carrying out a deadly shooting spree in Krakow died in hospital on Monday, two days after he was critically wounded in a gun battle with police. After he had originally been linked to the far right, prosecutors said that his reasons for killing nine people, including three family members, remained unclear. AFP

PARIS

France accuses Iran of carrying out cyberattacks on supermarkets



AP

France on Monday said Iran's Revolutionary Guards were behind cyberattacks on supermarket fridges last month, vowing sanctions against Tehran. Swathes of stores were hit in the October 11 and 12 cyberattacks, which raised the temperatures in their refrigerators, forcing them to throw away inventories of perishable food. AFP

AMSTERDAM

Thousands march in Amsterdam, seeking govt. response to Gaza war



AFP

Tens of thousands of people marched in Amsterdam, Netherlands, on Sunday aimed at pressing the government to take more decisive action against Israel over Gaza. Organisers of "Red Line" protests called for measures including stricter trade sanctions, halting arms sales and declaring Israel's actions in Gaza as genocide. AFP

War with Iran 'highly unlikely' to resume if talks progress: Trump

U.S. leader signals lull in fighting but warns decision depends on a strong deal, claims economic pressure will force Tehran to concede to Washington's terms; Iranian Minister says peace talks had paused following Republicans' rout in midterms

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump cast doubt on renewed fighting with Iran, telling CNN it was "highly unlikely," ahead of a meeting with mediator Qatar's Prime Minister on Monday.

Mr. Trump has threatened to resume strikes in recent weeks, with U.S. media reports suggesting that hostilities could restart after last Tuesday's midterm elections.

The President told CNN in an interview on Sunday that renewed fighting was "highly unlikely," but warned that his decision "depends on whether or not they sign a very strong agreement."



U.S. President Donald Trump had acknowledged that the Iran war was partially responsible for the Republicans' defeat. REUTERS

"I would if necessary, but we hit them really hard. I hit them so hard. You don't know how hard I hit them," he said.

Mr. Trump is scheduled to meet Qatar's Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani at the White House on Monday. The meeting will be Mr. Trump's first with a foreign leader since a massive midterm loss that saw his Republican Party lose control of Congress.

Political fallout

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi suggested on Sunday that peace talks had been paused while the political fallout of the vote was being assessed.

"For the past few days, there has been no more travel (by mediators), and the reason for this is the shock that the election results in the U.S. have caused to everyone," Mr. Araghchi said.

"We now have to see how long it will take for them to digest these results, in order to determine how we are going to move forward," he added.

Mr. Trump has acknowledged that the war with Iran as at least partially responsible for the Republicans' defeat.

In Sunday's CNN interview, Mr. Trump once again suggested that the economic pressure Iran is under will force its leaders into accepting the Washington's terms.

"They're a failing nation. It just came out, you saw this year, 301 percent inflation," Mr. Trump claimed. "They're withering away financially. We've hit them militarily. We could finish them off."

Iran's official figures put inflation at nearly 90 percent year-on-year in September.

Russia, Ukraine exchange strikes a day ahead of talks

Associated Press
KYIV

Russia battered Ukraine's power grid again and Ukrainian forces hit another of Russia's biggest oil refineries, officials said on Monday, hours before delegations from Moscow and Kyiv were due to meet for new U.S.-brokered talks on how to end the fighting.

The three-way talks between envoys from the U.S., Russia and Ukraine are due to start in Abu Dhabi on Tuesday.

Russian forces targeted four electrical substations in Ukraine's Kyiv, Dnipropetrovsk, Cherkasy and Vinnytsia regions, Russia's Defence Ministry said on Monday.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Monday that the European Union had agreed to activate a special emergency mechanism that speeds up funding for power grid repairs.



On the frontline: Firefighters work at the site of a reported Russian attack in Odesa Region, Ukraine, on Sunday. REUTERS

Three killed

Russia launched 317 drones of various types including 105 jet-powered drones at Ukraine overnight, Ukraine's air force said.

Russian forces hit a warehouse in Odesa in southwestern Ukraine containing food supplies for kindergartens and schools, killing three people, local officials said.

Meanwhile, an attack by Ukraine started a fire at the KINEF oil refinery, one of Russia's largest, Leningrad Governor Alexander Drozdenko said on Monday.

Netanyahu's poll rival Eisenkot tasked with forming govt. in Israel

Associated Press
JERUSALEM

Israeli President Isaac Herzog formally gave Opposition politician Gadi Eisenkot the first chance to form the next government on Sunday evening.

"I hope with all my heart that whatever government is formed will lead to unity, connection and healing among all segments of our people," Mr. Herzog said.

Mr. Eisenkot has 28 days to form a coalition, with a possible two-week extension from the President. If he is unable to form a government, Benjamin Netanyahu could then be given a chance.

Mr. Eisenkot promised to give the country a leadership that people can trust, that will act in the interests of the public and that represents all parts of society.

"An absolute majority of Knesset members representing the Israeli public support change," he said. "I intend to navigate the situation with patience, humility, composure and a deep commitment to a Jewish, equal, liberal, and secure Israel."

The October 27 election gave neither his bloc nor Mr. Netanyahu's a clear majority in Parliament.

Among the possible kingmakers are the Arab-led parties.

Catching the waves



A boy learning to surf on a soft-top board at Ngor beach in Dakar, Senegal. As the country hosts the Youth Olympic Games, the first Olympic event ever held in Africa, Senegalese surfers hope they can get more resources and visibility to be able to fulfil their potential. AP

Death toll rises to 44 in Saudi air strikes in Yemen, Houthis say

Agence France-Presse
SANAA

The death toll from Saudi strikes on Yemen's Sanaa province climbed to 44, including more than 20 children, the Houthis said on their television channel on Monday.

A 2022 truce that had paused fighting in Yemen's long-running conflict fell apart in July, restarting fighting between the Iran-aligned Houthis and the Saudi-backed government.

Saudi Arabia has since traded blows with the Houthis, who have struck Saudi airports, energy infrastructure and military sites.

"The toll from the Saudi enemy's massacre in the al shariyah area of Bani Hushaysh, east of Sanaa, has risen to 84 casualties: 44 martyrs and 40 wounded," the Houthis' Ministry of Health said, according to the group's Almasirah TV channel.

It said 21 children and 10 women were among those killed.

"Rescue teams are still searching for the missing," it added.

The fresh toll comes after the Houthis claimed on Sunday an attack on the financial district of the Saudi capital Riyadh, with eyewitnesses saying they saw damage to a skyscraper belonging to oil giant Aramco.

Pentagon chief to hold presser to discuss impeachment threat

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

Facing an expected impeachment resolution in U.S. Congress, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said he is eager to litigate the policy choices that he and President Donald Trump have made in Iran and Venezuela.

"If you want to take issue with what we did in Epic Fury or Rough Rider or nabbing Nicolas Maduro, you're taking issue with the troops and what they accomplished, which is historic," Mr. Hegseth told presspersons on Monday.

He also announced that he would hold a press conference on Tuesday – his first in over 180 days – on the looming impeachment threat.



Pete Hegseth

Republican Rep. Thomas Massie has pushed the impeachment resolution forward over the objections of House GOP leadership as momentum grows to hold Mr. Hegseth accountable for the Iran war, which many Republicans blame for the party's midterm election wipeout.

He argued that starting the war with Iran was a "bold move" by Mr. Trump "and as the President points out so clearly – you can't let crazy Islamists have a nuclear bomb."

"The choice was don't act and wish it away or take a bold move, which the President did with Midnight Hammer, which we've done with Epic Fury," Mr. Hegseth said, referring to the code names for the strike on Iranian nuclear facilities and the larger war. His remarks come after voters last week overwhelmingly showed the unpopularity of the conflict.

U.K. comedian Russell Brand jailed for over 10 years for rape, sexual assault

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Former comedian and Hollywood star Russell Brand was sentenced to ten and a half years in prison for rape and sexual assault by the Southwark Crown Court in London on Monday.

The 51-year-old actor was found guilty by the court of rape and three counts of sexual assault and not guilty on three other counts on November 5. He was charged in relation to a total of seven crimes. His crimes were committed between 2004 and 2009.

The court found him guilty of raping a woman in 2009 at his home, after meeting her at a comedy show. Brand has the possibility of being released in approximately seven years subject to conditions, the judge said.



Russell Brand

"The consequences of what happened have affected almost every aspect of my life. Even now, I continue to experience anxiety, difficulties with trust, reduced confidence and the lasting effects of trauma," the woman who was raped said on Monday at the sentencing.

'Sexual predator'

One of his victims said she was in "shock and turmoil" and did not "have any respect" for herself as a result of the attack on her. The judge referred to Brand as a "sexual predator".

Brand had argued during the trial that while his past behaviour had been "wrong", he had never forced himself on anybody.

The actor was formerly a left-wing activist. In the early years of the current decade, he moved to the right, becoming sceptical of vaccines and the origins of COVID-19, building bonds with big names in U.S. President Donald Trump's Make America Great Again (MAGA) movement, including the President's son, Donald Trump Jr., tech billionaire Elon Musk, commentators Alex Jones and Tucker Carlson, as well as Robert F. Kennedy Jr., the U.S. Health Secretary.

In September, Brand participated in a video call event for MAHA, the Make America Healthy Again movement, which is headed by Mr. Kennedy. Brand converted to Christianity more recently and was baptised in the Thames in 2024.

GTA VI downloads begin ahead of launch

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

U.S. studio Rockstar Games allowed gamers to begin downloading its much-anticipated "Grand Theft Auto VI" on Tuesday.

Fans in New Zealand were the first to be able to download the latest offering in the gangster saga as access was rolled out at the stroke of midnight in each time zone. Players will still have to wait to start gaming until midnight on Thursday of next week.

The release of GTA VI comes 13 years after its predecessor scaled new heights in terms of gameplay and profitability.



Ryndova waits outside a hospital in Kyiv to meet her husband after four and a half years, on Thursday. REUTERS

Ukrainian meets wife after years in war-torn city

Reuters
KYIV

Larysa Ryndova hurried to see her husband as if they were going out on a first date – makeup on and perfume spritzed in the car.

It was the first time she had laid eyes on 68-year-old Serhiy in 4 and half years – time he had spent trapped with others in the Russian-held town of Oleshky in southern Ukraine.

They last saw each other in 2022 when Larysa fled to England to live with their son, three months into the occupation following Russia's all-out invasion of Ukraine. Serhiy stayed to look after the family home, ending up stuck in the town peppered with Russian-laid landmines.

Serhiy got out on October 30 with hundreds of other residents, evacuated during a ceasefire.

Serhiy survived on humanitarian aid that he had stockpiled during the occupation – noodles, grains, canned meat and fish.

"Sometime around April (this year), the people who used to bring us food died – two men. After that, all food deliveries stopped completely," Serhiy said. Locals shared what they had. The local hospital ran out of supplies. Bodies were stacked up in the morgue, as forensic experts refused to risk the journey to the town to perform autopsies.

Serhiy said he probably would not have left the town himself had it not been for the evacuation. Landmines were laid out on all the roads and even in the town. "A lot of people were killed in Oleshky. Someone would go out to pick a cherry plum and get blown up." He said he felt sure he could have survived another winter, despite the ordeal of occupation and food shortages.

Nvidia's chief Huang blunders into the eye of a Beijing-linked spy imbroglio

Nvidia said that it was investigating Jensen Huang, after he told the board he had been intimate with a customer, Alice Huang, whom U.S. intelligence determined was a Chinese spy; the controversy has renewed scrutiny of leadership accountability at a company central to the global AI chip race

NEWS ANALYSIS

John Xavier

Nvidia is the world leader in making chips for AI data centres, and its role in providing the critical hardware for the development of large language models cannot be understated. Powerful AI tools like Anthropic's Claude, Google's Gemini, Meta's Muse, and OpenAI's GPT exist today because of Nvidia's graphic processing unit (GPU) chips.

Accessing Nvidia's GPUs to build powerful AI models started becoming difficult for Chinese companies since 2022 as Washington doubled down on measures to tighten controls on who can access advanced chips. The first big move came in October 2022, when the U.S. Commerce Department blocked the A100 and H100 chips from being sold to China. Nvidia then responded with a China-specific versions of the chip – the A800 and H800.

Washington closed that gap a year later, and Nvidia designed the H20 to fit under the new thresholds. Each round of rules produced a new workaround, and each workaround produced a new round of rules. Beijing, meanwhile, was never a passive bystander. Even back in 2020, China's market regulator approved Nvidia's $6.9 billion purchase of the Israeli networking firm Mellanox on the condition that Nvidia keeps supplying GPUs to Chinese buyers.

Unstable controls

Washington's own stance has been anything but steady. The Trump administration required licences for H20 sales in April 2025, then reversed course a few months later. Nvidia and AMD agreed to hand 15% of their China revenue to the U.S. government, a deal that has drawn questions in the U.S. Congress about whether the government can charge for export approvals at all.

This year, the Commerce department moved the more powerful H200 chip to case-by-case review, while keeping Blackwell and Rubin – more advanced Nvidia AI chips – off the table.

Now Beijing is the one holding things up as a Reuters report says that about 600,000 H200 chips are stuck in Hong Kong because China is withholding import approval as Nvidia, as per a *Financial Times* report, has told cloud partners to cap Chinese customers at 49% of their base.

Beijing's reluctance to take in the shipment of H200 is partly strategic as it aims to prop up Huawei, which, according to industry reports, shipped over 812,000 AI chips in China in 2025, and is projected to take about 62% of the domestic accelerator market this year.


The path forward: NVIDIA CEO Jensen Huang with U.S. President Donald Trump. REUTERS

Mr. Huang himself has said Nvidia has "largely conceded" the AI chip market to Huawei. China still lags badly as its chipmakers are stuck at 7nm-class manufacturing with low yields, and it has no competitive homegrown high-bandwidth memory.

And the chips that Washington has tried to keep away from China were finding their way across the border anyway. As per a research by C4ADS, a non-profit think-tank, restricted Nvidia GPUs, worth about US$13.4 million, were routed via Vietnam, India and Malaysia to Hong Kong and China between 2022 and 2025.

This is the backdrop against which the latest news about Mr. Huang's romantic relationship with a Chinese spy lands.

A probe begins

Nvidia said on Sunday that it was investigating Mr. Huang after he told the board he had been intimate with a customer, Alice Huang, whom U.S. intelligence determined was a Chinese spy, as per a report by *New York Times*.

Ms. Huang is employed at Megaspeed International, a subsidiary of a Chinese gaming company 7Roads. It is a multi-jurisdictional entity, meaning it has registered corporate offices in different countries.

Its primary business is focused on cloud computing service, data processing and infrastructure hosting. Think of it like a massive cloud vendor that provides computing space for companies that unable to set up their own racks of Nvidia GPUs.

As per a report by Bloomberg, which was part of the C4ADS report, Megaspeed is the largest Southeast Asian importer of Nvidia's GPUs.

On LinkedIn, the company's handle has 557 followers, and describes the cloud vendor as provider of "massive GPU scale on fast, flexible infrastructure" and that it is a premium business partner of Nvidia "strategically positioned in the Asia Pacific region."

A quick search for "Alice Huang" revealed an image of a woman who looked very much like the person seen with Nvidia chief Huang at a restaurant in a now viral video footage. Ms. Huang has listed herself as the CEO of Megaspeed International in her LinkedIn profile.

In a LinkedIn post, the company has denied the accusations and said that it has undergone multiple on-site inspections and reviews in the past six months by the Bureau of Industry and Security of the U.S. Commerce Department, the Ministry of Investment, Trade and Industry of Malaysia, and NVIDIA.

But the *New York Times* report claims that Ms. Huang was sharing information with Beijing. In a message to staff, Mr. Huang apologised, saying, "I was unfaithful to my wife," and that there was no excuse for his actions. It would be wrong to read too much into what is still an unfolding story. The board has said it has no reason to believe that national security or Nvidia's secrets were compromised, though its outside counsel will examine all available information.

But the question to ask is not really about one man's personal conduct. It is about concentration of power. Mr. Huang is a co-founder who dictates all aspects of a business that is at the centre of the most important technological shifts in history with the most contested technology supply chain in the world.

In a market where Beijing has used antitrust rulings, security probes and import approvals as bargaining chips, the personal ties of the one person steering Nvidia's China strategy are bound to attract scrutiny.

South Africa's ANC hits new low in local polls as its decline continues

Associated Press
CAPE TOWN

South Africa's African National Congress (ANC) party was handed its worst election results ever Sunday in a new low point on its gradual decline in popularity as voters rebuked it for a failure to deliver basic services like water and electricity.

The once-dominant ANC – the party of Nelson Mandela – received 31% of the vote in Wednesday's local government elections, according to official results Sunday.

The ANC remained the largest party by total share in an election involving hundreds of parties, but the Democratic Alliance (DA) that is its main opposition won 25% of votes.


South African President Cyril Ramaphosa casts his ballot at a polling station in Johannesburg. AFP

That brought closer to reality the once-unthinkable notion that the ANC that led South Africa out of the white minority rule of apartheid and delivered freedom in 1994 under Mandela might one day not be its biggest party.

It used to command 70% of the vote. The ANC's popularity has declined for more than a decade.

It won 45% support in the last local elections in 2021, the first time it had dropped below 50% in any election. In 2024 it then lost its Parliamentary majority for the first time in a national election, which brought about a coalition national government and a seismic shift in South African politics with the end of the ANC's 30-year dominance.

ANC's setback

The ANC saw a steep drop of 15 percentage points from the last local elections and the loss of approximately one-third of its support from five years ago. "If anyone has not heard what the people are saying in this election, then you are lost," said ANC Secretary-General Fikile Mbalula. "This has been a very catastrophic outcome for the ANC." DA leader Geordin Hill-Lewis said his party had now "taken a big step forward" in its aim to be South Africa's biggest.

Through the cracks


A child peers through a tear in a tent at a camp for displaced Palestinians in Deir el-Balah, in the central Gaza Strip, on Monday. Three children and two women were killed on Sunday evening when a sand embankment collapsed in the camp, according to rescue services. AFP

Ancient treasures unearthed as Kabul's Bala Hissar fortress gets a new life

Associated Press
AFGHANISTAN

Perched high above the southern edge of Kabul's old city, the imposing fortress of Bala Hissar has endured centuries of invasions, uprisings and conflict that scarred Afghanistan and left the citadel crumbling.

Now, an extensive, year-slong project by the Aga Khan Trust for Culture (AKTC) is painstakingly conserving Bala Hissar. The aim is to turn the site into a public archaeological park, complete with landscaped gardens, restaurants and a museum.

Echoes beneath

Despite decades of neglect and war, archaeological treasures gradually unearthed within the walls of the strategic fortress in the Afghan capital are revealing more than two millennia of the country's tumultuous history.

The excavations are uncovering an astonishing wealth of finds, from evidence of ancient human habitation to the luxurious baths of a Mughal palace.

"We never thought we would find so much," said archaeologist Babak Rafiei-Alavi.

Work in five separate trenches at the site has unearthed ancient coins, fragments of Buddhist statues, glazed Islamic ceramics, and the remains of palaces, monasteries and dwellings.

"In some parts we were expecting something. But not this," Rafiei-Alavi said of the discovery of remnants of a Mughal palace, complete with murals, a thronelike structure and a star-shaped pool carved into the rock at the top of the hill.

The location of Bala Hissar, which means High Fort in Dari, is key to its significance. Cascading down a prominent outcrop of the Kuh-e-Sher Darwaza mountain ridge, the fortress occupies a commanding position above the old city that helped it protect access routes to Kabul.

Bala Hissar also was an important religious settlement and political center of power along a crucial trade route connecting the Indian subcontinent to Central Asia and beyond. It was "part of a string of pearls of these types of cultural and human settlements," Aga Khan Cultural Services Project Manager Mustafa Nouri said.

Through the ages, the site has served as a fortress, palace complex, arsenal, administrative center, prison and military garrison.


Bala Hissar fortress is seen in Kabul, Afghanistan, on Nov. 9, 2023. AP

Only traces remain of its royal palaces and Buddhist monasteries. But an enduring characteristic has been the site's use as a strategic defensive location, from the first century B.C. to the Mughal empire, Anglo-Afghan wars, Soviet invasion, civil war and the U.S.-led coalition. Part of the site's lower areas are still used by the Afghan military.

While Bala Hissar suffered repeated destruction and rebuilding through the centuries, the heaviest blow came when British troops avenged the 1879 killing of British envoy Sir Louis Cavagnari and his entourage inside Bala Hissar by destroying much of the complex.

Today, the sprawling site still bears the scars of years of neglect and Afghanistan's repeated conflicts.

At the foot of the hill, destroyed and decaying Soviet military hardware lies tangled in a rusty heap. Nearby, large-caliber weapons abandoned after the U.S. withdrawal in 2021 stand in neat rows, now property of Afghanistan's military.

Part of the site within the walls was leveled off in 2008 by U.S. forces who "destroyed many archaeological layers," Rafiei-Alavi said.

Planning for the AKTC's ambitious conservation project began in 2017, with work starting the following year. Initial surveying and documenting, including with ground-penetrating radar and 3D laser scans, were followed by emergency stabilisation to prevent further collapse of the historic fortifications.

The French Archaeological Delegation in Afghanistan was initially involved in excavations, but work temporarily halted after the Taliban seized power in Afghanistan in 2021. AKTC continued operating and has carried out its most extensive work since 2022, Nouri said.

Heritage reclaimed

Afghan authorities say they are keen to preserve the country's cultural artifacts and historical sites, a radical departure from the previous Taliban rule of Afghanistan from 1996 to 2001. In 2001, the Taliban dynamited two giant, sixth-century Buddha statues carved into a cliff face in Bamiyan in central Afghanistan and ransacked the National Museum of Afghanistan in Kabul, smashing ancient artifacts, especially statues considered to be un-Islamic. But now, the current Taliban government says it is keen to safeguard the nation's monuments.

"We recognize the importance of preserving the country's ancient sites," said Ministry of Information and Culture spokesperson Khubaib Ghufran. "We view these remnants of past civilizations as valuable sources of insight and lessons."

The government prioritises restoring monuments facing threats, such as Bala Hissar, "ensuring that we can pass on the legacy of both past and present civilisations to future generations in a well-preserved state," Ghufran said.

TARGET 200

Grandmaster No. 100 for Bharat, AICF president congratulates Anuj



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

AICF president Nitin Narang congratulated Anuj Shrivatri for becoming India's 100th Grandmaster by winning the ASEAN Plus individual chess championships 2026 in Ozamiz City. "Grandmaster No. 100 for Bharat! Congratulations, Anuj! A proud moment for Indian chess. Onwards to 200 Grandmasters," he wrote on X.

HIGH PRAISE

A cracker of a 100, says Anand on India hitting a century of GMs



FIDE

Viswanathan Anand, India's first Grandmaster, congratulated Anuj Shrivatri on becoming the country's 100th GM. "A cracker of a 100. Congrats to Anuj on getting India to this milestone. Funnily, today I was thinking that December 2027 will mark the 40th anniversary of my GM title, and this literally manifested," he posted on X.

TEAM UPDATE

Kiwis summon Clarke as cover for Tickner; Ferguson ruled out



FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

Fast bowler Kristian Clarke, second left, has been called up to the New Zealand squad as cover for Blair Tickner ahead of the third ODI against India. Pacer Lockie Ferguson has been ruled out of the fourth and fifth ODIs after failing to fully recover from a low-grade tear in his right calf sustained during the T20I series.

GETTING IT RIGHT

Gauff outlasts Pegula in a thriller, Noskova cruises past Kostyuk



AFP

Coco Gauff defeated fellow American Jessica Pegula 6-4, 6-7(5), 6-2 on the opening day of the WTA Finals in Indian Wells on Sunday. Gauff had beaten Pegula three months ago in Cincinnati and found the right formula once again. Czechia's Linda Noskova got the better of Marta Kostyuk 6-2, 6-4 in another round-robin contest.

Anuj lights up Indian chess, becomes the 100th GM

The 22-year-old from Madhya Pradesh, who quit his software engineering job to pursue a career in the sport, says it feels good to join the roll of honour and that all the hard work has borne fruit

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

A job offer in a Germany-based IT company was on hand, but Anuj Shrivatri chose a career in chess over being a software professional. He doesn't regret that decision. The 22-year-old provided cheer to India by becoming the country's 100th Grandmaster on Sunday when it was celebrating the festival of lights.

Ever since V.S. Rathanvel became the 99th GM, the question of who would the 100th was on the minds of chess-lovers. And, Anuj did it, winning the seventh ASEAN Plus individual open chess championship in the Philippines.

"It feels very good to become a GM and being the country's 100th is special," he told *The Hindu*.



Fabulous feat: Anuj will cherish his achievement for a long time.

"I had been trying to become a GM and winning the tournament earned me the title directly. All the hard work paid off."

He admitted there was some pressure at the business-end but he made it a point not to overthink and miss out on the opportunity. "I played some really good chess in the last two rounds to win and clinch the title," Anuj, who became the first-ever GM from Madhya Pradesh said.

Having realised the GM dream, he said "the focus is to cross the 2600 barrier and win lot of tournaments."

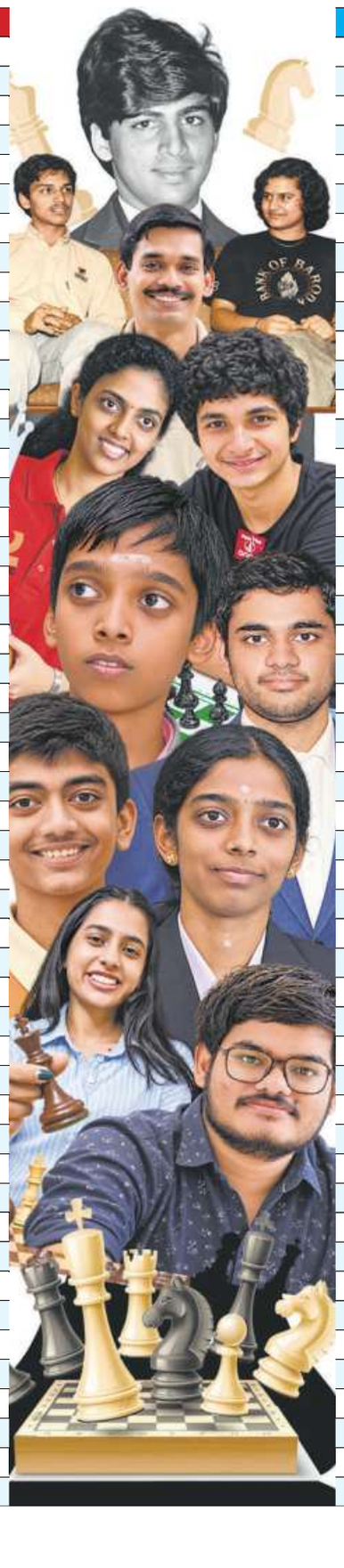
Introduced to chess by his father (Ashok) at the age of six, he took a liking to it and made rapid strides with support from the family.

"I can't thank my father and mother enough. They encouraged me to pursue chess when there was a good job offer," Anuj, who admires World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen and Indian legend Viswanathan Anand, said. "Openings and endgames are my forte and time-management is something which I can improve on," he added.

Having chosen the game of 64 squares over cloud computing, he is already on cloud nine and aiming for the sky.

India's **100 GMs** on 64 squares

FROM **ANAND** TO **ANUJ**, THE MEMBERS OF THE ELITE GRANDMASTERS' CLUB



Sl. No.	Who	When
1	**Viswanathan Anand**	**1987**
2	Dibyendu Barua	1991
3	Praveen Thipsay	1997
4	Abhijit Kunte	2000
5	Krishnan Sasikiran	2000
6	**Pentala Harikrishna**	**2001**
7	**Koneru Humpy**	**2002**
8	Surya Shekhar Ganguly	2003
9	Sandipan Chanda	2003
10	**R.B. Ramesh**	**2003**
11	Tejas Bakre	2004
12	Magesh Chandran	2006
13	Deepan Chakkravarthy	2006
14	Neelotpal Das	2006
15	Parimarjan Negi	2006
16	G.N. Gopal	2007
17	Abhijeet Gupta	2008
18	S. Arun Prasad	2008
19	S. Kidambi	2009
20	R.R. Laxman	2009
21	Sriram Jha	2010
22	Deep Sengupta	2010
23	B. Adhiban	2010
24	S.P. Sethuraman	2011
25	**D. Harika**	**2011**
26	M.R. Lalith Babu	2012
27	Vaibhav Suri	2012
28	M.R. Venkatesh	2012
29	Sahaj Grover	2012
30	**Vidit Gujrathi**	**2013**
31	M. Shyam Sundar	2013
32	Akshayraj Kore	2013
33	V. Vishnu Prasanna	2013
34	Debashis Das	2013
35	Saptarshi Roy Chowdhury	2013
36	Ankit Rajpara	2014
37	Aravindh Chithambaram	2015
38	Karthikeyan Murali	2015
39	Ashwin Jayaram	2015
40	Swapnil Dhopade	2016
41	S.L. Narayanan	2016
42	Shardul Gagare	2016
43	Diptayan Ghosh	2016
44	K. Priyadharshan	2016
45	Aryan Chopra	2017
46	N. Srinath	2017
47	Himanshu Sharma	2017
48	Anurag Mhamal	2017
49	Abhimanyu Puranik	2017
50	M.S. Thejkumar	2017
51	Saptarshi Roy	2018
52	**R. Praggnanandhaa**	**2018**
53	Nihal Sarin	2018
54	**Arjun Erigaisi**	**2018**
55	Karthik Venkataraman	2018
56	Harsha Bharathakoti	2019
57	P. Karthikeyan	2019
58	G.A. Stany	2019
59	N.R. Visakh	2019
60	**D. Gukesh**	**2019**
61	P. Iniyan	2019
62	Swayams Mishra	2019
63	Girish A. Koushik	2019
64	Prithu Gupta	2019
65	Raunak Sadhwani	2019
66	G. Akash	2020
67	Leon Mendonca	2020
68	Arjun Kalyan	2021
69	Harshit Raja	2021
70	R. Raja Rithvik	2021
71	Mitrabha Guha	2021
72	Sankalp Gupta	2021
73	Bharath Subramaniyam	2022
74	Rahul Srivatshav	2022
75	V. Pranav	2022
76	Pranav Anand	2022
77	Aditya Mittal	2022
78	Koustav Chatterjee	2023
79	M. Pranesh	2023
80	N.R. Vignesh	2023
81	Sayantan Das	2023
82	Prraneeth Vuppala	2023
83	Aditya Samant	2023
84	**R. Vaishali**	**2023**
85	P. Shyaam Nikhil	2024
86	L.R. Srihari	2025
87	Harikrishnan A. Ra.	2025
88	**Divya Deshmukh**	**2025**
89	S. Rohith Krishna	2025
90	A.R. Ilamparthi	2025
91	V.S. Raahul	2025
92	Aaryan Varshney	2026
93	Aarav Dengla	2026
94	Mayank Chakraborty	2026
95	Aronyak Ghosh	2026
96	Ethan Vaz	2026
97	G.B. Harshavardhan	2026
98	S. Aswath	2026
99	V.S. Rathanvel	2026
100	**Anuj Shrivatri**	**2026**

Compiled by NEHA SURANA

Milestone underlines India's rapid growth

P.K. Ajith Kumar

When Viswanathan Anand played Alexei Shirov in Tehran in 2000 for his first World title, he knew his time would come, if not then. Back in the latter half of the 1980s, when he was trying to become a Grandmaster (GM), he wasn't as sure.

"I had no way of knowing if I would become a GM or not," Anand once told this correspondent during an interview at his home in Chennai. "It took me two full years to get it."

Anand got his final GM norm in December, 1987, from the Sakthi Finance tournament in Coimbatore. India didn't have a GM till then. Asia only had two. Nearly four decades later, India has a hundred Grandmasters. Anuj Shrivatri became No. 100 on the Deepavali Day. He got his GM title, directly, by winning the ASEAN Plus Individual Open Chess Championship at Ozamiz City, the Philippines. He didn't have to struggle for making the three norms and touching the FIDE rating of 2,500 Elo points, which is the usual way to become the GM, the title that matters most in chess.

India is now churning out GMs like the IPL unearths fresh talents. It is indeed remarkable that a country that had no GM till four decades ago now has 100.



Anand... the trigger. FIDE

Fourth in the list

Only three others – Russia, the United States and Germany – are in that exclusive club. But they all have had GMs from the time the world chess governing body started awarding the titles in 1950.

Seven decades later, there are only around 2,000 GMs across the world. That gives a fair indication about India's feat.

After Anand, India had to wait for another four years before its next GM. Dibyendu Barua, the country's original chess prodigy, became a GM in 1991. It was only six years later that India got another GM – Pravin Thipsay.

The next generation of Indian chess players had it easier. It was after Abhijit Kunte became India's fourth GM in 2000 that the country began to see the coveted title arriving home regularly.

Chess, thanks to Anand's exploits as the Lightning Kid on the global stage, was becoming increasingly popular and the Indian parents were willing to invest in their children. The All India Chess Federation was conducting tournaments and coaching camps, including reputed GMs from overseas, and corporate support was also trickling in.

Rarely in Indian sport have so many things worked in such tandem.

Usha loses SOM elections, IOA likely to get a new president

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

The Indian Olympic Association (IOA) is all set to have a new president.

Incumbent P.T. Usha, who was expected to stand for re-election next month, failed to make the IOA's Sportsperson of Merit (SOM) list in the elections held on Monday, ending her hopes of continuing to head the country's highest sporting organisation for a second term.

While the four male members – Gagan Narang, Kamlesh Mehta, Yogeshwar Dutt and Vijender Singh – were elected unopposed after a spate of withdrawals on Saturday, the final day for doing so, six women were in the fray for four spots. Usha finished fifth with 40 votes in the elections while former long jumper Anju Bobby George, also an AFI senior vice-president, got the maximum 53 votes.

The voting was done by the 80 SOMs – 40 men and women each – of the electoral college with each listing their four choices in order of preference.

Former Indian hockey captain Rani Rampal was second with 50 votes, followed by Dola Banerjee (45) and Saina Nehwal (43). Anita Paul Durai got six votes. Interestingly, the four elected names had contested as a unified panel.

Usha can still contest the December 5 elections to the IOA EC if she is nominated to the general assembly by any National Sports Federation, but it looks unlikely. Each NSF can nominate two – one of each gender – but the Athletics Federation of India is expected to prefer former president Adille Sumariwalla and Anju for the same.

Saina had emerged as a challenger to Usha's IOA presidency, but Monday's voting may well upend all calculations and push Anju to the forefront.

Men in Blue look to seal series

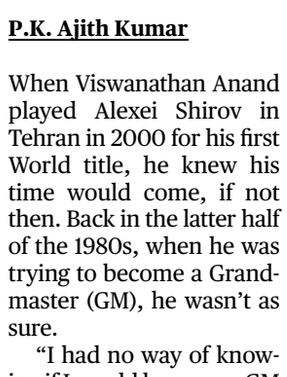
INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
HAMILTON

Veteran Rohit Sharma's form is a worry, but India looks on course to seal the series against an injury-ravaged New Zealand in the third ODI here on Tuesday even though the seamer-friendly conditions are expected to pose a challenge for the visitor's top-order.

India leads the five-match rubber 2-0, but barring Virat Kohli's majestic knock at Eden Park, none of the other batters, including skipper Shubman Gill and Rohit, have looked particularly comfortable.

For Gill, ensuring a series win will be top of the agenda as he won't be playing the last two games of the series. He will shift his focus to red-ball cricket to prepare for the Test series against the Black Caps.



Shreyas. CREIMAS/BCCI

The third game at Seddon Park could well be another rain-curtailed affair and the cold, wet conditions will once again turn the track into a paradise for seam movement and extra bounce.

While India is unlikely to tinker with its winning combination, head coach Gautam Gambhir might want to revisit his ploy of sending in Axar Patel at No. 5 ahead of the far more accomplished K.L. Rahul.

With Auqib Nabi also picking up wickets and Gurnoor Brar, Anshul Kamboj and Arshdeep Singh delivering the goods, the pace attack has been a smash hit.

As for New Zealand, its performance has been underwhelming. The top three of Tim Seifert, Will Young and Henry Nicholls have looked out of sorts.

Match starts at 7.30 a.m. IST.

SNAPSHOTS

Sensational Hridoy denies WI a sweep

Towhid Hridoy became the first Bangladesh batter to score over 300 runs in a Test match as the second Test against West Indies ended in a draw in Sylhet on Monday. Hridoy made 82 in the second innings, taking his match-aggregate to 324 and surpassed Mominul Haque's record of 281 in 2018. The draw denied WI a series sweep.
The scores:
West Indies 356 & 398/6 decl. in 93 overs (King 61, Hodge 142, Wickham 78) drew with Bangladesh 386 & 184/4 in 59 overs (Hridoy 82, Mushfiqur 49). **PoM:** Hridoy. **PoS:** Warrican.

Debutants, Babar give Pakistan day one honours

Captain Babar Azam (50) and debutants – Tayyab Arif (57) and Mohammad Taha (51) – were among four batters to hit half-centuries as Pakistan reached 281 for five on day one of the first Test against Sri Lanka in Rawalpindi on Monday.

The scores: Pakistan 281/5 in 67.2 overs (Tayyab 57, Taha 51, Babar 50, Shakeel 57 batting) vs. Sri Lanka. **Toss:** Sri Lanka.

Shourya wins bronze in 100m hurdles

Promising sprinter Shourya Ambure won a historic bronze in women's 100m hurdles, clocking her personal best at the Youth Olympics in Dakar.

The 17-year-old clocked 13.59 seconds to ensure a podium finish.

INBRIEF



Carlos Alcaraz rules the roost in Paris Masters

Carlos Alcaraz continued his late-season surge by beating Ben Shelton 7-6(5), 7-5 in the Paris Masters final on Sunday for his second straight title and fifth of the year. It was Alcaraz's 29th title of his career and followed his victory in Vienna last Sunday. Last month he won the Japan Open, having only returned from a right wrist injury in late August.

Man United snatches a point against Villa with late goals

Manchester United rescued an incredible 4-4 home draw against Aston Villa in the Premier League on Sunday with two stoppage-time goals.

Important results: Premier League: Brighton 2 (Gomez 15, Gross 42-pen) bt Brentford 0; Crystal Palace 1 (Nketiah 90+5-pen) lost to Liverpool 3 (Mac Allister 40, Wirtz 54, Isak 89); Manchester United 4 (Fernandes 16-pen, Tielemans 44, Zirkzee 90+2, Dorgu 90+6) drew with Aston Villa 4 (Alysson 1, Jackson 4, McGinn 48-pen, Goretzka 53); Sunderland 1 (Le Fee 36-pen) bt Chelsea 0.
LaLiga: Atletico Madrid 1 (Simeone 10) lost to Barcelona 2 (Lopez 45, 66); Elche 0 lost to Real Betis 2 (Riquelme 81, Bartra 89).
Serie A: Inter Milan 2 (Esposito 12, Thurm 19) bt Como 0; Napoli 1 (Pedraza 48-og) drew with Lazio 1 (Frattesi 28).
On Saturday: Premier League: Nottingham Forest 3 (Cunha 6, Delap 18, 73) bt Manchester City 1 (Cherki 52).

Hamza guides Pakistan past India in under-19 Asia Cup

Hamza Zahoor struck an unbeaten century to guide Pakistan to a thrilling three-wicket victory over India in the ACC under-19 Asia Cup group match at Al Amerat on Sunday. Pakistan recovered from a precarious 61 for five to overhaul the target of 209 in 48.1 overs. Arjun Rajput's 107 went in vain.

The scores: India 208 in 46.3 overs (Arjun Rajput 107, Ali Raza 3/37, Niqab Shafiq 3/42) lost to Pakistan 209/7 in 48.1 overs (Hamza Zahoor 100 n.o.). **Toss:** India; **PoM:** Hamza.

Rain plays spoilsport on the third day of the final 'Test'

Persistent rain on Monday washed out the third day's play of the third and final 'Test' between India-A and New Zealand-A in Lincoln.

The scores: India-A 464/5 decl. in 146 overs (Jaiswal 102, Sai Sudharsan 88, Jurel 71, Tilak 81 n.o., Washington 50 n.o.) vs NZ-A 36/2 in 14 overs.

LIVE TELECAST

New Zealand vs. India: Third ODI, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 7.30 a.m.
Pakistan vs. Sri Lanka: First Test, Day 2, VETO App, 9.30 a.m.

Linette comes from behind, bags fourth Tour-level title

The Pole defeats reigning champion Tjen, enjoys the perfect finish to a tournament she wasn't too keen on competing in; Karamoko and Waltert beat Vaishnavi and Rutuja to win the doubles event

WTA CHENNAI OPEN

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI



Bringing cheer: Linette dedicated her victory to the victims of a mass shooting at Krakow. R. RAGU

Magda Linette wasn't too keen on playing the WTA 250 Chennai Open after a round-of-16 loss in Guangzhou. But the decision had already been made by her team.

Linette, the third-seeded Pole, didn't have much to complain about in the end as she beat reigning champion Janice Tjen 5-7, 6-1, 6-4 in a thrilling final on Monday to claim her fourth Tour-level title.

The summit clash was originally scheduled for Sunday before being shifted to the reserve day due to rain and Deepavali fireworks-induced smog.

Amidst the cacophony of firecrackers bursting sporadically in the distance, the contest began at 11 a.m. with 600-odd spectators on the centre court at the SDAT Stadium and under a clear sky.

Costly error

The first set had been on a knife edge till World No. 68 Linette misjudged a loopy forehand from the top-seeded Indonesian.

Tjen, after wasting five, finally converted a break point with a forehand down the line to take a 6-5 lead before serving the 64-minute opener out.

Drop in level

However, her level dropped in the second essay – her first serve % dipped from 67 to 58 and she also made three double faults.

Linette, growing in confidence, broke her serve twice. Before the decider, the match had to be suspended for 10 minutes due to 'extreme weather conditions' with the temperature exceeding 30.1 degrees Celsius.

After falling behind early in the third set, Tjen hit a crosscourt backhand drop shot and an inside-out forehand to break back Linette in a marathon sixth game.

But the Pole restored her advantage immediately before losing just one point in her next two service games, sealing the victory in two hours and 43 minutes.

Linette dedicated her triumph to the victims of a mass shooting at Krakow in her home country.

"I just want to say that my heart and wishes are with all the victims and those who are hurt," she said.

Earlier, in the doubles final on Sunday, the Swiss pair of Naima Karamoko and Simona Waltert defeated the all-Indian duo of Vaishnavi Adkar and Rutuja Bhosale 6-2, 6-0.



To play or not? The scheduling didn't go down well with the players' camps. R. RAGU

Postponement of final sparks controversy

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI

The postponement of the WTA 250 Chennai Open singles final due to rain and fireworks-induced smog on Sunday evening sparked controversy over the organisers' handling of the situation.

The final, set for a 6:30 p.m. start, was delayed thrice due to rain. Once the rain relented for good, the organisers dried the centre court at the SDAT stadium and rescheduled the final at 9 p.m.

However, the smog caused by the Deepavali firecrackers had made the air quality hazardous and the match had to be shifted to 11 a.m. on Monday in which Poland's Magda Linette defeated Indonesia's Janice Tjen, the reigning champion, in three sets.

Christopher Bint, Tjen's coach, in an Instagram story late on Sunday night, claimed that the organisers wanted to conduct the final despite the extremely poor air quality. "And they still wanted the match to go ahead," he wrote, attaching a screenshot showing an AQI of 1556 in Chennai. Later, after Monday's summit clash, Bint said, "Maybe, it could have just been postponed a little bit earlier."

Linette felt the doubles final, which started at 4 p.m. on Sunday, could have been moved forward. "We should have put the doubles final way earlier which would have given us a lot of time," said the 34-year-old Pole.

Hiten Joshi, the tournament director, said, "In these emergencies, the tournament supervisor (Sheetal Iyer) has to get permission from the WTA. So, they were going back and forth, and she also wanted to wait to see if any play was possible."

Norris wins a wet race; Mercedes takes the constructors' crown

FORMULA ONE

Associated Press
SAO PAULO



Norris... unstoppable. REUTERS

McLaren driver Lando Norris was so excited after winning Sunday's rainy Sao Paulo Grand Prix at Interlagos that his usual champagne celebration went awry, while Mercedes had another weekend to remember after securing its ninth F1 constructors' title.

Norris, the 2025 Formula 1 champion, won from pole position with the Red Bulls of Max Verstappen and Isack Hadjar completing the podium.

Norris had his second consecutive victory in Brazil after a race he led for 47 of 71 laps, with Brazil soccer great Neymar waving the checkered flag. The British driver briefly lost the lead to new F1 champion Kimi Antonelli, but got it back after the Italian spun.

Mercedes celebrated the constructors' title on a separate podium. It now has 652 points against Ferrari's 510 and can't be caught.

The results (top-10): 1. Lando Norris (Mercedes) 1h 35m 23.504s, 2. Max Verstappen (Red Bull) +14.602s, 3. Isack Hadjar (Red Bull) +24.485, 4. George Russell (Mercedes) +33.991, 5. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) +36.017, 6. Oscar Piastri (McLaren) +56.475, 7. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari) +1:13.585, 8. Liam Lawson (Racing Bulls) +1:15.402, 9. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) +1 lap, 10. Nico Hulkenberg (Audi) +1 lap.
Standings (top-5): Drivers: 1. Antonelli (390 points), 2. Verstappen (279), 3. Russell (262), 4. Hamilton (261), 5. Leclerc (251).
Constructors: 1. Mercedes (652), 2. Ferrari (512), 3. Red Bull (415), 4. McLaren (398), 5. Racing Bulls (112).

How Pegu bounced back from a near miss to clinch bronze

YOUTH OLYMPICS

Neha Surana

Tirthank Pegu is making waves at the Youth Olympic Games.

The 17-year-old from Assam became the first Indian male swimmer to win a medal at the Youth Games after finishing third in the 200m butterfly event in Dakar, Senegal. Pegu clocked 2:01.25 in the final after qualifying as the fastest swimmer from the heats. The bronze came after he narrowly missed out on a medal in 100m, where he was fourth in 54.98 seconds, just 0.27 seconds behind the last podium finisher. The miss initially left Pegu all jittery ahead of the 200m butterfly race, but the desire to clinch a medal kept him going.



Pegu.

"I was really nervous and not so confident because of the result in 100m. I was worried, 'what if I disappoint my coach, Sandeep [Sejwal] sir, and everybody?' During the race, I was just thinking about winning a medal," Pegu, an Inspire Institute of Sport athlete, said.

Having achieved his objective, Pegu is delighted. "It was my dream to win a medal at the Youth Olympics. My coach and I worked for this particular competition the whole year. So I am feeling really good right now," he said.

Pegu, who took up swimming at the age of four, has set his sights on becoming the first Indian swimmer to reach an Olympic final. "My main goal is to qualify for the final in the Olympics. I have been wishing for this from a very young age".

SLK: Calicut gets the better of Kombans, books semifinal spot

M.R. Praveen Chandran
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM



Opening salvo: Maximiliano converted a penalty for Calicut in the third minute. A. JAYAMOHAN

Table-topper Calicut FC punched its ticket for the semifinals of the Super League Kerala (SLK) after scoring a 2-1 win over Thiruvananthapuram Kombans in a seventh-round match at the Chandrasekharan Nair Stadium here on Sunday.

Calicut FC, after its fifth win, took its point tally to 17. It extended its lead at the top to four points over second-placed Forca Kochi, while Thiruvananthapuram Kombans stayed fourth with eight points.

Komabans conceded an early penalty when goalkeeper Satyajit Bordoloi fouled Calicut captain Prasanth inside the box. Argentine Maximiliano Nicolas converted the spot kick to put the visitor ahead in the third minute.

Calicut completely dominated the first half, moving the ball through both flanks to create chances. Had Maximiliano and Leonardo David been a little more sharper with their finishing, Calicut could have sealed the contest in the opening half itself.

Kombans had just one chance in the first half but a lumbering Joao Paredes skied the ball over an open goal. A heavy downpour slowed the game at the half-hour mark before it relented at the start of the second half.

Calicut doubled the lead when Maximiliano and Leonardo exchanged passes before the former provided the perfect pass for the latter to score in the 51st minute. Paredes wasted a chance for Kombans on the hour mark. Substitute K. Sreeraj pulled one back for Kombans in the 82nd but Calicut held on.

The result: Thiruvananthapuram Kombans FC 1 (K. Sreeraj 82) lost to Calicut FC 2 (Maximiliano Nicolas 3-pen, Leonardo David 51).

Sanjay to lead Indian hockey team on New Zealand tour

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Olympic bronze medallist Sanjay will lead a young Indian men's hockey team on a three-match tour of New Zealand from November 15 to 23, marking 100 years of sporting ties between the two countries.

India will take on the hosts on November 19, 21 and 22 at the Lloyd Elsmore Hockey Stadium in Auckland.

The tour commemorates the historic 1926 visit of an Indian Army hockey team.

The squad:

Goalkeepers: Mohith H.S., Pawan; **defenders:** Sanjay, Nilam Sanjeep Xess, Shardanand Tiwari, Talem Priyobarta, Anmol Ekka, Yashdeep Siwach; **midfielders:** Angad Bir Singh, Aditya Arjun Lalage, Rabichandra Singh, Vishnukant Singh, Manmeet Singh, Rosan Kujur, Venkatesh Kenche; **forwards:** Ajeet Yadav, Uttam Singh, Karthi Selvam, Arshdeep Singh, Araijeet Singh Hundal.

Suryakumar to lead Mumbai in Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

Suryakumar Yadav will return to lead Mumbai in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, marking his comeback to the domestic circuit after missing the Ranji Trophy.

Suryakumar, who was not part of Mumbai's red-ball campaign, will take charge of the side in the tournament, beginning in Kolkata on November 14.

"It is a matter of immense pride to represent Mumbai.

"I am honoured to lead this talented group. Mumbai has a rich cricketing legacy and a winning culture, and we will look to uphold those traditions," Suryakumar said.

His appointment comes in the absence of red-ball captain Siddhesh Lad, who will skip the tournament. Tanush Kotian and Suryansh Shedge will also be unavailable as they are part of the India-A squad for the Rising Stars Asia Cup.



Suryakumar.
FILE PHOTO: M. PERIASAMY

"We have a good mix of experienced players and exciting young talent, and I am confident that the team will come together and play with intensity," Suryakumar added.

The squad includes several established names like Shardul Thakur, Shivam Dube, Sarfaraz Khan and Tushar Deshpande. Musheer Khan and Angkrish Raghuvanshi add to the batting options, while Shams Mulani, Mohit Avasthi and Atharva Ankolekar provide further depth.

Shardul had missed Mumbai's Ranji Trophy campaign due to injury.

Suryakumar, meanwhile, will look to make the most of the opportunity to lead Mumbai, having been out of India reckoning since captaining the country to the T20 World Cup title in March.

The squad:

Suryakumar Yadav (Capt.), Shardul Thakur, Shivam Dube, Sarfaraz Khan, Musheer Khan, Tushar Deshpande, Angkrish Raghuvanshi, Shams Mulani, Divyaansh Saxena, Mohit Avasthi, Hardik Tamore (wk), Sylvester D'Souza, Atharva Ankolekar, Maxwell Swaminathan, Suved Parkar, and Sairaj Patil.

The squad includes several established names like Shardul Thakur, Shivam Dube, Sarfaraz Khan and Tushar Deshpande Shardul had missed Mumbai's Ranji Trophy campaign due to injury

Khawaja's claims 100% accurate, says Warner

Agence France-Presse
SYDNEY

David Warner backed former teammate Usman Khawaja's claims that the entire Australian team was in on the 2018 'sandpapergate' scandal, describing them as "100% accurate".

Warner, one of three players banned over the ball-tampering controversy in Cape Town along with Steve Smith and Cameron Bancroft, said he stood "with my brother" Khawaja. "It has been eight years since I spoke on this topic," the 40-year-old said in a video. "Uzzie, I throw my full support behind you. I thank you for what you have done. It is 100% accurate what you have said. Now everyone knows the truth. It is out there. People wanted to know it. You have come out and said it," Warner added.

Khawaja had re-ignited the infamous incident on Saturday ahead of the release of his autobiography.

Gurnoor — the X-factor in India's bowling cartel

Shubman Gill has made no secret of his desire to have extra pace at his disposal to force the issue in the meandering middle overs. India can't afford to be conservative in using Gurnoor in the lead-up to the mega event because he will only get better, more tactically astute and suave once he has more overs in his legs in the pressure-cooker situation of an international contest



CREIMAS/ BCCI

R. Kaushik
HAMILTON

Nothing sets the pulse racing more than watching a tearaway pace bowler in action. A long, never-ending run-up, an explosive build-up of momentum, the bowling crease attacked with ferocity, sometimes with a leap, culminates in the little orb being propelled at the rate of knots through a combination of shoulder and wrist and snappy fingers.

For long periods, India have yearned for a speed merchant, someone who can rattle opposition batting line-ups with naked, raw, untamed pace. It is said that Mohammad Nissar, who played in India's first Test against England at Lord's in June 1932, was frightfully pacy and deadly accurate. On India's first day as a Test nation, he sent the stumps of openers Percy Holmes and Herbert Sutcliffe flying for six and three respectively, reducing the hosts to 11 for two.

Just 10 days previously, Holmes and Sutcliffe had put on a world record 555 for Yorkshire against Essex in the English County Championship. Nissar gave them a reality check and even though England recovered to post a 158-run victory, Nissar and his new-ball partner Amar Singh had given the home side a proper scare.

Nissar, the first Indian with a five-wicket haul in Test cricket (five for 93 in the first innings), finished with six wickets for the match. His Test career lasted a little over four years and six games, and he signed off with 25 wickets, taking a wicket every eight overs.

Batters and spin bowlers can be held back and tested over a year, at the very least, to allow them to learn from their mistakes and grow organically, but it makes little sense to rein in a pace machine

Nissar an outlier

In some ways, Nissar was an outlier because soon, India became the unquestioned land of high-quality spin. A plethora of the craft of exceptional deception kept the Indian spin flag flying until the feared quartet of Bishan Bedi, Erapalli Prasanna, B.S. Chandrasekhar and S Venkataraghavan combined to herald the golden era of Indian spin. Over time, several other wonderful spinners emerged; Dilip Doshi and Shivlal Yadav did their bit to buttress the reputation of Indian spin, while Anil Kumble, Harbhajan Singh and R.Ashwin pushed it to exalted heights.

While India were blessed with such great tweakers and celebrated them with the pride that they commanded, there was always a lacuna so far as pace bowling was concerned. Ramakant Desai and Pandurang Salgaonkar promised briefly, but it wasn't until Kapil Dev arrived in 1978 that fast bowling received a genuine fillip. Kapil's emergence was followed almost immediately by live television from England and Australia, and finally being able to see a role model 'live', if not in flesh and blood, served to inspire successive generations of fast bowlers.

Kapil quickly realised, with help from well-meaning quarters, that it would be impossible for him to have a long career if he continued to bowl as fast as he could. Given that he would play, roughly, half his Test matches on unresponsive Indian tracks, it made sense for him to sacrifice pace and enhance other aspects of his bowling, most notably swing. But he had done enough before he dropped pace to inspire others into bowling fast, not least the gangling engineer from Mysuru, Javagal Srinath.

The Srinath case

Tall and thin, Srinath was all arms and legs but blessed with the ability to procure steepling bounce from a length and to bring the ball late and wickedly into the right-hander. It was a bit of a shame that for the first few years of his international career, when he was in the genuinely 'express' category, Srinath had to warm the bench because team dynamics dictated the presence of all-rounders - in this case, Kapil and Manoj Prabhakar, who doubled up as opening batter and new-ball bowler. That didn't stop Srinath from picking up an impressive 236 Test wickets and 315 sticks in One-Day Internationals, without dropping pace, not even after he had to undergo shoulder surgery in 2001 for a rotator cuff injury.

Ajit Agarkar, slight of build but with a big heart and a wonderfully fluid action, could crank up the speed gun, effortlessly delivering at more than 140 kmph, and Zaheer Khan was in the same pace bracket at the start of his career, while speeds of 150 kmph were wrongly attributed to Munaf Patel even before he made his international debut or before he was officially measured in a formal match setting.

While India were flush with spin riches, they occasionally cast baleful eyes towards the north-west and Pakistan, who somehow unearthed an assembly line of quicks. Several of them faded away as meteorically as they climbed the summit, while others like Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis and Shoaib Akhtar ruled the roost in the modern era for extended periods. India envied Pakistan their pace battery, while Pakistan were enamoured by India's spin depth. Oh, for a Waqar, Indian cricket cried.

Their prayers have been somewhat answered in recent times, though neither Umran Malik nor Mayank Yadav, the two fastest bowlers in the last few years, has contributed a great deal. Malik has spent more time off the field than on it while Mayank too has already had his fair share of dalliances with injuries, a fast bowler's constant companion and an inevitable occupational hazard.

Batters and spin bowlers can be held back and tested over a year, at the very least, to allow them to learn from their mistakes and grow organically, but it makes little sense to rein in a pace machine. Provided they showcase reasonable control, it is best to unleash them when they are fresh and raw. Having learnt their lessons with Malik, and to a lesser extent with Mayank, India haven't wasted much time in letting Gurnoor Brar loose. The results are there for everyone to see.

Gurnoor ticks every box required of a fast bowler. He is very tall - standing six-foot-five in his socks - and is powerfully built without looking intimidatingly buffed. He is unafraid of running in hard and letting the ball rip, makes excellent use of his height and doesn't commit the very cardinal error of trying to bang every ball in. His natural length might seem to be a bit on the shorter side, but he does get the ball up in uncomfortable (for batters) areas, almost drawing them forward but also ensuring that they are wary of the ball suddenly getting big on them. He has natural aggression, is in the batters' ears without crossing the line, and knows that he isn't a restrictive option but an attacking one and therefore doesn't place a premium on economy.

He has had an interesting start to his international career, which is only 11 ODIs young since his debut against Afghanistan in Dharamshala in June. In his very first appearance, in the altitude of the hills, he turned in a terrific spell of fast bowling, finishing with three for 27 in 4.5 overs in a tall-scoring 25-overs-a-side contest. Twice in his short journey, he has gone for nearly 100 runs in his ten overs - none for 97 against England at Lord's and two for 96 against West Indies in Guwahati - but only twice also in his 11 bowls has he gone without taking a wicket. He has taken two or more wickets seven times and racked up career-best figures of four for 30 in Wellington the other night, the second-best figures by an Indian fast bowler in an ODI in New Zealand behind Srinath's four for 23 in Auckland in 2003.

Gurnoor is proving to be a worthy successor to the Mysore Express, leaving nothing behind in the dugout as he gives the batters a serious working over. What has been impressive so far on this tour of New Zealand is his propensity to keep his wits about him. Nothing excites any fast bowler, and an Indian fast bowler at that, more than help from the surface. Both at Auckland's Eden Park and at the Hnry Stadium in Wellington, Gurnoor and the other fast bowlers have been encouraged by prodigious lateral movement but also bounce - trampoline-like in Wellington, as crack New Zealand batter Daryl Mitchell termed it - and still, he has been able to resist the temptation of bowling short and trying to rattle the batters through bounce alone.

Shubman Gill, like Gurnoor also from Punjab, has made no secret of his desire to have extra pace at his disposal to force the issue in the meandering middle overs when bowling sides generally go through the motions. With that in mind, the Indian captain has used Gurnoor as a second-change option in this series, behind new-ball operators Arshdeep Singh and Auqib Nabi, and Anshul Kamboj, in what is definitely not India's first-string attack by choice. All of these names are auditioning for the 50-over World Cup in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia next October-November and more than anyone else, Gurnoor's progress is being followed keenly because of the X-Factor that he brings with him.

As things stand, the 26-year-old has stolen an early march in the race to a place in the World Cup 15. Obviously, Jasprit Bumrah is a shoo-in, and Prasidh Krishna isn't far behind in the pecking order provided he remains fit. Mohammed Siraj is an experienced campaigner though one isn't sure whether he figures prominently in the scheme of things, given how sporadic his ODI appearances have been in recent times. All-rounders Hardik Pandya and Nitish Kumar, when available, are near certainties given the depth and firepower they lend the batting group.

Against this backdrop, Gurnoor's progress has been little short of encouraging. It is expected that pitches in South Africa will reasonably mirror those on offer in New Zealand, perhaps without the excessive seam movement, and if Gurnoor can string together another couple of impressive performances, he will go right to the top of the list among the chasing pack, if he isn't already there. India, however, can't afford to be conservative in using him in the lead-up to the mega event because Gurnoor will only get better and more tactically astute and suave once he has more overs in his legs in the pressure-cooker situation of an international contest. That's where the challenge lies — in ensuring that he is a more rounded, experienced and dangerous version of his current self without running him into the ground, but also without wrapping him in cotton wool because unless he bowls more, his evolution along expected lines will not transpire.

Gurnoor couldn't have asked for a more qualified individual to work with and under than bowling coach Morne Morkel, the former South African speedster. In some ways, Gurnoor is not unlike Morkel when the latter first burst through, so it is fair to assume that the Protean is in the perfect position to optimise the potential for damage that Gurnoor possesses.

THE GIST

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As things stand, the 26-year-old has stolen an early march in the race to a place in the World Cup 15 to be held in the Africas next year

Gurnoor ticks every box required of a fast bowler. He is very tall — standing six-foot-five in his socks — and is powerfully built without looking intimidatingly buffed